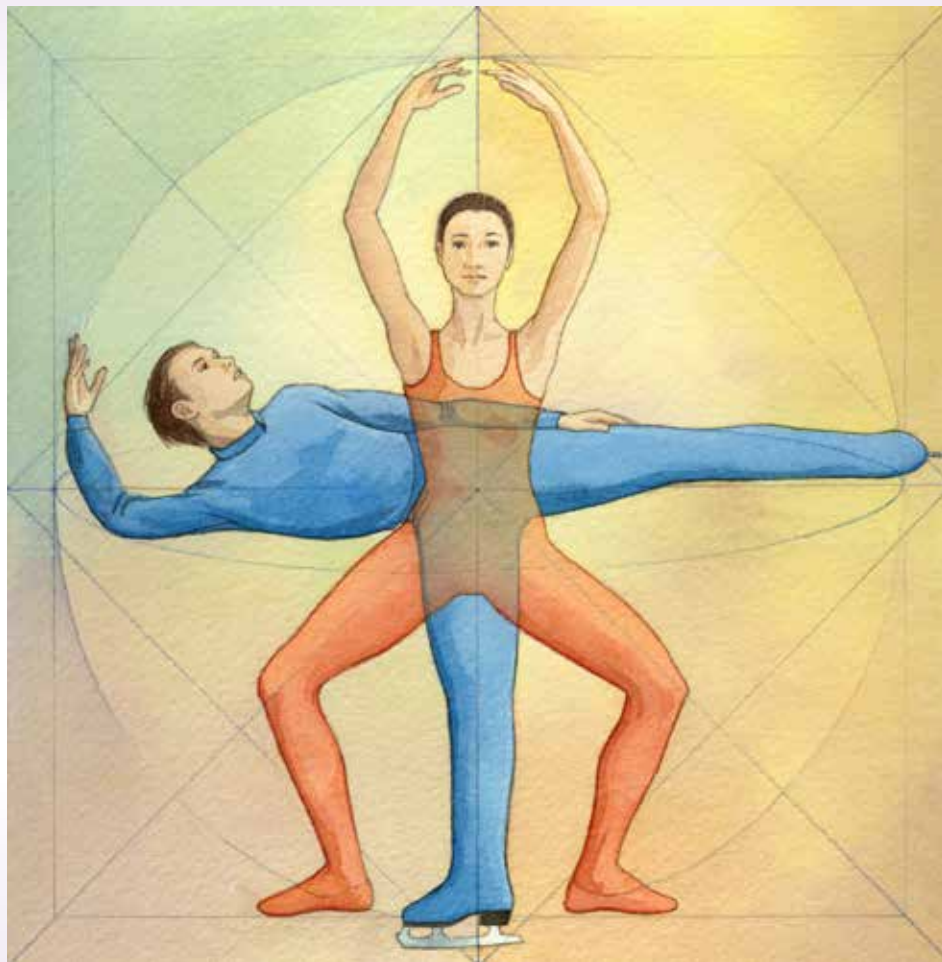


BALLET FOR FIGURE SKATERS MANUAL FOR COACHES

*A science based, unified off to on-ice approach
to teaching the art and sport of figure skating*



By Annette T. Thomas

Edited by Madeline Lydia Stammen

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FOR MY STUDENTS

“When One Teaches, Two Learn”

- *Robert Heinlein*

INTRODUCTION

This manual, and the supplemental books and video, should be approached as a “mini degree” in how to teach movement training, specifically classical ballet methodology to figure skaters, in order to enhance body awareness and skating technique as well as prevent injuries. There is a significant amount of study on anatomy, physiology, kinesiology, body awareness, music theory and specific movement training methodology involved, which, when applied correctly, will enable the teacher/coach to train each individual student into the very best skaters they can be.

The primary focus of this course is understanding and applying Vaganova Methodology (pedagogy) to figure skaters, including the specific use and value of the exercises. In order to know what to look for in each of your students and help them to improve in a meaningful and progressive manner, actual study must be done on precise, scientific methodology, not merely on choreography. This means you must become so familiar with the material given that you are able to correlate, synthesize and APPLY all the material herein.

The premise of the Vaganova Ballet Teaching and Training Method is similar to the approach of physical therapy for sports medicine – each exercise is designed scientifically and is to be precisely executed in order to strengthen, stretch, balance, align or form the body in very biomechanically precise ways. Think of the Method more as “prevention”, as it anticipates all future possibilities or problems within an individual, which automatically prevents injury. The exercises contained in the manual are PROGRESSIVE in that one must approach each exercise and each section of study as building upon the last so that a real method of training evolves within the mind and understanding of the reader. This cohesive Methodology is what makes this course so valuable and unlike any other.

It is my hope that you find this course to be not only informative, but inspirational. May it revolutionize your concepts of what teaching and training can be.

Best Always,
Annette T. Thomas

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Page

Materials and assignment in preparation for Lesson One

6

THEORY AND HISTORY

Lesson 1- A Brief history of ballet methods and styles. Deconstructing perceptions of what classical ballet is. The development of the Vaganova Method, and its practical applications to figure skating. “Sport vs. Art” mentality and why the two mind sets can clash – results oriented vs. process oriented **8**

Lesson 2 – Reconstructing our approach to ballet teaching and training. The importance of “placement” - Injury prevention and developing a culture of an effective “unified teaching method”. The “7 ways of Learning” understanding the differences between a teacher and a trainer; The 8 elements of movement training. **13**

THE FOUNDATIONS

Lessons 3 – Anatomy and physiology: Understanding the crucial role of Myofascial Massage in body work preparation and setting a solid foundation for whole body warm up practices and injury prevention. **16**

Lessons 4 – I Resistance band exercises. Learning 12 Vaganova based Floor-Barre exercises - the foundations of all stabilizer movement **18**

Lesson 5 - Introduction to beginning Vaganova ballet technique for the figure skater: terminology, understanding music (tempos, time signatures, and how to count exercises). “The 7 Steps Toward Becoming a Master Teacher” and how to make lesson plans for all ages and the crucial role of wholistic cuing. **23**

PRACTICE AND APPLICATION (PRAXIS)

BALLET SYLLABUS

Lessons 6 - 11 – Ballet Syllabus methodology and pedagogy: Beginning barre, center barre, carriage of the arms, jumps and turns. **30**

SKATES ON - SPECIALTY

Lesson 12 - Beginning “Skates On” Off-ice Specialty class **57**

ON - ICE BALLET

Lessons 13 – Beginning on-Ice Ballet Classes - mine as well as how to create your own based on the information learned. **66**

Appendix Materials:

Becoming the Music	76
The Value of Studying Pedagogy	77
Why ballet Specifically Geared for Figure Skaters is the best Choice	81
What Makes teaching/Learning Classical ballet Different	86
The Importance of Warming Up	91
The Seven Rules of S-t-r-e-t-c-h-i-n-g	93
Progression of Mind-Body Connection Skills	95
Student Physical Assessments	97
The 12 preliminary Vaganova Floor Exercises	98
The 7 Steps Toward becoming a “Master Teacher” and the Art of Cueing	105
Ballet Lesson Syllabus	109
Lessons in Ballet for Figure Skaters Level 1 Video Booklet	111
Example of Correlative Chart	129
On-Ice Diagram #1 (consecutive 3 turns using 2nd port de bras)	130
On-Ice Diagram #2 (continuous flow of port de bras & skating elements using the whole sheet of ice	131

Pre-Assignment Instructions for Lesson One

1. Gather the materials from the list below.

Reference Materials outside this Manual:

- BOOK: "Fundamentals of Alignment and Classical Movement for Figure Skaters" - by Annette T. Thomas
- BOOK: "Lessons in Classical ballet for the Figure Skater" – by Annette T. Thomas
- OPTIONAL BOOK: "Technical Manual and Dictionary of Classical Ballet" – by Gail Grant
- OPTIONAL BOOK: "Foundations of Classical Ballet" - complete and unabridged translation of the 3rd edition by Agrippina Vaganova
- INSTRUCTIONAL VIDEO: "Lessons in Ballet for Figure Skaters" by Annette T. Thomas
- 6" wide X 5' long Resistance band
- Journal for reflections
- MUSIC: "Ballet Class Music for the Figure Skater" – available at: Whitefeatherproductions.com

2. Read the material below.

- "The Value of Studying Pedagogy" – page 77 in this Manual
- "Why Ballet Specifically Geared to Figure Skaters is the Best Choice" – page 81 in this manual
- "What Makes Teaching/Learning Classical Ballet Different?" - page 86 in this manual.
- The "Introduction", all of Chapter 1, and pages 5-3 through 5-8 in my "Fundamentals" Book for reflection and perceptions of what classical ballet is, what pedagogy is, and what your personal goals are in taking this course.
- The "Forward" through page 30, and index pages xiii through xviii in my "Lessons" Book.
- "Foundations of Classical Ballet" - Agrippina Vaganova pages 11 - 49

3. Read the Syllabus Overview

Syllabus Overview and Goals

- a.** You will learn methodology as “Fine Art.” It is PROCESS oriented, as is science, in contrast to “results oriented,” which tends to be the case in sports training. You will learn to integrate science and somatics for effective injury preventative training.
- b.** You will learn to teach off and on-ice movements biomechanically as opposed to teaching visually (Progression of Mind-Body Connection Skills – page 95), and the Correlative Chart (page 129) in this manual.
- c.** You will learn to understand and practice teaching by CUIING verbally and physically from the inside out using placement, not choreography. You will teach from floor, to barre, to centre, and then to ice by seeing *‘through the body’* and by knowing how best to reach each student effectively. (The Art of Effective Cueing” page 107)
- d.** You will learn how to embody the full scope of the methodology and then impart it to your student(s) in a “unified and biomechanically sound manner” vs. merely creating “class content”, which means staying just a few lessons ahead of your student and/or focusing on only one aspect of the body. (The 7 Steps Toward becoming a Master Teacher – page 105) all in this manual.

Lesson 1

Lesson 1 Agenda

In this lesson, we will focus on the deconstruction of what ballet is by getting rid of false preconceptions and reimplementing understanding based on *true* methodology, theory and purpose.

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

- A - The difference between a method and a style
- B - The three methods of classical ballet
- C - Three styles of classical ballet
- D - The difference between ballet pedagogy and choreography / syllabus

Reflection on the reading assignment:

Pull out your journal and write a reflection on your reading assignment. What surprised and interested you most? What was new to you? How did it change your perceptions of teaching classical ballet?

Lesson 1 Lecture

A Brief History of Ballet

1-) Classical Ballet Methods vs. “Styles”:

Method refers to a specific progression of forms of each exercise which are based on understanding the biomechanics of the body, temperament and capabilities at each age level required in order to create an artist in the most complete and efficient way possible without risking injury. Methodology is based on the biomechanics of each movement and how it should be applied through time according to the abilities of each student. This involves scientific placement, progression and formation “from the inside of the body out”. Most individuals, schools and organizations merely teach a syllabus, NOT the methodology behind the syllabus.

“Art and Science have their meeting point in Method” Edward G. Bulwer-Lytton

Style refers to the outward appearance, choreography, musicality and emotional “feel” of an exercise.

****NOTE:** By necessity, the proceeding section has been greatly condensed to give the student a brief idea of the timeline, influences and ensuing outcomes of what we call “Classical Dance” today.

There are Three Main Methods of Classical Ballet:

French Method: “Paris Opera Ballet” – Begun in part by King Louis the 14th (1643-1715) through the earlier influences of Catherine de Medici, and several ballet masters of the Baroque era that were primarily interested in promoting ballet as “an art of harmonious royal and aristocratic spectacle.” The French were the first to develop ballet (which at that point in history just meant court dances) as an art form, and, in some ways, one can still see remnants of its roots in court dancing, at times displaying overly “plastic” (soft), reserved and elegant lines but often superfluous movements. It is important to understand that different cultures consider “beauty” or “perfection” in different ways. These “ballets” were created as both full length stories as well as displays during the “entre acts” of operas. It became a true codified method under both NOVERRE (1727-1810) and Marius Petipa (1818 – 1910) who are considered the fathers of what we today call Classical Ballet.

Italian Method: “Cecchetti Method” (Enrico Cecchetti 1850 - 1928) This method focuses on strong jumpers and dynamic, quick movement, but is not very fluid and can tend to create bulky muscles. The flow of arms is not a central priority, and therefore not as much attention is given to the details of movement within classical lines of finger groupings or head/eye gaze positions (Épaulement). *Again, we are speaking here of a specific cultural aesthetic not an absolute.

Cecchetti was highly influenced by the Italian dance teacher and theoretician Carlo Blasis (1797 – 1878), who wrote the book “The Code of Terpsichore”. Blasis based his theories of movement on mathematics, specifically geometry and how poses of the body are related to space. Cecchetti taught at the Russian Imperial Ballet school, as well as being Ballet Master to the dancers of the two companies known as The Ballet Russes, so his influence was greatly felt by the Russian school. This is also why we in the West are more familiar with his work as The Ballet Russes and The Ballet Russe de Monte-Carlo traveled extensively in the “New World” from as early as 1910 through 1968. Vaganova was very interested in Cecchetti’s work but having already graduated from her studies was unable to study with him directly. After her graduation, she was taught Cecchetti’s method by his best student Olga Preobrajenska (1871-1962).

Russian Method: The Vaganova Choreographic School, originally known as the “Russian Imperial Ballet,” was refined and codified into a scientific methodology by Agrippina Y. Vaganova (1879 to 1951) and is now called the Vaganova Method. It is used by both the Bolshoi Ballet and Mariinsky Ballet (formerly known as the “Kirov”). Vaganova took what she felt were the best qualities of both the French (having been taught primarily by the French born ballet pedagogue and choreographer Marius Petipa 1818 - 1910) and the Italian method and then added a distinctively Russian cultural bent. This meant she developed the importance of portraying dynamic and distinctive personas within the repertoire of steps as both drama and fine art. Vaganova scientifically “reverse engineered” the entire teaching and learning process from the desired end result, with the hardest jumps and tours, to the most fundamental techniques needed to be learned from day one. To do this, she broke the process down into the most minute detail and spread it out over an 8-year study period. Vaganova

wanted to solve the problem of “how do we get this child at age 10 to master the steps in the repertoire with the greatest consistency, musicality and expression, without injury, by age 18?” The answer was the Vaganova Method and this is the method you will learn in this course.

There are three* main styles of classical ballet:

English Style – Royal Ballet & Royal Academy of Dance (RAD) – A combination of the French, Russian and Italian schools was originally described as “Operatic Dance” as in England “Classical” meant Greek. Founded dually by Edouard Espinoza (1872–1950) and Ninette de Valois (Edris Stannus 1898-2001) who was an English Irish dancer who studied with Cecchetti and Legat (another Russian offshoot) and danced briefly with the Ballet Russes.

Balanchine Style – Created by George Balanchine (1929-1983), it is an offshoot of the Russian Method. Balanchine, a dancer and choreographer, defected to America and founded the School of American Ballet and New York City Ballet (along with Lincoln Kirstein) with his unique style, which is quick, stark, and almost ahead of the beat. Bodies are instruments, with the head facing front and open hips in arabesque.

Bournonville Style – August Bournonville (1805 – 1879) Creator of the Danish style (Royal Danish Ballet). It is rooted in the culture of Danish Country life but based primarily in the French Method. It is very light with lots of petit and medium allegro with diagonal torso epaulement and minimal arms - Distinctively charming.

*There are many “sub-styles” and offshoots of methodologies, which can be confusing. Choreographers create their own styles based on the approaches they studied to suit their personal expression and “voice”.

Styles are always offshoots of the particular choreographers’ dance background, and used as a “toolbox” for movement, not taught with the detail or scientific rigor of movement training from a pedagogical standpoint.

The above is extremely important to acknowledge as the majority of skaters and coaches believe that ALL dance is merely a STYLE, only important to skating as an add-on to elegance and expression, not as an actual technical assist to their training methods. We want to dispel that mind set! We need to create awareness that REAL ballet training is a scientific method important to ALL aspects of skating, both technical and artistic.

2-) What is Ballet Pedagogy?

Definitions of Pedagogy: From the Greek “Leading Children”

“The act, process and art of imparting knowledge. The art and science of instructional methodology. The academic discipline that deals with the theory and practice of teaching and how these influence student learning.”

Pedagogy provides the building blocks for true training “from the inside out”, not merely the choreography (appearance) of the movement. It takes into account the entire progression of the dancer/artist through every point of their development—mentally, physically and emotionally—in a comprehensive, methodical manner.

Pedagogy courses demonstrate that teaching ballet is not just about teaching choreographic pieces of “end form” exercises slowed down, but that there is an entire progression of “forms” which lead up to the ending form of each and every step in the classical ballet repertoire. It is the difference between “taking a class,” where the teacher assumes much and fixes later, and “having a lesson,” where the teacher knows their students’ level of comprehension and physical ability and prepares progressive lesson plans in accordance with the methodology in light of their needs.

What we’re going to do here is not about choreography or “grace” or “fixing arms and hands”, but an all-encompassing methodical teaching program that leads up to a fine art...like the Vaganova teacher who often has only one class for each of the 8 levels (normally 12 – 15 students/disciples in a class), we are forming and creating a “work of art”. Each of your students and each of your group of students (your class) is a work of art, YOUR work art!

All true ballet pedagogy courses do the same thing:

- You learn HOW to break down the steps and tempos into their most basic parts
- You learn WHAT to look for on each student, to help ensure that progress at the proper rate for the individual is maintained without risk of injury.
- You learn WHEN to introduce a new step/exercise or tempo.
- You learn WHAT each step/exercise specifically builds within the body.
- You learn to CUE accurately - precisely verbalizing the intent and import of each step to your students and PLACING them accordingly. This is intellectually **not** visually imparted education or the “follow what I do” mentality.
- You learn HOW to create lesson plans based on the syllabus, and how to take notes to improve, progress or change the day’s lesson depending on the student’s progress.
- You are taught to understand classical dance as a “Unified Method”, transitioning from; floor to barre to centre, to pas de deux, with artistry and intelligence integrated from the very first lesson.

Homework for Lesson 2:

- ❖ If you haven't finished the required reading for the first lesson, please do so and answer ALL of the Workbook questions for Chapter One in the "Fundamentals" book; The Teaching vs. Training (Pages 1-7 and 1-8) and the 8 elements of movement technique etc.
- ❖ READ: The Progression of Mind-Body Connection Skills – page 95 in this manual.
- ❖ READ: Chapter 2 of the Fundamentals book to familiarize yourself with the material and concepts presented - particularly the section on Myofascia: pages 2-33 through 2-41. Answer all of the questions in the various sections of Chapter 2 and reflect on how you as a teacher/coach have (or have not) been incorporating these concepts into your teaching.

Lesson 2

Lesson 2 Agenda: In this lesson we will focus on continued theory and the reconstruction of what classical ballet training is (or should be). I will emphasize the importance of placement, injury prevention and developing a culture of an effective “unified teaching method.” We will cover “The 7 Ways of Learning,” the differences between a teacher and a trainer, and how they each affect learning outcomes. We will also cover “The 8 Elements of Movement Training.”

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

- A - The difference between teaching by scientific placement of the body and choreographic (appearance guided) instruction.
- B - How a unified method of training (off to on-ice) is essential to the mind body connection and injury prevention.
- C - Whether you are more of a teacher or a trainer, and what you need to work on in order to reach more learning styles effectively.
- D - How the 8 essential elements of movement training should be incorporated into your everyday teaching (lesson plans and cuing).
- E – The importance of how awareness of anatomy and physiology should influence every exercise you teach.
- F - The difference between a warm up and a stretch, as well as the role of Myofascia in injury prevention.

Reflection on the reading assignment

Pull out your journal and answer the following questions.

- ❖ What is the difference between a Method and a Style of Ballet (name them)?
- ❖ Why/How is Vaganova Methodology & Pedagogy most closely related to the needs of figure skaters?
- ❖ Review any thoughts & questions in chapter 1, as well as questions on pages 1-7 & 1-8 --- Are you more of a teacher or a trainer, and why?
- ❖ How we learn is usually how we teach, but how your students learn should determine how you teach. How could you be more flexible in your teaching style in order to accommodate the 7 ways of learning?
- ❖ Reflect on the 8 Essential Elements of Movement Technique. Do you feel that you use all 8 elements effectively in your teaching?
- ❖ You can create a journal to remind yourself to utilize more of these elements in your daily lesson plans. (Page 1-31 in the Fundamentals Books)

Lesson 2 Lecture

The importance of PLACEMENT and Injury Prevention – Developing a Culture of an Effective “Unified Teaching Method”

The Vaganova Method is all about Placement, NOT Choreography, so everything in the curriculum revolves around creating accurate placement. Accurate placement means science based whole-body alignment, and understanding the FEEL of classical line, stability, and core strength within the mind-body connection of the dancer before moving on to combinations and choreography. *You don't “fix” movement or poses based on how they look – you see through the body to build from the Musculo-skeletal foundation.*

This is why the entire Vaganova pre-ballet program as well as the first-year syllabus focuses on the entire core muscle complex.

Stabilizers not mobilizers - because you cannot successfully mobilize what isn't stable.

Loose Joints vs. Useable Flexibility (Page 3-25 in Fundamentals Book)

Dance instructors inevitably *love* to create very “dance-y” - emotion-based movements and exercises because it's “fun” and because it makes you feel like you are “already a dancer”. **This kind of “teaching” is using the mobilizer muscles before the stabilizers.** While it's fine for learning choreography, this type of teaching is not effective in creating strong, flexible, aware and versatile dancers/skaters.

“It's not about how many steps you know, it's about your placement within the steps”

When you practice accurate, hands-on teaching, you place the student - each bone and muscle, and ask them to describe the FEEL of correct placement—on the floor, facing the barre, one hand on the barre, in the centre of the room AND on the ice. The same movement correlated with the same feeling, will produce accurate muscle memory, not by looks, but by feel. This is also why accurate scientific CUING is so important. This also creates “smart movers” – meaning those who can self-correct and with fewer repetitions. “Working smarter not harder”, which leads to better results with fewer injuries.

Putting whole body placement before choreography ensures the least risk for injury and the greatest potential for artistry.

If a curriculum is based on choreography, or what things look like from the outside, you will be setting up an environment for future injury. Think of all the skaters who practice jumps away from the trained eye of the coach and just keep repeating bad form until their bodies give out and an injury occurs, or the coach who just keeps saying, “do it again” without any specific or further instruction going on. By focusing on specific

instruction and placement, you are creating more of a classroom setting on the ice, and while this may be a foreign feeling for some students, it is absolutely essential in order to create healthy athletes with the greatest potential for success.

❖ **Most injuries occur because of faulty teaching**

As teachers and coaches, we can teach the same exercise but get an *entirely* different outcome depending on our understanding of the movement and how we teach and cue it.

Biomechanical Placement & Injury Prevention
A reference and discussion on Chapter 2 of the “Fundamentals” book

Familiarize yourself with the following reading material. We will be referencing these concepts throughout the course.

- Training and “whole person” (somatic) concepts – pages 1-3 to 1-6
- Teaching “kinesthetic awareness” (cuing in the moment) to create smart “aware” dancers/athletes – read the “Did you know” section on page 2-4 and 2-5
- Growth spurts and training - page 2-8
- Q angle - page 2-10 (watch the rise from the plié!)
- “Eye spine Connection” - pages 2-5 (top of page), 2-14 and 2-37 (Eye spine connection exercise)
- Stabilizer muscles and Myofascia – Pages 2-31 through 2-39
- Locking vs. pulling up the knees – sickling of foot (balancing the peroneus with the tibialis anterior) - pages 2-16, 3-54 and 3-56
- Stretch reflex and stretching injuries Page 2-24
- The main Fulcrum of the body and why a 90° angle is the “magic number” - Page 2-28 (we are “stabilized” at this angle on a multiplanar level)
- Nervous system, breathing & sleep - pages 2-46 & 2-67
- Nutrition - page 2-56 and 2-57

Homework for Lesson 3:

- Re-Read Chapter 2 (esp. the above highlights)
- Read all of Chapter 4
- Answer all workbook question in Chapter 2 and 4 for personal reflection

Lesson 3

The Difference Between a Warm-up and a Stretch and Why This Distinction Is So Important

Lesson 3 Agenda: Anatomy and physiology: Understanding the crucial role of Myofascial Massage in body work preparation and setting a solid foundation for whole body warm up practices and injury prevention.

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A – Know the difference between a warm up and a stretch and when a warm up becomes a stretch (to increase ROM) for each of your students.

B - Why taking the body as a whole (connections, muscles, ligaments etc.) is imperative to progressive achievement and injury prevention.

C - How intentional breathing techniques will improve performance, stamina and mental focus.

D – How Myofascia plays a crucial/pivotal role in flexibility and injury prevention.

Reflection on the Reading Assignment

Pull out your journal and take notes on the following material.

- **Chapter 4 in the Fundamentals book** Warm-up vs. stretch - pages 4-3 through 4-13; 4-55 through 4-57 and 2-30 & 2-31

Lesson 3 Lecture

Read the following material and take notes in your journal.

- “The Importance of Warming Up” - page 91 in this manual
- “The 7 Rules of Stretching” – page 93 in this manual
- ❖ Origins and insertions – Stretching only when warmed up and from the belly of the muscle – NEVER at the boards with your skates on!
- ❖ Muscle imbalances – Balancing the use of strengthening and stretching (agonists and antagonists) exercises in one lesson – the same day of training is even better. TYPES of stretching/strengthening exercises – as in sports we do too many CONCENTRIC contraction exercises and we need more ECCENTRIC contraction exercises as these are the ones that strengthen the stabilizers. We also do too much passive stretching.
- ❖ Dealing with growth spurts – How to detect them and training “around” them. Focus on “artistry” (port de bras, and musicality in low impact movements), also ALL exercises in the Fundamentals Book Chapter 3.

- ❖ The role of correct breathing – aids technique - helps to reduce stress – gives more oxygen to the muscles and brain so that you have more stamina and a longer attention span

The Important Role of Myofascia: “The Warm Up Before the Warm Up”

Myofascia: Pages 2-34 through 2-40 in the Fundamentals book

Foot & Back Line – Page 2-34 fig. 2.24

Tibialis & Front Line – Page 2-36 fig. 2.25b

- **The Myofascial massages for both are on my instructional video**

Homework for Lesson 4:

- Read in this Manual: “The Importance of Warming Up “- page 91, “The Seven Rules of S-t-r-e-t-c-h-i-n-g “– page 93 and “Student Physical Assessments” - page 97
- Watch the “preliminaries” section of my instructional video.
- **Begin to synthesize the materials read so far in this course so that it begins to make sense as a whole; this can take more time than you might think as movement training has been so compartmentalized in the past.**
- Teach the Myofascial massages you learned today to some of your students and get feedback to discuss next week.

Lesson 4

You will need to wear form fitting clothes, have a mat and a strong, wide resistance band

Lessons 4 Agenda: Resistance band exercises. Learning 12 Vaganova based Floor-Barre exercises - the foundations of all stabilizer movement (Page 98 in this Manual)

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A - How to assess your students' abilities and weaknesses and address them moving forward.

B - Based on the Correlative Chart and the article on the progression of mind body skills - what a unified method of training (off to on ice) might look like.

C - How to teach the 12 Vaganova Floor exercises and how to relate them in detail to what each exercise will improve in the body specifically and as a whole.

D - How to teach the 4 resistance band exercises how to relate them in detail to what each exercise will improve in the body specifically and as a whole.

E - The art of effective cuing.

Reflection on Lesson 3

Pull out your journal and answer the following questions.

- How did your teaching of the 2 massages go? Did you get any feedback?
- The Vaganova Method is based on _____ not _____. What makes this a better methodology and why?
- Describe what a "Unified Method" of training might be and how it can help both the teacher and the student?
- Reminder that "when a warm up becomes a stretch" is a very individual thing that needs to be assessed, taught and practiced accordingly – It should **not** be assumed that everyone in the same skating/dance class is of the exact same aptitude and body-type.

Lesson 4 Lecture

Overview of "Progression of Mind-Body Connection Skills" (page 95)

Refer to the "Correlative Chart" (Page 129) in order to facilitate the understanding of everything being taught from floor to barre, to centre, and to ice. The Chart is a visual representation of how you should view the methodology as a whole.

“Student Physical Assessments” (Page 97 in this manual)

This section covers muscle imbalances and possible causes & effects. This assessment should be done on the first day of classes. When performing an assessment, you will:

- ❖ Detect and correct the muscular imbalances in your students
- ❖ Monitor progress and changes by taking notes over time. (Note: Mark heights on the wall of your studio to monitor growth spurts.)
- ❖ Formulate plans that balance the use of strengthening and stretching exercises in one lesson. (If in one days' full circuit of training, this is even better.)

This is continuity of movement training and requires that ALL coaches and teachers of a single student be on the same page – not usual, but we can try!

The Art of Effective Cueing

****Cueing in the moment****

Most teachers teach an exercise and then give corrections at the end – this is not an effective way to help your students learn or break bad habits. Learning how to cue *in the moment needed* is the only way to ensure that your students will both do and *remember* *what you have taught accurately. Please read pg. 107 in this manual for further insights.*

Resistance Band Exercises

Watch the first two exercises on the Instructional Video and take notes on the following:

- Pointing the Feet
- Finding/Strengthening “Turn-Out”

***Origin of arm movement exercise is explained here as it is not on the video**

This is both a somatic as well as a strengthening exercise for all arm movements. Arms should always be a technical assist to good posture, jumps, spins and footwork and not just an “artistic add on.” Try to feel each movement as coming from the STERNUM and SPINE, not just the shoulder joints.

- 1- Begin seated on the floor with legs crossed (Taylor style), grasp the resistance band with both hands (palms down) knee width apart with no slack in between. Now stretch the resistance band as wide as you can with arms completely straight at about navel level. Make sure that your posture is as erect as possible with ears, shoulders and hips in complete alignment and laterals lifted (in and up) as if there is a wide band around your waist. Keep posture lifted throughout BREATHING on the HOLD of each position.
- 2- Raise band to shoulder height and HOLD **4 counts**.
- 3- Raise band to above head and HOLD **4 counts** - *do not move your head, raise shoulders or torso to accommodate the band!*

- 4- Tilt wrists outward (laterally), extend band even wider and lower band to behind your shoulders without the band touching your body - band should be at least 6" away from the body. HOLD 4 counts
- 5- Continue to lower the band behind you to your waist and HOLD 4 counts

THEN REVERSE THE PROCESS

** Reminder to keep the torso completely lifted, arms completely straight and no movement in the shoulders or head to accommodate the band. This is an eccentric contraction exercise which strengthens the entire "core complex"

Please also see Chapter 3 "Origins of Arm Movements" in my Fundamentals book.

Introduction to the 12 Preliminary Vaganova Floor Exercises: Setting the Stabilizer Muscles in Place

Read pages 98 -104 in this manual and become familiar with the exercises.

THESE EXERCISES REPRESENT THE ENTIRE FOUNDATION OF THE VAGANOVA METHOD

Although there are over 35 floor exercises, we will focus on only 12. They are expressly focused on the "main fulcrum" of the body and set in place both strength and flexibility at 90 degrees. They concentrate on the "stabilizers" not the "mobilizers" as well as on the alignment of the Shoulder girdle, Spine and Pelvic girdle.

❖ All 3 of these are complexes are considered part of your core, and NOT just the deep abs. I call it the capital letter I

The way you comprehend, demonstrate and teach (cue) these exercises will determine student outcomes for the entire program

Homework for Lesson 5:

- Practice the exercises **yourself** as much as possible, taking *extensive notes* in the feel and purpose of each movement.
- **"Rehearse" the verbal and physical cues you will use to get the best results/responses from each student as individuals.**
- Then teach them to your students, with an eye for finding their weak and strong points. **Include the myofascial massages and resistance band exercises at the beginning of your lesson.**

Note: I highly recommend that you instill in your students that they should do ALL the Myofascia and resistance band exercises prior to **any** on or off-ice lessons (not just the ones you give them) to show the student how much more aware and prepared their bodies they can be - as *"the warm-up before the warm-up"* and for injury prevention.

A - Review the following reading materials and take notes in your journal.

- The 8 Elements of Movement Training
- The 7 Ways of Learning
- “The 7 Steps toward becoming a Master teacher”
- The Art of Effective Cueing

B - Apply the above concepts to your teaching and lesson plans. Ask yourself:

- Can you explain what each exercise does?
(stretch/strengthen/articulation/awareness/connection etc.)
- Can you perform a biomechanically correct and complete teaching of the exercise?
How would you verbally articulate this to individuals at various levels of skill?
- Can you explain what the exercise will improve moving forward in your students’ studies (skating/alignment body awareness or artistry)?
- Can you give them “the bigger picture” on why this exercise should be important to them and how they can incorporate it off to on-ice?
- Can you explain how the exercise effects the entire body, and not just the “focal point?”

Keep these points in mind when creating your lesson plans!

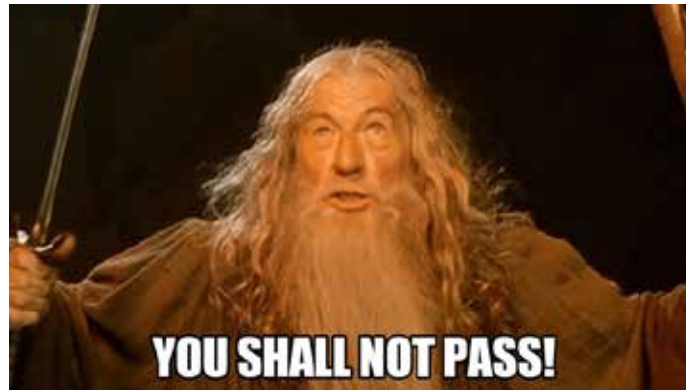
From now on in this course we will use the following process (method):

Note: if you don’t understand something - GO BACK!

- 1-) Practice the exercises yourself in order to feel them correctly in your own body (somatics) and take notes.
- 2-) Think about your individual students and what specific difficulties they may have and how you will approach cuing and teaching them
- 3-) Create written lesson plans with counts and cues (this gives you a permanent record which can be printed out and used/modified throughout your teaching career). Read Pages 5 - 12 and x - xii (about testing your students) in the Lesson Book, and also review my lesson plans in the Lesson Book to see how the counts are laid out above the steps.
- 4-) Rehearse your exercises with music in conjunction with cuing and counting before you go into your classroom.
- 5-) Teach your students first WITHOUT music – slowly and intentionally so that they really feel what they are supposed to feel and can be self-aware and self-correcting (not just going through the motions to get it over with). Have them practice the exercise several times without music while you count and cue only. You can even choose to do exercises for several weeks without music – but have the music “playing in your head” so to speak so that you can keep an accurate tempo in your head while teaching.

***NOTE: playing music at the outset for any exercise implies that the “choreography” of the piece is what is most important – and since this is NOT the case, we want to keep PLACEMENT as of the utmost importance in the student’s minds.**

6-) If there is any concept you do not have a clear grasp on, GO BACK, and GO BACK often. It is integral to understand each step of the methodology before proceeding to the next step. As our dear friend Gandalf says:



Pre-Assignment for Lesson 5

Look over the Beginning Ballet Syllabus (pages 87 and 88 in this manual), and re- read the intro through page 30 of the **Lessons Book**, as well as pages 5-7 to 5-13; 5-16 to 5-22 and 5-25 to 5-27 in the **Fundamentals Book**. Lastly, have the “**Ballet Class Music for Figure Skaters**” album ready to study (along with the music counts and tempos pdf. – from the Whitefeather Productions website) as ALL musical references in this manual with reference selections from this album.

Lesson 5

Lesson 5 Agenda: Introduction to beginning Vaganova ballet technique for the figure skater - Terminology, understanding music (tempos, time signatures, and how to count exercises). Cueing in light of adding musical counts to our cues. Overview of the ballet syllabus (Pages 109 -110 in this manual), How to make lesson plans for all ages. (Pages 5 -10 in my Lessons Book).

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A - How to count music and why counting is imperative to good teaching practices.

B - How tempo and musical phrasing effect movement comprehension (both in the teacher and the student).

C - Why ballet terminology matters.

D - What teaching Methodology really looks like and why it is a scientific *formula* not merely a suggestion.

Lesson 5 Lecture

The Ballet Syllabus and French Terminology – “Technical Manual and Dictionary of Classical Ballet” by Gail Grant is the best book to purchase on the subject

It is important to remember that the ballet syllabus is merely a fixed list of exercises and that it is the systematic procedure (methodology) of teaching those exercises which provides the building blocks necessary to produce optimum results without injury. The implementation of both the syllabus and the methodology is, to a certain degree, left to the creative discretion of the individual teacher in that your “class” is your “work of art in progress.” It is up to the teacher to “feed” the syllabus to the students at a slow and steady pace so as to simultaneously develop clean, accurate technique from the inside of the body out and to challenge the student in an emotionally and intellectually satisfying manner. The teacher also needs to take into account both individual as well as class progress and set the pace of learning accordingly. With this approach, true mastery is attainable with no need to “clean up” or revisit basic skills.

Ballet terminology does vary between methodologies, BUT the French Language is a LIVING language which needs accurate pronunciation with verbs and nouns just as any language does. Below are some common misuses within the ballet community:

Relevé means “to rise” and is an ACTION (verb) while

Demi-pointe means “half pointe” and is a POSE (noun)

Coupé means “to chop off” and is an ACTION (verb), while

Cou de pied means “on the neck of the foot” and is a POSE (there are 5 positions to this pose)

Retiré (withdrawn or to retire) and Passé (to pass):

There are many disagreements about Retiré and Passé, but generally speaking, Retiré is an action of the toe of the working foot being drawn from a foot position on the floor (as in 5th position), to the knee of the supporting leg and then returning to the floor.

Passé is the working foot passing through the pose Retiré to an extended position such as “arabesque”.

Plié means to bend while **Cambré** means to arch

Dégagé means to “detach” while **Tendu** means to stretch or to tense (contract)

Uses of the phrases: “Taking a class” vs. ‘Having a Lesson” - and “giving a class” vs. “giving a lesson”

A “**Class**” is a group of students – a “**Lesson**” is the information being taught. If someone says they are “giving a class” they are usually just choreographing a “lesson-like” group of exercises and offering tips on how to improve. They may use a syllabus, but their “methodology” is purely subjective as it is usually based on choreography not pedagogy.

Basic Musical terms:

Adagio –moderately slow tempo, connected

Legato – slow, smooth, flowing

Staccato – sharp, quick & choppy

Marcato – a sharp beginning tone, which extends into a smooth ending

Rallentando – gradually slowing down but not as abruptly as ritardando

Rubato - The temporary disregarding of strict tempo to allow an expressive quickening or slackening, usually without altering the overall pace.

Crescendo – gradually becomes louder

Diminuendo – gradually becomes quieter

Piano – quiet or soft

Forte – loud or strong

Down Beat – the first beat of a musical measure

Up Beat – an unaccented beat preceding an accented beat (down beat).

Syncopation – displacing beats so that the strong/upbeat becomes the weak/down beat and vice-versa

Pitch – Note, sound vibration – “Sharp” increases vibration frequency of a specific pitch, and “Flat” decreases the vibration frequency. (Analogous to tint and shade in art)

NOTE: The difference between Music Meter (2/4, 3/4, 6/8 etc.) and Music Value is how long a movement lasts to get from A to B to C (beginning, middle and end of the movement). **Please also read “Becoming the Music: on page 76 of this manual**

**"Music and silence combine strongly because music is done with silence, and silence is full of music."
— Marcel Marceau —**

Understanding Music Specifically as it Applies to the Ballet Lesson: Tempos, Time Signatures, and How to Count Exercises –

This section is presented only as general background information. Further study on music theory, appreciation and application can be studied through other materials such as the book “Ear Training for the Body” by Katherine Teck, and personal online study.

Counting brings order and accurate repeatability to a movement and connects one movement to the other. It is this continuity of time and movement that communicates the purpose and artistic relevance to the medium of dance and skating, and brings it all together to make a cohesive piece of art – a contiguous thought/picture (form and content). When we are in a creative mode, we move and think “outside of time” but when we need to teach the choreography of what we have conceived (or in this case a ballet exercise), we must communicate it IN time. Read Quote on page 5 of my Lessons book under “Music and Mental Focus”.

PHRASING: All ballet exercises are based on combinations of 2,4,8 or 16 counts – likewise almost all ballet class music is presented in “etudes” (studies or groups) of 32, 64 or 128 counts, so each exercise has to be counted out completely to contain a symmetrical or balanced combination which begins with (préparation) and concludes precisely with the music. Vaganova lesson music is best as it has clean precise beats that are mathematical and not emotional, as well as easy to follow. It feeds the student both the tempo and feeling of the exercise while also cueing when an exercise may be repeating itself, ending, or moving on to a different movement.

TIME SIGNATURES - and their meaning



A time signature tells you how many of what kind of notes (eighth, quarter, half, whole etc.) are in a measure, how many beats are in a measure, and that the specified kind of note gets a full beat.

The top number indicates how many beats (claps) are in a measure – the bottom number indicates what kind of note gets the beat. There are also “Rests” that can have a full, half, or quarter “beat/duration” of silence. Each measure in a piece of music must equal the same number of counts no matter how fast or slow the piece goes.

Waltz and Mazurka $\frac{3}{4}$ = 3 beats per measure and each quarter note gets a beat, $\frac{6}{8}$ = 6 beats per measure and each eighth note gets a beat (see diagram above) Example of 6/8: Track #23. Example of 3/4 - Waltz: Track #18; Mazurka: Track #22 which has the

same time signature as a waltz but with differences in accent, tempo and “feel” of the piece (staccato or legato).

March, Polka and Tango, 4/4 or 2/4 = 4 or 2 beats to a measure and each quarter note gets a beat. Example of 4/4: Track #5, 2/4: Track #1 (again see above diagram) Polka: Track #19 Tango: Track #17

The Tempo is the speed at which a piece of music is played (tempo means “time”) Example ♩= 60 means that the eighth note gets the count (beat) and it is played at 60 beats per minute (BPM - like a heartbeat)

The Key is determined by the group of pitches (chords) or scale upon which the piece of music is composed. The pitch of a piece of music affects the mood or feeling of the piece. Generally speaking, Major keys = bright and happy, Minor keys = sultry, sad, or contemplative. **(Keys are listed on the pdf. accompanying our album.)**

Counting Out Lesson Plan Exercises to Fit the Music

With very few exceptions, as mentioned above, all ballet class music, regardless of the time signature, is indicated/identified in groupings of 8 counts (e.g. 32, 64, 128). This is because most ballet exercises are counted in either 8 or 16 counts for beginners - as movements are done more slowly; and 2 or 4 counts for more advanced students – as movements are done more quickly.

I say “regardless of the time signature” because, in the beginning classes especially, you are counting only ONE BEAT PER MEASURE, the DOWN BEAT (or the strong beat), of each measure in the piece of music you are using.

Things to think about when preparing a lesson plan:

1-) All exercises must **begin and end exactly with the music**: There is to be a visible and specific “Préparation”, combination, and finish. Each exercise is seen as a “mini performance” so you would not stop or restart the music unless something is drastically wrong. Explain and demonstrate the exercise well enough so that every student understands the flow and meaning of the **entire** exercise - beginning, middle and ending. Keep the exercises simple with emphasis on precise movement, giving time (slow) to instill mind-body connection (Habit).

2-) Each exercise must be **symmetrical in composition & timing**, so, what you do to the right you must also do to the left, and/or what you do to the front you also do to the side and back. When facing the barre or with back to the barre, the normal progression would be: right side then repeat exactly the same to the left side. If doing an exercise “En Croix” (to the front, then side, then back and then side again), each direction must be identical in length and number of repetitions.

3-) If an exercise calls for 4 counts per movement that means that the movement should take **the ENTIRE 4 counts to get there** – not arrive on count one and then wait it out.

Given all the above, when preparing to compose a particular exercise, this is how you would proceed:

Decide what you want your students to practice. For example: Facing the barre, one battement tendu & one battement tendu jeté to each direction in **8 counts each**. So, this means you will have a total of **16 counts per direction**.

If you choose a piece of music which has **64 counts** to it, you can break up the exercise as follows:

“Preparation” (**4 count of the music “intro”**) Then - Right side (**16 counts**), Left Side (**16 counts**), Right Back (**16 counts**), Left Back (**16 counts**) And lower the arms to preparatory. **This totals 64 counts**

You can then have the student place their back to the barre, repeat the music and have them repeat the exercise (including the preparation and the ending) to the sides and to the front.

If you choose to do the exact same exercise with a piece of music which has **128 counts** (twice as many as the previous piece of music), you can do the exercise consecutively “1X en croix” like so:

“Preparation” (**4 count of the music “intro”**) Then - Right front (**16 counts**), Right side (**16 counts**), Right back (**16 counts**) and right side again (**16 counts**) (**this totals 64 counts**) *immediately repeating ALL to the left and lowering the arms to preparatory to finish.* **64 (right side) + 64 (left side) = 128 counts total**

The advantage of breaking up an exercise into smaller increments (**like choosing 64 counts over 128 counts**) is that the student has less to think about and can focus more strongly on fewer elements. It also gives you a chance to cue and critique in between portions of the same exercise.

Reminders in teaching your exercises:

A-) You are to explain the “composition” of the exercise clearly and demonstrate it as accurately as possible. Including *préparation*, and finish in time to the music.

B-) You should give at least 2 biomechanical directions for each exercise. What the exercise DOES for the body, how one should FEEL the exercise to produce the desired results, etc. (you can find these directions in the instructional video and in both of my books as well this manual)

C-) You should give at least 1 correlation for that exercise to an on-ice movement. E.g., “Tendus will help you to point your foot better in the skate as well as help you to feel what a very straight/pulled up knee feels like”. This will motivate the student to visualize

what the ballet exercise will actually DO for them - the WHY for taking this class with you! They will also feel it more accurately if it is correlated with their field of endeavor. D-) You should count for the students to make them stay on track (physically, mentally and musically) throughout the exercise. You can also have THEM count as they perform the exercises to practice tempo.

E-) You should give a thorough and personal critique after each exercise. (What was good/better and what specifically needs improvement.

F-) You should take notes after class as to those specific comments you gave to your students so that you can pick up where you left off at the next lesson – reminding them of those issues before they do them again.

Working with the “Ballet Class Music for Figure Skaters” CD

[Listen to the entire album with these points in mind:](#)

Track #1: is in 2/4 (March) and has 64 counts

The first 4 counts of each piece are for the “Préparation” (motivating breath)

- ❖ Clap or count out loud to the **down beat (count 1)** for at least 8 measures – **which would be 8 claps**
- ❖ Clap or count to the down beat and stamp on the **up beat (on the “and”)**
- ❖ Clap or count ALL the beats in 8 measures - **which would be 16 claps.**

Track #18 is in 3/4 (Waltz) and has 128 counts

- ❖ Clap or count out loud to **ALL the beats (1-3 of each measure)**
- ❖ Clap on count 1 and whisper 2,3)
- ❖ Clap on counts 1, 2 and whisper count 3
- ❖ Listen to the phrasing of the whole piece and think of other ways of feeling the meter. Phrasing your claps, steps etc. is part of learning musicality.

Track #7 is in 4/4 but “tricky” (Rond de Jamb par terre) and has 64 counts

What is the Down Beat & what is the Up Beat? Notice the flow and movement of the piece—the down beat is the lower sound & the upbeat is higher (melody) in order to propel you into the “fall” of the phrase. If you begin on the upbeat, the piece loses structure and becomes ambiguous. The designated accent of the beat affects perception and thus choreography.

Track #14 is an adagio (legato/connected), which means the notes would have a slur or tie under or over them to indicate that they are to flow together like so:



This means that even though you hear individual notes you need to take the phrasing as if it were a “song” – so the movement has to flow accordingly.

Tracks #23, #24 and #25 are for medium and small jumps (Échappé, temps levé and Trampoline jumps) so the music is either Staccato or Marcato, which means that movement to this music must be sharp, precise and “clean” with clear starts and stops.

Read again in relation to teaching to the music: “The 7 Steps towards becoming a ‘Master Teacher’”: page 105 and the Art of Effective Cueing: page 107 in this manual. *Your goal is to be so familiar with the material AND the methodology (Pedagogy: form, content, breakdown, synthesis and timing) of each step within a particular semester/year that you can easily create a curriculum which will be most effective in teaching every individual in a particular class – no additions, embellishments or eliminations. You should come into your classroom full of the entire level, purpose and goal of each year/semester of teaching, not “two steps” ahead of the students and merely working from a syllabus, as this will translate into chaos. - Students know the difference. Both you and they will have more confidence in your ability to help them reach their goals.*

5-) Creating lesson plans for all ages

Read Pages 5 - 12 and x - xii (about testing your students) in the Lesson Book, and also review my lesson plans in the Lesson Book to see how the counts are laid out above the steps.

****You can print out any of the “hand-outs” in my Lesson book to pass along to your students, parents, coaches and Board Members: Page 4 and xiii – xxi**

Homework for Lesson 6:

- A-** Make a point to go through the entire album and count the music correctly. Try to anticipate hearing the phrasing of each piece as, in doing so, even when you lose count you will know where you are in the piece and be able to get back on count easily. Familiarize yourself with sound and counts of the “Préparation” and the “close/finish” of each piece of music.
- B-** Practice a few of the floor exercises with the album and write the counts above each movement (usually 8 counts per “repetition”).
- C-** Look at the Beginning Lesson Plan (starting on page 36 of the Lessons Book) and count the exercises out loud to music from the album.
- D-** If you are having difficulty with counting, get a metronome app (I use a free one called “Metro Timer”) and practice counting/clapping and creating symmetrically phrased exercises just to the “beats”.

❖ Watch the Preliminaries through the end of battement tendu jeté on my video.

General Review:

- E-** READ Pages 41-49 “Lesson Construction” in “Foundations of Classical Ballet” – Vaganova Book and the Preface (page 33) if you haven’t already.
- F-** If you’ve not finished reading pages 4-13 and 20-30 in the Lesson Book, please do that as well.
- G-** READ: Chapter 5, pages 5-9 through 5-32 in the Fundamentals book.

Lesson 6

Lessons 6 Agenda: “Preliminaries” (on the instructional video) and beginning Vaganova barre, theory and practice (Pliés through Battement tendu jeté)

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

- A – The importance of approaching the barre exercises as a physical therapist – through accurate “placement not choreography”
- B – The importance of going slowly in order to set the mind-body connection
- C – How to teach and cue this lessons’ exercises effectively to every individual in your class (different body types, different learning styles, different needs/skills)
- D – How to connect each of these barre exercises with their corresponding floor exercises from the previous lesson.
- E – What these exercises will improve technically in specific skating elements

NOTE: Six lessons are devoted to the study of the ballet syllabus (on pages 109-110) which includes: “Preliminaries” (as shown in my video), 14 barre exercises and 12 centre exercises, some of which have multiple parts.

To reiterate: Each exercise is to be approached as a Physical Therapist might approach an exercise prescription for a specific physical outcome – looking “through the body” and teaching for maximum results on each repetition.

Beginning Vaganova Barre Theory:

- ❖ Everything learned at the barre is a part of a jump, spin or an element found in the “Pas de Deux” (partnering duet including lifts).
- ❖ Further setting and translating whole body placement (stabilizers, posture and stance) from the Vaganova floor exercises to a standing position without losing structural integrity.
- ❖ All Barre exercises are at first practiced facing the barre, then, when mastered with one hand on the barre. This is to teach a “square” and balanced torso with equal strength on each side.
- ❖ All NEW exercises (as well as beginning jumps) are introduced and practiced facing the barre.
- ❖ All exercises are at first practice to the sides only to increase whole body awareness for turn out strength, balance (stability) and alignment.
- **Simple exercises at a very slow, even pace serve two purposes:**
 - ❖ To create the correct mind/body neural pathways so that good technique becomes second nature without need to “clean up” later
 - ❖ To give the teacher a chance to view exactly how each student is doing. **Usually no faster than c.55 - 60 bpm for music and counting**

- *Battement tendu is considered to be the foundation of the Vaganova Method (pages 5-28 through 5-32 in the "Fundamentals" book)*

Battement Tendu "sets" the entire structure of the foot, ankle, knee, hip joint, pelvic girdle and lower back in every direction. Battement tendu jeté (at 45°) goes even further in that *it sets the entire body alignment* when practiced correctly.

Beginning Vaganova Barre Practice:

Exercise numbers correlate with the Ballet Syllabus on pages 109 – 110 of this manual

A- Preliminaries:

Positions of the feet (p. 5-13 in Fundamentals) 6th position is feet together in parallel
Correct Stance TBS (The Basic Stance):

- Arches lifted - so that the Tibialis Anterior Tendon is visible, equal pressure on the big toe, little toe and heel
- Knees pulled up (not "locked")
- Coccyx (tail bone) should remain pointing directly downward toward the heels with no arching or curving of the lower back (pelvis in neutral – which, at the beginning, will feel slightly "tucked" for most skaters)
- Ribcage NOT constricted (breathing correctly from the BASE of the lungs!)
- Shoulders pressed down & open with chin lifted slightly higher than parallel to the floor, ears parallel to shoulders - so that neck tendons show). Curved shoulders indicate poor understanding of what the shoulder girdle should and should not be involved in when engaging the "core". Traditional "crunches" create curved shoulders (as opposed to a Pilates or my capital letter **I** Core Complex understanding of where the focus should be). Also, a false understanding of a Flat Back in certain ballet circles can actually create curved shoulders. Please see exercises in Chapter 3 in my Fundamentals book pp. 3-5 through 3-9 and 3-34 through 3-31).
- How to hold the barre (p. 5-12 in the Fundamentals book and on video) Hands across from shoulders and elbows aimed down to the floor – thumbs UNDER for the preliminary practice of standing in the positions ONLY!
- Standing with "isometric squeeze" (strengthens turn-out) in each of the turned-out positions for a very slow (c. 50bpm) 8 counts and then tendu to the next position (in 8 counts) - this "sets" the entire mind-body connection to feel correct turn out in every foot position. ***NOTE: You are standing in 'turn-out' even when your feet are in parallel as your glutes are engaged and your knees are presented directly in line with the center of the toes.**

B- Barre Exercises

A count of 8 will be used for ALL exercises – Exercises are presented here in their simplest form. Try to teach them to your students in this same form *with no deviations* as this is essentially a “scientific formula” which works. As you and your students’ progress, you can create “combined” exercises (Enchaînement) as per the demonstration exercises on my instructional video.

Re-read: Introduction to Plié for the Figure Skaters” (Fundamentals Book pages 5-16 to 5-18) - in skating (as in ballet) the demi-plié is everything! Deep, well-centered (knees over toes, etc.) demi-pliés are the foundation of all jumps –

➤ **The deeper the demi-plié, the higher the potential of the jump**

***NOTE:** All page numbers in this section refer to the **Fundamentals book** unless otherwise noted. It is recommended that you video your own teaching and rewatch to critique yourself on what you may have missed and how you can improve in the future.

3 - Demi-plies with “isometric squeeze” in 1st, 2nd and 3rd (pp. 5-18 through 5-20)
Track #14 (128 counts) To begin you can practice 3 demi-pliés in each position with 8 counts to transition to the next position (since Battement Tendu has not yet been taught just change foot to the next position via a “point the foot” as in the floor exercises.)

Demi- Plié:

counts are as follows:

1 - 4 and 5 6 7 8

Demi-plié, Deepen, Push to straighten, Isometric squeeze (with knees pulled up – not locked)

Grand Plié: (pp. 5-21 and 5-22) studied after demi-plié has been mastered ****NOTE:** ONLY Fig. 5.15 in the Fundamentals book is a correct demonstration

counts are as follows:

1 - 2 , 3 4 and 5 6 7 8

Demi-plié, Grand plié, come back to Demi-plié, Deepen, straighten & isometric squeeze (pulling up the knees)

REMEBER: Always deepen the demi-plié before straightening and always push away from the floor to straighten (activates the “antigrav” muscles rather than the quads.) Watch that the knees track consistently over the toes both down and *especially* on the way up. The hands “slide” to the right a bit as you change into 2nd position, then back again for 3rd or 5th position. The hands must ALWAYS be directly across from the shoulders with elbows facing the floor at all times.

Track #14

6- Battement Tendu in 1st and 5th (pp. 5-28 through 5-31) **Track #3 (128 counts)**

The beginning of balancing on one foot, NO counterbalancing (as in tilting away from the working leg) allowed! Counterbalancing must occur (physics!) but by pushing into the floor and lifting out of the hips on the supporting side. Lifting out of hips (remember floor exercise #1) strengthens turnout on one foot and engages the entire body. *Always push supporting leg and foot into floor! Energy out the working toe (and head). No leaning/weight on the working foot. Always looks dynamic, never just like a pose. **This exercise is repeated only to the sides 8X on the right foot and then 8X on the left.**

*On the extension aim for a slightly greater turn out every time, on returning the working foot to 1st or 5th the student must feel as though the supporting leg upper thigh and back of the knee is being pulled medially as much as the working leg (isometric squeeze).

- A. Begin extensions to the side ONLY for turn out, balance and alignment
- B. Next teach the meaning of the term “En Croix”
- C. Teach trajectory differences between 1st and 5th to front & back
- D. Teach “**hit heels**” returning from the side for tendu and tendu jeté from 3rd and 5th. Sliding the working foot against the supporting foot on closure to 3rd and 5th
> Heel stays down as long as possible without twisting hips!

Counts as follows for tendu in 1st position:

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

Tendu, hold, close, hold (isometric squeeze) Knees constantly pulled up.

Counts as follows for tendu in 3rd and 5th (for side):

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

Tendu, hold, **hit heels** & slide into 5th, hold.

NOTE: Take the **full 2 counts** to get into the tendu and back to the return. Any time there is a “hold” the body is still in a complete state of action/stretch/lift etc.

7- Battement Tendu Jeté in 1st and 5th (pp. 5-31 through 5-32) **Track #4 (128 counts)**

The continuation of learning how to balance on one foot in a completely aligned manner. ** If tendu isn’t learned correctly (no weight on the extended foot, no counterbalancing “side to side” etc.) then correct tendu jeté will **never** happen. Tendu Jeté is always at 45°, the torso must stay completely still even to the back. Beginning study is done from point tendu to the floor, then a sharp lift to 45°, then the toe goes back to point tendu to the floor before closing to 1st or 5th. **(Repeat 8X per side)**

Beginning counts for tendu jeté in 1st are as follows:

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

Tendu, sharp lift, sharp tendu to the floor and isometric squeeze close

Beginning counts for tendu jeté in 5th (for side) are as follows:

1 2 3 4 5 6 and 7 and 8

Tendu, sharp lift, sharp tendu to the floor, hit heels and isometric squeeze close

Homework for lesson 7:

- Practice with music yourself using cueing/visualizing your student(s) etc.
- Rehearse to solidify counts and verbal cues (create a written lesson plan)
- Teach your student – practice your “role” as teacher/trainer with them
- Video after you have a “product” you are satisfied with
- Review your video and take note on what you need to work on.

WHAT YOU ARE TO TEACH AND RECORD:

- 1-) Posture & Stance (TBS) facing the barre in 1st position: discuss with your student proper stance from feet to head and tell them the reasons why. Relate HOW to get into 1st position (from the resistance band exercise on the floor).
- 2-) Demi and grand pliés in 1st, 2nd and 3rd positions
- 3-) Relevés in 1st, 2nd, 3rd and 5th positions
- 4-) Cambré front, side and back with 2 hands on the barre
- 5-) Battement tendu in 1st and 5th **to the side only***
- 6-) Battement tendu jeté in 1st and 5th **to the side only***

*When practice to the sides looks stable you will then introduce Battement Tendu and Battement Tendu Jeté to the front and back (without shifting weight). Finally, it will be put together as an “enchâînement” (combination) practiced “en croix” (in a cross = front, side back and then again side).

REMINDER:

- Hands on placement
- Accurate/specific verbal cuing in the moment needed
- Slow tempos (counting) keeping the student focused and on task.
- Tell why the exercise is important for skating technique
- Correlate each exercise with at least one of the 12 floor exercises

Lesson 7

Lessons 7 Agenda: Centre work – points of the stage, the meaning of the pose “croisé”, basic arm positions, finger grouping, head and hand training, elements of First Port de Bras and all barre exercises learned in Lesson Six.

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A – The Points of the Stage and how this relates to poses both off and on the ice.

B – The Importance of finger groupings, head and eye focus/coordination when practicing arm movements.

C – The importance of using arms as a “technical assist” by connecting each arm movement with the **Core Complex**.

D - The specific importance of tendu and tendu jeté in the centre.

E - The importance of learning ALL barre exercises in the center in order to create strength, coordination and proprioception in small motor skills.

Beginning Vaganova Centre Theory

- ❖ Everything learned at the barre is then translated to the centre in an “en face” position (facing the front of the studio/mirror, which is Point one – see Appendix page I in Lesson book), further “setting” whole body placement and BALANCE without losing integrity. This is called “**Centre Barre Work**”.
- ❖ When the teacher presents an exercise at the barre, the **exact** same combination (tempo, music, repetitions) should be practiced in the center without variation.
- ❖ Hand, eye and arm coordination (**Port de bras**) is introduced in the centre even before the student learns the barre exercises with one hand on the barre. The reason for this is to see, feel and understand port de bras “from the inside out” in a bilateral “flat” manner, facing the mirror. (See pages 13 through 21 in the Lesson Book)
- ❖ The student must maintain awareness of **whole-body alignment** at all times. Never let them get preoccupied with just the “moving limb”, their neighbors’ movement, or any other distraction. Focus on breathing, posture, correct execution of technique - “the whole feeling and picture from head to toe”.

Beginning Vaganova Centre Practice

A- Preliminaries

- The 8 Points of the Stage (Lesson Book appendix page “I”) Marching Game – hands on waist, marching single file into the room; then call out numbers of the points of the stage every 4 counts. (p. 38 in the Lesson Book) use: **Track # 1**
- Review posture, stance and basic foot positions in the center, with arms in preparatory. Have them look at themselves in the mirror AFTER they feel everything “correctly” – to front and turning sideways to see both sides.

- Basic finger groupings (Arrondi and Allongé), basic arm positions; 1st, 2nd and 3rd (pages 13, 14, 20, 21 & 39 in the Lesson Book and also in the “Preliminaries” on my video.)
- Basic concepts of “Epaulement” – En face and Croisé.

Take time with finger grouping, arm positions with correlating head positions and eye gaze, as they are the basis of all expression!

B- Centre Exercises: This includes exercise numbers correlating to the Ballet Syllabus Centre Exercises (page 109 in this Manual). ***All “Centre Barre” exercises will use the exact same music, counts and composition as at the barre, with the addition of using arms - Préparation and the “Finish”***

The very first thing you will do is the Marching Game with the students circling the room into their assigned places with correct spacing. Teach the 8 Points of the Stage (Appendix page i in the Lesson Book) using the “Student Physical Assessments” (page 99 in this manual) - assess gait, posture and any anomalies and write them in your roster. Use **Track #1 and count (step to) every beat.**

2 - The First of the 3 port de bras (Including basic arm positions, correct finger groupings, head and hand training) See Pages 13 through 21 in my Lesson book, my video “Preliminaries C”, Centre exercise #1, and barre exercise #14. *Also see Pages 3-38 through 3-40 in the Fundamentals book for floor barre port de bras –a great preliminary exercise to feel a flat back with shoulders open!*

BASIC HAND TRAINING: The training of hands, arms, head and eyes are first learned in a more “relaxed 1st position of the feet in the centre of the room, while maintaining correct whole-body alignment and awareness.

TEACH: Hand and finger training (pages 20 and 21 in the Lessons book)

- ❖ Arrondi (rounded)
- ❖ Allongé (elongated)

THEN: The Preparatory Position, Demi 2nd, and “Motivating Breath”

Followed by:

BASIC ARM POSITIONS 1st – 3rd: After demonstrating the basic hand and arm positions with correct head and eye gaze, go behind each student and **place** them correctly (**holding elbows**), so that they can see and feel the correct placement. Have them practice the correct feeling and look (both front and side) to the mirror while you work with the other students.

Breaking down the elements of 1st Port de Bras as follows

a-) Begin with finger grouping with arms in preparatory. SHAPE: understanding of both positive and negative shapes is very important to develop in the student. Teach “Motivating Breath” and hand positions “Arrondi and Allongé” **Practice in 4 counts each at least 4X with no music** (see page 39 exercise #4 in the Lesson Book)

b-) Next, practice bringing the arms into 1st position (to navel only – no higher) and then back down to preparatory, first without using the head (just looking straight forward) and then incorporating the correct head movements (tilt right and tilt left) with eye gaze.

c-) Next, practice bringing the arms from preparatory to 1st and then into 3rd, and reversing back to preparatory. (4 counts for each position - 16 counts total) looking straight ahead then with correct head and eye gaze – looking at hand, wrist, back to hand and straight ahead). *Watch that the lower back does not arch on bringing the arms into 3rd. (A good floor exercise for this is in the Fundamentals book pp.3-38 to 3-14).*

d-) Next, practice the arms going from preparatory to 1st and then opening to 2nd. Then turn the hands to allongé and bring the arms back to preparatory. (16 counts total) looking straight-ahead and then with correct head and eye gaze.

e-) Lastly, practice the arms going from preparatory to 1st, to 3rd and then opening to 2nd, allongé and lowering to preparatory. (16 counts total)

f-) When all the above has been mastered, begin study of complete First Port de Bras in 16 counts First “en face” and then later in “croisé” Use: **Track #16**

*For further understanding for the preliminary on-ice practice: Review pages 3-34 through 3-43 in the Fundamentals book concerning origins of arm movements and a few fun things to work on in preparation for on-ice practice of port de bras.

1 - Centre Practice Demi Pliés and Relevés in 1st, 2nd and 3rd (or 5th) no Grand pliés yet. This exercise is practiced “en face” facing the mirror (Point 1) See video Centre exercise #2 – the counts will be faster on the video but will give you a visual.

When initially teaching these elements you would practice them individually – exactly as practiced at the barre in Lesson 6 - and NOT as a combination. Use: **Track #14

Begin in 1st position with arms in preparatory, use “motivating breath” for the préparation, but conclude with the arms remaining in the preparatory position.

Exercise in 36 counts total - Red “and” is spoken within the counts for deepening the demi-plié

1 - 4 and 5 - 8 1 - 4 5 6 7 8
 Demi-plié & straighten; relevé pulling knees up, hold the demi-pointe & lower heels
 1 - 4 and 5 - 8 1 - 4 5 6 7
 Repeat Demi-plié & straighten. Then tendu to the RIGHT side, hold and lower
 8
 heel to 2nd position. (Bring foot in slightly so heels are directly under hip bones)

Arms in this exercise are as follows: Move from preparatory to 1st on the tendu (counts 1,2) of the transition to the next side and open to 2nd position (counts 3,4), then allongé (counts 5, 6) and lower back to preparatory on the lowering of the heel or closing of the working foot (counts 7,8). Essentially this is the beginning 8 counts of 1st port de bras

Repeat all in 2nd position

1 - 4 5 6 - 8
THEN: Tendu to the RIGHT, **hit heels**, slide into 3rd or 5th position right foot front.
**Arm go from 2nd position into allongé on the tendu, and lower to preparatory on the feet closing to 3rd.

Repeat all in 3rd or 5th (if 3rd is being practiced do not slide the front foot into a tight position during relevé)

END: Tendu LEFT foot side to bring it into 3rd or 5th front and repeat. End with tendu right foot to side and finish in 1st position with arms lowering to preparatory.

NOTE: When the student is ready, both arms are drawn up to 1st during the relevé in 3rd or 5th and lower back to Preparatory for the second demi-plié OR open out to 2nd position for the grand plié. (arms in 1st are naval height NOT chest height!)

***Grand – Pliés** should be added **ONLY** after the student has proven ready: good body mechanics throughout, knees over toes both going down and coming back up, little to no wobbling on the relevé.

Grand plié will also introduce more complex arm patterns when practiced in the centre. (Please see instructional video)

Same counts as the barre – 2 counts to demi-plié, 1 count to grand (calves and thighs must not touch!), 1 count back to demi-plié - **DEEPEN** and then 2 counts to straighten.

3- Battement tendu and tendu jeté in 1st and 5th (video centre exercise #3 is much more complex and faster but shows all the “forms”) Use Tracks #3 and #4

Beginning in 1st position with arms in preparatory facing point 1

Préparation is the motivating breath; bring arms from preparatory to 1st and then opening out to 2nd position, it is done in 4 counts, then holding the arms in 2nd position correctly throughout. This exercise is extremely difficult, but must be stressed as imperative for balance, and whole-body alignment before moving on to positions “in the air”.

Counts, music and repetitions are exactly as at the barre (8 counts each). Practice ONLY to the sides for the first few lessons, then do the exercise 1X “en croix”.

To “finish” the exercise, take the arms from 2nd position arrondi to allongé and then bring them down to the preparatory position.

REMINDER: When going from the barre to the center - Always use the same music for the same exercise. This helps the student to focus on correct execution rather than trying to fit the exercise into a new piece.

Homework for Lesson 8:

Re-read pages 13 through 21 in the Lesson book

- WHOLE BODY, MUSICAL CUEING and hands on placement of student
- Methodical teaching, with the purpose of imparting the full intention of the movement; say something that will connect the student to their on-ice practice of each exercise/concept you are teaching them.
- Teach (instruct) And **Motivate!** – Your “tone” means everything – you can motivate without yelling – use a loud voice but with a smile and humor! I tell my teacher students **“Cheer, not Fear”!**

WHAT YOU ARE TO TEACH AND RECORD

- 1-) Show proper spacing in the centre of the room and tell why this is important
- 2-) Show basic finger groupings: Arrondi and Allongé (you can do this by showing “motivating breath” with music.)
- 3-) Show BOTH the breakdown of, and the full 1st port de bras in 16 counts each 2X through (once looking to the right and once looking to the left)
- 4-) Show Demi-pliés and Relevés in 1st, 2nd and 3rd positions
- 6-) Battement tendu in 1st and 5th 2 each direction in 8 counts each (to sides only)
- 7-) Tendu jeté in 1st and 5th (or 3rd) 2 each direction in 8 counts each (to sides only)

Critique your own progress by journaling

Lesson 8

Lesson 8 Agenda: Continuation of barre exercises: passé par terre, demi rond de jamb par terre, full rond de jamb par terre, rond de jamb par terre in demi-plié, and demi and full Grand rond at 45° en dehors and en dedans, Review of First Port de Bras (adding pose **Croisé**). Begin Elements of 3rd port de bras.

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A – Rond de Jamb is the first “multiplanar” exercise which requires full control over the torso

B – Continued correlation of floor to barre exercises in a clinical and somatic manner

C – How to relate the exercises in this lesson with specific skating elements

E - Learning the pose Croisé and using port de bras (carriage of the arms) in coordination with head and eye gaze with correct finger groupings. Understanding fluidity of movement while still engaging the Core Complex

Continuation of Barre Exercises

The following group of exercises is connected in that the first 3 are elements and “forms” of the ensuing exercises. (See video “Preliminaries section E: 3 sections of rond de jamb”, video Centre Exercise #6, and pages 5-33 through 5-36 in the Fundamentals book *correction on pp 5-34). All “rond de jamb par terre” exercises begin from 1st position and must be taught in precise order and tempo to ensure that whole body alignment, turn-out and balance are maintained at all times. Concepts of “en dehors” (meaning “outside”), and “en dedans” (meaning “inside”); These exercises are essential to “body box” (Capital letter “**I**”) control during jumps and spins. Keeping the torso (hips, spine and shoulders) absolutely still while the leg is circling is the goal.

8- Passé par terre (in 4 counts – 2 counts for each position) **Track #7**

Begin in 1st position with both hands on the barre. On the musical préparation” (4 counts) slowly bring the right foot to tendu back. On counts 1 and 2 return the foot strongly turned out back into 1st position; on counts 3 and 4, pass from 1st to tendu front. Return to 1st position (counts 5, 6) and pass through again to tendu back (counts 7,8). Repeat 2&1/2 times, ending close to 1st (on counts 5,6) THEN: tendu back with left foot (on counts 7-8) to repeat all with the left foot, ending with a HOLD in 1st position for the last 2 counts (counts 7,8)

9- Demi rond and full Rond de jamb par terre:

A- Demi-rond de jamb en dehors in 8 counts each:

Tendu front (2 counts) draw a ¼ circle to the side (2 counts) **HOLD** (2 counts) & squeeze close to 1st (2 counts). Tendu side, draw a ¼ circle to the back, **HOLD** and close to 1st. Repeat all a total of 2X's, and then repeat with the other leg.

B- Demi-rond de jamb en dedans in 8 counts each:

Tendu back (2 counts) draw a ¼ circle to the side (2 counts) **HOLD** (2 counts) & squeeze close to 1st (2 counts). Tendu side, draw a ¼ circle to the front, **HOLD** and close to 1st. Repeat 2X total, and then repeat with other leg.

C- Full rond de jamb par terre in 8 counts each en dehors & en dedans

*Only when the student has shown that they can keep the working leg in turn out at all points without twisting the hips and torso or leaning away from the supporting leg. 2 counts per movement and always beginning with “en dehors”

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

Tendu front, trace to side, trace to back and close to 1st 4X

THEN: repeat with same foot en dedans. Repeat music to repeat with other leg.

10- Rond de jamb par terre in demi-plié en dehors and en dedans Track #8

Begin in 1st position Begin En dehors is as follows:

1 2 3 4 5 6
Demi-plié, stay in demi-plié and tendu front, trace to side, trace to back,
7 8

Straighten the supporting leg and close back to 1st position. And repeat.

Repeat en dedans and then repeat with other leg.

Make sure the supporting leg is well turned out with good knee to toe alignment and that the hips stay completely still (no “Hula”!) during the “rond” of the working leg.

This exercise in particular is EXCELLENT for skaters as it trains the skating knee to stay over the supporting toe during multiplanar movements of the free leg. This exercise can later be practiced with the working leg off the floor at ever increasing height. It can also be done later with skates and guards on the “working” leg to improve strength.

11- Demi and full Grand rond at 45° en dehors and en dedans Track #12

Begin in 1st position. Demi-grand rond “procedure” is very similar to Demi-rond de jamb par terre (without the “HOLD”), but at 45°. Make sure that the torso stays COMPLETELY LIFTED and perpendicular to the floor at all times with no leaning side or forward to “accommodate” the working leg. *WATCH supporting hip – no resting on hip.

*If the student has not mastered stability in rond par terre they are not ready for this exercise. Don’t try to rush training – if the student cannot hold the torso still when practicing this exercise “par terre” (toes on the floor), they are not ready to do this exercise.

Always remember “The Tortoise and the Hare”! ☺

En dehors is as follows:

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
Tendu front, lift to 45°, carry to the side, tendu & close to 1st

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
Tendu side, lift to 45°, carry to the back, tendu & close to 1st

Repeat again and then repeat 2X en dedans.

Full Grand Rond at 45° is as follows:

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
Tendu front, dégagé to 45° carry to the side, carry to the back, tendu & close 1st

Repeat 2X and then repeat 2X en dedans. Then repeat with the other leg. OR you can do en dehors to both sides and then en dedans to both sides to relieve possible strain.

3-) Centre Work: Review of First Port de bras adding the pose croisé. Begin Elements of 3rd port de bras

- Review and practice First Port de Bras in 16 counts using the pose **Croisé** (see **video centre exercise #1**) to point 8 and point 2 with feet in 3rd position
- Study elements of 3rd Port de Bras (see video and pp.16 of the Lesson Book)

3rd Port de Bras In 16 counts each:

(Track #16)

Begin in pose Croisé (in 3rd position) to point 8.

1 2 3 4
Arms from preparatory to 1st, arms open to 2nd (head coordinates with right arm),

And 5 6
Lift torso and cambré front flat back to 90° (parallel floor) without swaying the legs & seat back; arms come into first position on count 6 of the Cambré head faces floor.

and 7 8 and 1 2
Lift and come up bringing arms to 3rd, **Lift** and Cambré back (head and eye gaze is 3" above the inside of the right elbow for 3rd) without pushing the hips forward.

And 3 4 5 6 and 7 8
Lift and come up with arms still in 3rd, open arms to 2nd, allongé and lower arms to preparatory

**The legs and hips should remain as motionless as possible throughout (Isometric squeeze – "in and up"). There should be no swaying backward and forward during the bends of the body. When coming up from the cambré front, remember to correlate this to the straddle floor exercise and the cambré front facing the barre. Engage the glutes strongly and push feet into the floor to come up from the bend.*

Homework for Lesson 9:

ALL exercises in this lesson

1-) Practice (rehearse) alone FIRST with cueing and music counts in correct tempo – beginning and ending with the music you have chosen. Then, practice several times with your students before filming.

2-) Describe what “croisé” means – what it does artistically and visually (contrapposto), and what its on-ice application might be (teach “the eye spine” connection in regard to proprioception).

3-) Remember to USE ALL HEAD, EYE AND HAND COORDINATION especially in the port de bras as this is going to have on - ice application and will be extremely difficult if it is not extensively worked on off-ice FIRST.

❖ **REMEMBER your Chart (on page 129 of this manual) and correlate exercises to SPECIFIC on-ice elements.**

Lesson 9

Lessons 9 agenda: Continuation of centre exercises, Study of “Temps relevé par terre” and review/continuation of 1st and 3rd port de bras

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A – All centre exercises need to be accomplished with the same control (aplomb), alignment and attention to detail as at the barre.

B – The inner beats of the music are important to use for cuing and correction.

C – Counterbalancing must be held eccentrically (within the body) and not by tilting away from the working leg.

D – Musicality and whole-body movement is now entering into the training through head, eye and arm coordination.

E - How being both a **teacher** and a **trainer** is essential to good cuing practices.

Continuation of Centre Exercises

As mentioned previously, all exercises begin “en face” (to Point 1) except for the Port de Bras. Use the same music, counts and number of repetitions as you used for the correlating barre exercises to keep thought process continuity.

Arms (and head/ eye gaze) will continue to be an increasing part of the centre exercises and will become more complex as we progress. *For now, each exercise will begin with the same “Préparation”: using “motivating breath” always in 4 counts.*

4 - Passé par terre, demi and full Rond de jamb par terre

INDIVIDUALLY - as practiced at the barre – Later, these three elements can be combined in to one contiguous combination as is shown on my video Centre Exercise #6. In the first year the “Préparation” for all rond de jamb exercises are as stated previously: arms from the preparatory position, motivating breath, back to preparatory, up to 1st position and open out to 2nd position. The arms remain in 2nd position for the entire exercise and then allongé and lower arms back to preparatory for the “finish”.

5 - Rond de jamb par terre in demi-plié

As practiced at the barre – With arms going through the Préparation and remaining in 2nd position until lowering back to preparatory at the end.

Later, this exercise can be combined with **“Temps relevé par terre”**, which is the (eventual) full préparation for rond de jamb par terre. [*\(Centre exercises 5 & 6 in this manual are not on my instructional video\).*](#)

6 - Temps relevé par terre begins in 1st position with arms in Preparatory. For the Préparation - open both arm to demi-second on **counts 1 & 2** at the “top” of the motivating breath HOLD the demi-second position on counts 3 & 4.
(Track #8)

Practice 4X en dehors in **8 counts each** as follows:

1 2 3 4
Demi-plié bringing the arms back to Preparatory; tendu front bringing the arms to
5 6
1st, remaining in demi-plié, then trace the working foot to the side opening the
and 7
arms to 2nd, keeping the arms in 2nd position - straighten the knee, and bring the
8 and a
working foot back into 1st position. Palms turn down and allongé to repeat.

Then practice 4X en dedans and repeat all to the LEFT side. LATER you can combine this exercise with Rond de jamb par terre in demi-plié – just as practiced at the barre. This “combination” will give an added challenge while in keeping with the methodology of balancing in the centre in demi-plié on one foot.

7- Demi and full Grand rond at 45° en dehors and en dedans

(Track #12)

Use basic “Préparation” opening arms to 2nd position and then practice exactly the same as at the barre. NO LEANING! LIFT out of hips and PUSH supporting foot into the floor!

You can use a small bean bag (c. 4”X 4”) on your head for this one – it’s fun and reveals so much about posture!

2- Review of 1st and 3rd port de bras in croisé

(Track #16)

Work on the fluidity of the movements and breathing while being constantly aware of the POWER and strength of arms as originating from the:

- Spine
- Sternum
- Quadratus Lumborum
- Iliopsoas
- Gluteals
- Laterals
- Trapezius
- Pectorals

Homework:

Practice all exercise learned today “en face (to Point 1), and 1st and 3rd port de bras to both “sides” (Point 8 and Point 2) in correct tempo from the pose croisé.

Be attentive to the fact that whole-body placement – LIFT – ALIGNMENT – LINE and COORDINATION – need to be addressed in your cueing at all times!

You will video all exercises learned in this lesson and then critique them taking notes in your journal as to what you can improve on.

A few reminders:

- ❖ Study all pertinent material in both books, the video, my notes & your own notes
- ❖ **Practice all exercise yourself several times**, take notes on what you need to brush up on/feel differently/ and or think your specific students may have trouble with.
- ❖ Choose appropriately SLOW music for each exercise in the counts indicated
- ❖ Practice exercises yourself again with your chosen music, counting out loud as well as giving appropriate technical “prompts” throughout. Always rehearse, so that you don’t have to think about it during your lesson time and demonstration - this way you can give FULL attention to the students.
- ❖ Teach it to your students FIRST and then finally
- ❖ Video tape it as a demonstration lesson for your personal review

** VERBAL technical prompts help the student to remain focused during each exercise. You must **constantly** verbalize the following: Lifting out of hips, working turn-out on BOTH LEGS – Say, “I want to see turn out on BOTH SIDES OF THE BODY! I want to see constant energy out of the toes of the working foot, never look stagnant, be dynamic – stretch, lift!” In ballet the body energy is always going in two directions at once, BOTH UP AND DOWN. This must be visible at all times, and you must see the entire body and mind working to the fullest at every second of every exercise.

****Be both a Teacher and a Trainer****

Lesson 10

Lessons 10 Agenda: Study of barre exercises Fondu par terre and en l'air, the wrapping exercise, Développé and Relevé lent at 45° and 90°, both at the barre and in the centre. Trampoline Jumps and beginning study of 2nd port de bras.

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A – What a strongly pointed foot should feel like with both a straight as well as a bent knee.

B- That a “Fondu” is essentially a plié on one foot (so all the same principles apply) and the beginning study of jumps on one foot.

C- How to raise the working leg SLOWLY to at least 90° in every direction without losing correct whole-body alignment and balance.

D- How to do continuous jumps using deep demi-pliés, pointed feet in the air, correct breathing techniques, and correct total body alignment (both ascending and descending) in time to the music.

E- The basic principles and coordinated movement of 2nd port de bras, including head and eye focus and movement from the complete Core Complex (Shoulder, Spine and Pelvis).

Continuation of Barre Exercises (numbers as listed on the Ballet Syllabus)

Study of 3 of the 5 “sur le cou de pied” positions: conditional front, wrapped and back

12- Wrapping Exercise for “sur le cou de pied” (Shown in the preliminaries of my video and as part of barre exercise #8) (Track #9)

The “wrapped” position of the foot is considered the “template” angle for all free leg ballet poses. In this position the heel of the working leg foot is in front and just above the malleolus of the supporting foot, then wrapped to the back of the supporting ankle, with the toe of the working foot touching the top of the supporting foot’s shoe (ballet slipper).

Begin facing the barre in 5th position, on the “Préparation”, tendu the right foot to the side and place the foot in a flexed position across the lower front of the left ankle.

1 2 3 4

Wrap, flex, a total of 6X

THEN – to change feet on the 7th repetition, do: wrap (counts 1&2) **tendu to the side** (count 3) close feet to 5th (count and 4) **tendu left foot side** (counts 5,6) flex on right ankle (counts 7,8)

Repeat with your left foot. (64 counts) and repeat all again (for a total of 128 counts)

13- Fondu par terre and Fondu en l'air (pages 5-36 thought 5-39 in the Fundamentals book. Also, in "Preliminaries" and barre exercise # 7 on my video).

*Fondu is the beginning study of jumps on one foot; You must feel the turn out equally on both legs and engage the supporting leg's inner thigh on the rise/push from plié.

(Track #6)

A – Fondu par terre first form – Begin in 5th position right foot front – Bring the working foot into cou de pied to conditional front on the "préparation"

1 2 and 3 4 5 6 7 8

Demi-plié, deepen and straighten, relevé and lower (4X), then bring the working foot into cou de pied back and repeat again (4X). Repeat music to repeat with left foot.

- Turn-out on BOTH legs must be maintained equally at all times
- **Tracking of knee over toes must be closely monitored**
- Torso (laterals) always lifts during the plié; ***this is essentially a plié on one foot so everything in plié applies here (same cuing)***
- No twisting of torso on the relevé

B - Fondu par terre second form – sides only:

Begin in 5th position, right foot front. On the préparation, tendu the right foot to the side

And

1

Lift the working leg slightly, bring the foot into conditional front while going into a

2

3

deep demi-plié on the supporting leg, bring working toe to the floor, straighten

4

both legs simultaneously. Repeat, beginning with lifting the toe on "and".

Repeat 4X to the side (2X in cou de pied front and 2X in cou de pied back).

Repeat music to repeat to the left. Later practice 2X each direction, 1X en croix.

C - Fondu en l'air first form

Begin as per fondu par terre second form

And

1

Lift the working leg slightly, bring the foot into conditional front while going into a

2

deep demi-plié on the supporting leg, bring working leg into "attitude front" at 45°

3

4

straighten both legs simultaneously. Repeat 4X to the side (2X in cou de pied front and 2X in cou de pied back).

Repeat music to repeat to the left. Later practice 2X each direction. 1X en croix.

D - Fondu en l'air second form

Same as above but in **2 counts each** with no stops (smoothly coordinated).

And

1

Lift the working toe slightly, bring the foot into conditional front while going into a

and

deep demi-plié on the supporting leg, bring working leg into "attitude front" at 45°

2

straighten both legs simultaneously.

15- Développé and Relevé lent at 45° and at 90° (pages 5-47 through 5-54 in the Fundamentals book, and barre exercise #10 on my video).

(Track #13)

Begin with back to the barre in 1st Position:

When practicing exercises with the back to the barre the elbows should still be pointing downward toward the floor, and the torso must remain square to the barre at all times. The hips must not tilt in any direction during the extension of the leg, and turnout on BOTH legs must be maintained equally at all times. When the leg lifts the torso must also lift upward without tilting or raising the shoulders - keep them pressed down and neck "long" (**think floor exercise #4**).

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 & 8

Développé: Passé; attitude side at 45°/ 90° extend & HOLD; tendu & close to 1st

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 & 8

Relevé Lent: Tendu to side & raise leg to 45°/90° & HOLD; tendu & close to 1st

Repeat to other side, then repeat to front both sides

THEN: stand behind the barre and repeat to sides and back

*The difference between Passé from 1st position and 5th position is that from 1st position, the toe of the working foot can be to the inside of the supporting leg at the specified height for all directions. In Passé from 5th position, the toe of the working foot would either be in front or in back of the supporting leg at the specified height depending on which direction/height you were extending to: mid shin or high conditional for front, bottom of the calf or top of the calf for back - for 45° and 90° extensions respectively.

NOTE: Attitude back needs special attention as the working knee needs to feel "attached" to the opposite shoulder along with a lifted torso for stability – ALWAYS hold the opposite shoulder of the leg which is raised in attitude until the student can accomplish it consistently on their own. It is also the beginning study for the Layback Spin – so the biomechanics must be closely monitored.

14- Beginning study of jumps: Trampoline Jumps using points of the stage and with variations (See #8 centre work on my video)

This is a tremendously fun exercise, which is all about natural "Ballón" (bounce) and torso control during easy jumps. It is also used to learn points of the stage and has several "virtuoso" variations. *It is important to note that all jumps except for trampoline jumps are first learned facing the barre.*

Music: Track #25 or #26

- In the centre, everyone stands in a slightly relaxed 1st position with arms in Preparatory. Begin with 8 consecutive jumps in one count each - and a **count of 8** rests and repeat this to the end of the music using deep controlled breathing.

Make certain that excellent musicality (timing) and posture is maintained throughout (shoulders not lifting, arms not “jangling,” and feet pointed in the air with the knees pulled up).

- When the students gain proficiency at this, have them jump for 12 counts and rest for 4 counts, then jump for 16 counts etc. until stamina is gained.
- This exercise can also be done jumping 2 counts to each point of the stage – both clockwise and counterclockwise. Also, it can be practiced in groups of 2, or as a “solo” of 8 counts – have the next student count to be ready to continue without skipping a beat.
- Trampoline jumps can also be done in parallel bringing the lower legs “back” so that the feet hit near the buttocks. These jumps can also be done “dodging” front and back, and side-to-side.

2- Beginning study of 2nd Port de Bras (Track #16)

Beginning in 5th position with right foot front in croisé to point 8.

After initial “Motivating Breath”: In 16 counts total practice:

1 2 3 4

Bring arms to 1st, open arms out - left arm to 3rd and right arm to 2nd positions (this is called croisé to pointe 8 in big pose)

5 6 7 8

Bring left arm to 2nd, simultaneously move left arm to preparatory and right arm to 3rd (eyes and head follow left hand until the right hand reaches 3rd, then the gaze switches to the right hand).

1 2 3 4

Bring both arms back to 1st position and open arms out to croisé in big pose

5 6 and 7 8

Bring left arm into 2nd position, allongé both arms and lower to Preparatory.

NOTE: In this, as in all port de bras, the torso (core complex) remains STILL. The shoulders do not droop as one arm goes to preparatory and the other to 3rd position.

Homework:

Practice Many times on your own - and then teach all exercise learned in this lesson, including 2nd port de bras in croisé to both sides in correct tempo, beginning and ending with the music chosen. Video and self-critique to note what you and your students need to work on.

Lesson 11

Lessons 11 Agenda: Completion of Barre and Centre exercises for the Beginning Course: Grand Battement at 90°, Barre “stretch and strengthen”, Temps Levé and Ballet port de bras for on ice practice,

After this lesson, you should be able to understand:

A - How to raise the leg SHARPLY to at least 90° while maintaining complete whole-body LIFT, alignment and control.

B – How to balance, use whole body proprioception, as well as stretch and strengthen with one leg on the barre.

C- How to practice correctly for better aligned and higher leg extensions as well as lower back positions for spirals.

D- How to maintain correct body alignment in centre practice of développé and relevé

lent while also coordinating arms – using the entire Capital letter **“I”** core complex.

E- How to keep time in 2 foot to 2 foot jumps with arm coordination.

F- How to coordinate head, eyes, arms, and good skating technique (deep demi-pliés, strong stroke ending in a strongly pulled up knee and pointed feet EVERY TIME) in time to the music.

Completion of Barre Exercises (numbers as listed on “Ballet Lesson Syllabus”)

Your Correlative Chart should be complete for the ballet section by the next lesson

At the Barre:

16-) Grand Battement at 45°/90° in 1st and 5th position (with back to and facing barre) pages 5-55 in the Fundamentals book and Barre Exercise #11 on my video (Track #15) *As always, this exercise is about whole-body alignment, and not just leg height! PUSH into the floor with the supporting leg to get the 'working leg higher.***

Begin with back to the barre and feet in 1st position. In 4 counts each, practice to the SIDES first:

And 1 2 3 4
Raise the leg sharply to 45°/90°, pointe tendu to the floor, hold and close to 1st.

4X total, then repeat to other side 4X; then repeat to the front Right, then Left 4X
Ending with the music (64 counts total), the students then face the barre to repeat the same exercise to the side, and then to the back.

* **The torso LIFTS “in and up” every time the leg is thrown** so that there is no “counterbalancing” or wobbling. There should be no tension in the shoulders, neck, hands or arms. The working leg is “thrown” up and controlled back down to a “gently” placed tendu.

19-) Demi-plié and relevé facing and side to barre with leg on the barre and hands on waist - ending with spiral and layback spin work. (Track #2 or #16) This is a 3-part exercises for strengthening and stretching the lower back and core complex for balance, spirals and layback spins. Part 2 and Part 3 can be done later with the skate on the working foot – ONLY when the student has mastered the exercise without skates.

Part 1: Before the music begins the student places the right leg on the barre directly in front of them, perpendicular to the barre (across from the Greater Trochanter) in a completely turned out and “square” manner with hands on waist and elbows directly out to the sides. **WATCH: complete body alignment and posture!**

This exercise is 192 counts long – you may subdivide it for less accomplished skaters in order to avoid overuse and fatigue. **Only Track #16 is 192 counts long**

1 2 and 3 4 5 6 7 8
Demi-plié, DEEPEN, push to straighten, relevé and lower to flat. (4X)
On the last relevé turn the body to the side of the barre (turning on ball of foot) and lower the heel in the new position. Repeat facing side to the barre (4X) and on the last one turn back to face the barre. Place both hands on the barre on either side of the leg and head on the knee of the leg that’s on the barre (64 counts total)

THEN:

1 2 3 4 5 – 8 and a 1 2 3
Demi-plié, straighten, come up w/arms in 3rd, Lift, cambré back with head turned
4 and a 5 6 7 8
toward the side of raised leg. Lift, come up and place hands and head back into beginning position. Repeat with head turned to the other side. (2X) (32 counts total)

counts 7 8
PART 2: On the 2nd repetition - bring the leg down to 1st position and **tendu back same leg as was on the barre**

And 1 - 2
Lift torso and turn head toward the tendu leg Cambré back, HOLD torso in that
and 3 - 4 5. -
Position Lift tendu foot to 45° - keeping the banana shape come up & Penché forward
Through count 8 counts 1. - 6
Toward the barre Keep the same angle of the leg to the torso and come up, slowly lower the foot to tendu to the floor, still in cambré back and straighten torso on counts 7 & 8

Repeat with head turned the other way - and repeat again (64 counts total)

** Make sure that the torso remains square to the barre with shoulders down at all times. If this isn’t possible, the student should lower the leg until they master the movement at a lower height. Use the glutes and deep abs to hold the “banana position” while stretching the iliopsoas. **ABSOLUTELY NO “DUMPING”** the torso forward or sinking into the lower back to get the leg up higher!

PART 3 (for layback spins) –

1 2 3 4
Tendu back and relevé lent to at least 45° keeping the torso fully straight and
5 6 7. 8
lifted. Then bend the knee to a 90° angle perpendicular to the floor, hold the pose.

1 2 3 - 8 and a 1 2
Lift both hands off the barre into 3rd position, hold, look to the left and lift to cambré back
3 4 and a 5 6 7 8
and come up, repeat looking to the right. Cambré back and recover, keep arms in 3rd,
1 2 3 4 5. 6 7
extend the leg straight place hands back on the barre, lower to tendu to the floor and
7 8
close to 1st position **(2X) (32 counts total)**

Repeat the exercise with the other leg

Precision and accurate body mechanics are imperative – go slowly and observe whether students are understanding the exercises both intellectually as well as physically. Ask questions – get answers – discuss! After this exercise has been mastered you can have the students push the hips forward in part 3 *WHILE MAINTAINING SPINE LIFT AND DEEP ABDOMINAL SUPPORT!

Completion of Centre Exercises:

9- Développé and Relevé Lent at 45° and 90° with arms

Use the same music, timing and sequence as you did for the barre. Arms are coordinated as follows: Facing Point 1, Feet in 1st position, arms in preparatory - motivational breath ONLY on the Préparation.

Counts 1 2
On the Passé the arms travel from preparatory to 1st position
3 4
On the extension (to side first) of the leg the arms open to 2nd position, Hold
5 6 7 8
extension, tendu and close to 1st – **ARMS remain in 2nd for the Relevé lent:**
1 2. 3 4 5 6 7 8
Tendu side, lift to 45°, HOLD, lower to tendu and close to 1st position.

Arms: allongé on “and” and bring arms back down through preparatory on the next passé (describing counts “and” 1).

15- Temps Levé in 1st, 2nd and 5th combination (#12 Barre on my video) (Track #24)

*This jump combination should be practiced facing the barre in the same tempo. Look for aligned trajectory of whole body here before going into the centre to practice. **You can teach just 1st & 2nd to start.

Facing the barre - begin in 1st position

In 4 counts each practice:

1 and a 2 and 3 4
Demi-plié, deepen and jump, land in demi-plié, DEEPEN and straighten slowly.

5 6 7 8
Repeat **3X** then: tendu side, and lower heel and repeat in 2nd position, repeat for 5th position right, then left foot front.

Immediately repeat this combination in the centre to preserve the mind-body connection. Later on, you can place this in the centre section after the trampoline jumps.

ARMS: Préparation is motivating breath only - **arms remain in preparatory during jumps**. On the tendu to transition to the next position: Both arms come up to 1st position (count 5), open to 2nd position (counts and 6), Allongé and lower back to preparatory (counts 7 and 8).

18- Ballet Port de bras preparation for on-ice exercise (#6 Centre Exercise on my video) (Track #18) Begin at the back of the room as this exercise travels forward. Begin in a “T- stop” position with **right foot front** (eventually traveling counterclockwise around the rink) and arms in preparatory. Use **4 counts** of “motivating breath during music introduction (Préparation) **Head and eye focus are imperative*

NOTE: The demonstration of this exercise on my instructional video has the head arm and eye focus directed toward the SKATING leg. I suggest that you try it BOTH toward and away from the skating leg to gain different perspectives of the same basic movements. On Ice I recommend beginning with the LEFT foot in front so as to direct the focus toward the FREE leg as this is the easier (most familiar/comfortable) position to begin with.

Counts for arms as follows:

1 2 3 4 and a
Arms to 1st, open to 2nd, HOLD, allongé and lower to begin again (with breath!)

Counts for feet/legs as follows:

1
From the “T – stop”, slide forward on front foot (this will become a push off the back foot on the ice), to a low arabesque (or toe to the floor if the students are struggling with balance) HOLD pose (this will be the “glide”) “close” to T-stop w/ LEFT foot in front to begin again.
2 - 4 and a

Sequence – ONE time to each side first looking to LEFT then RIGHT

- A. Both arms to 1st; open to 2nd; Allongé & lower.
- B. Both arms THROUGH prep. to 1st, then opening to 3rd & 2nd, Both open 2nd; Allongé & lower.
- C. Both arms THROUGH prep. to 1st then both to 3rd: Both arms open to 2nd; Allongé & lower.
- D. Both arms THROUGH prep. to 1st one arms stays and the other goes to 3rd; open both to 2nd; Allongé & lower.

*** This exact pattern will be used on ice later on in this study using different tempos so make sure your students feel this coordination DEEPLY – from head, to eyes to fingers to toes - before moving on. LIFTED LATERAL – and rib cage parallel to the ice!*

20 – Centre Grand Battement at 45° or 90° en face to the sides from 1st and in croisé devant and croisé derrière in big pose from 5th *preserving whole body alignment and stability is of primary importance. *Use the same music and counts as for the barre. Begin “en face” (facing point 1) in 1st position. Préparation is motivating breath, arms to 1st and open to 2nd position. Arms remain in 2nd for the entire exercise – **THIS IS VERY DIFFICULT! Maintaining proper 2nd position arms is important to torso lift and core stability...don’t let the arms sag – isometric LIFT of the torso.**

Practice 8 Grand Battements to the SIDES. Then practice 4 each direction 1X en croix (both sides)

Homework:

Practice all exercise learned today including all 3 Port de bras to both sides in croisé using correct tempo, beginning and ending with the music chosen. Cueing, using hands on correction, explanations of specific importance of each exercise and what it improves in on-ice technique (meaning specific elements), as well as artistry. Teach your students and video them for verification of accuracy.

**This concludes the ballet section of the course. Everything learned so far will be incorporated or “Embodied” and tested on the ice as to comprehension of purpose and execution of good skating technique and artistry – becoming habitual throughout ALL movement, not just within the specific elements practiced.*

NOTE: Don’t forget to add all of these exercises to your Correlative Chart as they apply to the 12 floor exercises and how each of these exercises will benefit skating technique! When you begin teaching the on-ice section, you will be required to refer back to each of the floor and ballet exercises in order to integrate the techniques and methodology.

Lessons 12

Lesson 12 Agenda– Beginning “Skates On” Off-Ice Specialty Class

Origins of the “Skates-On” class and its benefits

The floor exercises in this section have been adapted from basic Pilates floor work. The exercises facing the barre were adapted from beginning “pointe work” foot and ankle strengthening exercises, physiotherapy exercises for aligning and strengthening of knee “tracking,” and skating elements. The rest of the exercises are adapted from the Beginning Level ballet exercises, which have mostly been covered in the ballet section.

With all the off-ice strength training programs utilized by skaters and coaches, it is odd to me that rarely has the skate itself ever been used as a fundamental “piece of equipment”. The advantages to using one’s own skates as a weight, considering that it’s freely available and is what the skater normally works with, are numerous to say the least. Without the distractions of speed, fear of falling/balance issues, trying to correct alignment and other detailed instruction while skating, one can much more easily focus on:

- Being able to feel the foot, ankle and lower leg in the skate – pointing and flexing
- Being able to hold the leg in a straight manner – knee straight and foot not drooping down towards the floor/ice.
- Feeling the progression of “toe, ball, heel” for jump landings – foot articulation
- Feeling the different sections of the blade on the ice, like the Toe Pick, Spin Rocker/ Sweet Spot - between the toe pick and radius - under the ball of your foot a place where you can balance and can move with the least amount of friction, most jumping and spinning involves this part of the blade, Radius/rocker (from the ball of your foot to behind your heel is the radius) and the “Tail”.
- Gaining whole body awareness of correct body alignment during leg lifts, leg rotations and whole-body coordination of complex, multiplanar movements in a musical and artistic manner.
- Gaining whole body strength in a completely efficient, aligned and effective manner with no added equipment.

****Begin with skates off and do the Awareness Exercises on pages 3-49 through 3-55 in the Fundamentals book and always do the Myofascial Massages FIRST!***

6 Floor exercises (correlates with exercises demonstrated on my video)

Beginners and those with less strength can first do these exercises without skates on – just to get the feel of correct alignment and procedure. Then, have students try at least 2-4 per session with the skates on, with brief “rests” in between each, and build from there. ****After teaching these exercises separately for several weeks without music you can combine a few using appropriately slow music from the album. Try to correlate your music choices with music used for similar exercises practiced in the ballet section - just as you did for your chart. This will help carry through the feel and intent of the training.**

Preliminary floor exercise (“C” on my video pamphlet – page 111 In this manual)

With both skates and guards on: Lie on back with legs together and straight up to ceiling (hands on waist): flex and point **SLOWLY 10X** knees pulled up, legs isometrically squeezed together and glutes tight. Walk around to each skater and make sure they are feeling knees pulled up, ankles tightly together so that their feet don’t “sickle” during the “pointe” – feel the Peroneals and Soleus (lateral lower leg muscles). This can be a very difficult exercise when done correctly but it is imperative to get them to feel and do this exercise accurately as it sets the leg and foot alignment for feeling correct “pointe” in the skate.

1-) Turn-out Exercise with leg rotations (32 counts total)

Sit on your mat and lean back on your elbows. Bend knees & turn out at the hip joints bringing your feet close to your body with heels lifted off the floor. Make sure torso is well supported (doesn’t sag).

1 2 & 3 4
Bring right leg into attitude front; turn in & turn out; extend leg straight
and 5
to side as far as possible without twisting torso; flex foot & turn in strongly at the hip
6 and 7 & 8
socket & turn out; point foot; retiré & extend side again

THEN:

4 counts per rotation

Rotate in large circles 2 en dehors and 2 en dedans one time with a flexed foot and once w/ a pointed foot (always changing from point to flex on “and”)

Bring leg back to original position and repeat all with the left leg

2-)” Criss-cross” (32 counts total)

Lie on your back with hands behind your head and bottom of shoulder blades barely touching the floor; right knee touching the **outside** of left elbow and left leg straight down to between 1’ & 2’ off the floor. Lower back should not be arched off of the floor and deep abs should be pressed toward the spine and “up” throughout the exercise. Inhale fully on the “twist” exhale fully on the HOLD and alternate pointing and flexing the feet. Laterals should be stretched fully for each side – looking back to the elbow which is behind. **GO SLOWLY**

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
Reverse position & HOLD position & repeat to other side, HOLD
Do 2 **full twists** (Lt., Rt and again Lt., Rt) in 8 counts each = 16 counts total

THEN - Repeat: 2 **full twists** in 2 counts each side (8 counts total)

End with 4 **full twists** in 1 count each side (8 counts total)

END RELAXER: both knees to chest to relax back – breathe deeply

3-) Full stretch-up and twist (64 counts total, 32 counts per part)

Part 1: Lie on back **with left leg bent to the side on the floor** and right leg straight up at an angle of c.45° **turned out** & foot strongly pointed; arms straight in front and parallel to the raised leg.

And 1
Lengthen & lift torso without moving either leg so that the whole torso is off floor
2 3 and
in a sitting position; HOLD w/ arms in 3rd then open arms out to 2nd & lengthen
4
lowering torso back down to the floor (without moving either leg) **repeat 3X**
and change 4 counts to repeat with other leg

Part 2: Right leg is now bent in parallel (knee aimed to ceiling) skate guard heel is on floor and left leg is completely straight and turned out resting on TOP of the right leg

1 2 3
Stretch up w/ arms in parallel, then in 3rd; LIFT and twist the upper body to the right opening arms to 2nd;
And 4 5 and
come back to center lifting arms to 3rd. twist to left & open arms out to 2nd; come back
6 7 and
to center with arms in 3rd; opening the arms to 2nd lengthen torso and lower in a
8
controlled manner to floor **(4X) Immediately repeat with other leg extended. End with Back Relaxer (& stand a few moments if necessary)**

** Try to keep your torso lifted, shoulders down and knees together. Turn out extended leg within the hip socket "reaching away from centre" and point the foot strongly throughout the entire exercise. Think "eccentric contractions".*

4-) On Side with Développé with Leg Rotations (64 counts total) not on video

Lie on side with upper hand on floor in front of you to stabilize, with elbow bent and other hand supporting your head; legs are slightly bent to the back and together. *Try to maintain a straight line from shoulders to knee on the floor until the stretch back from attitude.*

1 2 3 and 4
Retiré & extend side up toward the ceiling without losing alignment; flex and point
5 and 6
Flex again & lower leg out in front of you to about 6 inches off the floor; pressing the
7 and 8
floor leg into the floor for leverage, lift the top leg to the ceiling again and point.

THEN:

1 and 2 3 4
Retiré, flex and push heel to ceiling to straighten leg & pointe; retiré again, and
5 6
attitude leg back & straighten leg back (stretch same arm as leg forward to counter-
7 8
balance). attitude again & arch to look back
and A
Put your hand back on floor and rond leg to side again extend to ceiling.

In 4 counts each, rotate leg 2X en dedans (down to floor, around and up to ceiling, once with a pointed foot and once with a flexed foot; and 1X en dehors with a pointed foot and

Immediately switch side to repeat all with the other leg

*Try to keep the foot of the leg on floor from lifting during exertion

5-) Reverse Crunch and spiral work (64 counts total) – please see instructional video exercise # 5)

Begin on “all fours” and extend right leg back in turn-out, and left arm straight in front of you. Beginners can keep both hands on the floor for added support. This exercise utilizes concentric and eccentric contractions.

1 2 and 3 4
Crunch in touching head to knee and extend w/leg turned out on the extension – reach away from centre (both working leg and arm)!

5 - 8 1 2 and 3 4
Do a side extension and return (4X) Place free hand on floor & do ‘up and overs” (toe lowered right in front of supporting arm hand and lifting back up directly from there.)

And 5 6,7 8
Bend knee to an "Attitude" position and drop and lift knee 2X (to relax the hip joint) then lift to

And a
attitude & extend leg straight to repeat the Up and over again ending with the knee drop on attitude.

THEN: Place your forehead on mat with working leg **straight** down to mat and do **4 grand battements** in **2 counts each = 8 counts total**

On count 8 1 2 - 8
to the back HOLD the last kick up high, bring head up & torso arched go to attitude back & extend HOLD &

End with child pose and deep breathing and Repeat Music to repeat all to other side

STAND AND SHAKE OUT LEGS WHEN DONE

**Of course, each student has very different capabilities but in general for the first 6 months to a year of consistent classes do not try to lift the free leg higher than hip level coming across the front of the body. During grand battements the lower back should NOT arch, and working leg should be directly in line with shoulder.*

6-) Scissors (changement de pieds) with flex and point (64 counts total)

Begin on your back with both legs up to ceiling in turn-out with feet strongly pointed, knees straight and hands on waist. Relax neck and shoulders throughout the exercise...keep the tension (power) in the deep rotators, gluteals and inner thighs. Concentrate the crossing of the legs at mid-thigh.

Criss-cross the legs 6X opening the legs to a small "V" and crossing the legs on the beat. Open the legs to the widest "V" possible on count 7 THEN: FLEX FEET on **count 8 and repeat - Alternating flex and point every 8 counts (4X – 32 counts total)**

THEN: **4 counts** straight of changement with no stops, **4 in flex & 4 in point (4X = 32 counts)**

ENDING (No Music): place both feet on floor and roll up torso (lift hips as high off the floor as possible) **8 counts** and lower (roll down) **8 counts and repeat**

**Tighten gluteals throughout to maintain turn-out and keep deep abs strongly engaged (below navel to spine)*

Barre Exercises with skates on

Facing the barre with skates on (same as “barre at the boards” pages 5-60 through 5-62 in the Fundamentals book and barre exercise # 1 on my video

***This exercise will be repeated at the boards where you can discuss the different parts of the blade, what each part does, and how to feel them correctly. ***

CAUTION: with certain types of newer boots designed specifically for triple jumps, the plié on the toe pick is not recommended.

1-) Demi-plié and relevé facing the barre (128 counts)

Face the barre in 6th position with both skates & guards on.

1 2 3 4 5 - 7 and 8

(A) Demi-plié & push to straighten & relevé HOLD & lower (2X)

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

(B) Demi-plié & straighten; relevé & hold; demi-plié in relevé & straighten & lower (2X)

Repeat with legs in small 2nd parallel Feet directly under hip sockets, knees MUST stay parallel to toes during all pliés – be acutely aware on the “push to rise” as the knees tend to “cave in”!

THEN: Repeat (A) and (B) 1X each with free leg in:

Cou de pieds back; then

Extended to side at 45°; then

Extended to back at 45°

Repeat with other leg

****Hips should be square to the barre at all times with working leg well turned out at the hip and foot strongly pointed. Supporting leg is still in parallel but the glutes are strongly engaged with knees over toes. Lift out of hips – plié always goes in 2 directions – it is an eccentric contraction!*

2-) Stroking exercise at the barre – (64 counts)

Begin Facing the barre with feet in parallel

1 2 3

Demi-plié, turn left leg/foot to a “T-stop” position, begin to straighten the left leg

4 5

by pushing heel of left foot strongly into floor, lift pointed straight leg to 45° and take

6 7 8 and a

arms off barre into 2nd position HOLD position, and return to beginning position to repeat to other side. This is a long piece of music - begin with 8 repetitions and increase with proficiency

*Keep the back straight, head up, with shoulders down and open, maintain strong torso lift, deep demi-plié with a well turned-out free leg and pointed foot. *Do not allow the free leg heel off the floor until after count 4. You can also do this as a “continuous flow” remaining in the demi-plié position throughout – just make sure that the buttocks doesn’t stick out on the return.*

3-) Cross Cuts exercise at the Barre (64 counts)

Begin facing the Barre, feet together in parallel (sixth position)

On “and” (of count 1)

Cross the right leg over the left, as if beginning a backward crossover.

1 2 3
Demi – Plié and slowly drag the pinky toe side of the left skate behind you at a
4
45° angle (still on the floor - like the undercut push of a back crossover) keeping light
5
pressure on the floor for as long as you can; then straighten and extend the free-leg
6
slightly above the floor to your finished back cross over position bringing your arms
7 8
into 2nd position to balance and come back to both feet in parallel and knees straight

Repeat 8 times alternating sides (both right and left side counting as one time) making sure your under-push leg reaches full extensions while you maintain a deep plié.

Note** On the ice, you will end up slightly sickling your foot on the under-push leg as you extend in order to utilize the full blade when you push. This is one of the rare times slightly sickling, instead of engaging your peroneals, is preferred on the ice. This is to avoid hitting the toe pick and allows you to utilize the full power of the edge.

Take LEFT skate off and continue using Left hand on the barre: Supporting leg is the leg with the skate off – working leg is the leg with the skate on.

4-) Dégagé to 45° with flex and point with one hand on barre*(64 counts)

Préparation: Standard – in 4 counts – from preparatory to demi-second, back to preparatory, then arm to 1st and open out to 2nd) arm remains in 2nd throughout exercise.

Both legs well turned out beginning in “3rd “(front knee is bent)

1 2 3 4 and 5
Dégagé leg front to 45°; flex, turn in; turn out; point; Demi-plié sup. Leg (lift
6 7 8
skate leg slightly) & carry leg to side; Straighten supporting Leg & lower to floor (either tendu to the floor w/leg straight OR back to original 3rd position w/front leg bent)

END with the working leg ending in the original pose (3rd position w/front knee bent). Again, this is a long piece of music - when the student becomes more proficient you can add repetitions OR repeat with the leg at a higher leg level (but no higher than 90°)

*Be strongly aware of whole-body alignment, as this is not just about the free leg.
When mastery over whole body alignment has been achieved at 45°,
practice at 90°.*

For the next exercise, place your back to the barre to practice legs side and front, and facing the barre for legs side and back

5-) Développé and Relevé Lent to 45° and 90° with demi - grand rond de jamb

The word “Lent” means “slow” - raising the straight leg slowly (**64 counts**)

Begin with back to the barre in strong turnout in “3rd” position (front knee is bent)

1, 2 3 4 5 6 7 & 8

Practice to side: Retiré; turn in; turn out & attitude, extend SIDE & lower to floor

1 - 2 3 4 5 & 6

NEXT: Relevé lent side to 45° & carry FRONT & HOLD (Flex & pointe)

7 8

Lower to tendu front. Repeat above beginning to the FRONT and repeat ALL from the beginning (**2x total**)

REPEAT MUSIC TO FACE BARRE to REPEAT ALL to SIDE and BACK.

Reminder to feel the opposite shoulder of the raised knee to feel “attached” in the attitude, while the torso is lifted in and up for support.

* The above exercise can be adapted for centre work for students who have mastered it (meaning able to easily maintain “aplomb”) at the barre.

6-) ONE HAND ON BARRE Développé and demi-grand rond and grand rond de jamb at 90° with pieds dans la mains (only for more advanced students) Similar to exercise #4 in the skates on section of the Instructional Video (Track #17**)**

Préparation: Standard **Begin Well** turned out in 3rd

1 2 3 4 and 5

Développé to front in demi-plié & HOLD; Straighten, and Grand rond de jamb en dehors

6 and 7

At 90° to arabesque. Demi-plié supporting leg while raising arabesques let even higher;

and 8

straighten supporting leg & lower extended leg foot to the floor.

Repeat en dedans – and repeat all again

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

Practice Pied dans la main front & extend/hold, release and SLOWLY lower to tendu front

1 - 8 1 - 8 and

Repeat side; then hold knee & extend back to Penché & come up (still in arabesque)

1 - 8 1 - 8

Face barre and practice Penché again with skate foot in line with top of head (view from mirror) come up & go into **attitude & hold w/head back.**

END: tendu side & Cambré side and other side to relax

Make certain that all alignment is accurate and that you are not leaning away from the free leg. When 45° is mastered try the exercise at 90° keeping torso lifted and vertical. The above exercises will be hard on the hip flexors if you do not fully engage the glutes to hold turnout.

❖ **TAKE RIGHT SKATE OFF and repeat exercises with Left skate on beginning with barre exercise #3**

6-) ENDING RELAXER/STRETCH FOR SKATES ON CLASS (music of your choice)

On back with legs up straight to ceiling and slightly open do:

In 1 count each

8 ankle rotations outward

8 ankle rotations inward

Pinwheel pose right leg front: bend forward 2 counts & come up 2 counts backward 2 counts & come up 2 counts

Bend side (toward the front leg) 2 counts & other side 2 counts

Change legs and repeat all 4 bends

Go into straddle with arms in 2nd and do:

flex feet and bend knees 2 counts & straighten & point 2 counts **(2X)**

End: feet together and knees bent out to sides curl forward, head to feet and elbows on thighs just above knees.

Homework:

1-) Practice these Skates-on exercises by yourself without music first to get a feel for them. Then, choose music at a suitably slow speed and incorporate all the counts evenly on both sides of the body. You can vary the repetitions but try to keep the tempos and counts as written. **Use relevant technical cues!**

2-) Teach your students **with no music first** (some of them may need to begin without skates on as these exercises are difficult)

3-) Correlate all these exercises to the Vaganova floor exercises, the Ballet exercises and * specific* on-ice applications – naming specific elements.

Reminder that cues and correlations should be BIOMECHANICAL not CHOREOGRAPHIC and specifically directed toward skating technique. Continually refer to the movements learned both in the Vaganova floor exercises as well as the ballet exercises. The most important aspect of these exercises is IMPRINTING accurate Neuromuscular patterns so that the basics of good technique are ingrained into the student. In the long run this will enable the student to essentially “work smarter not harder” preventing injuries and a skater whose artistry is genuinely intrinsic.

Lesson 13

Lesson 13 On-ice Class Objectives: To correlate and translate every movement and exercise learned off-ice onto the ice while feeling everything within the students' BODY and MIND.

Essentially the physical and verbal manifestation of your “Correlative Chart”

After this chapter, you should be able to understand:

- How & why Floor exercises help body awareness, strength, flexibility, posture and alignment.
- How & why Pliés increase awareness of deep “soft knees” in all skating movements, general rhythm & flow of movement, posture, jump entrances and landings.
- How & why Relevés, Battement tendus and tendu Jetés improve the line and stretch of the free leg and foot, as well as increase power in jump take offs.
- How & why Rond de jamb par terre improves maintenance of turn-out during transition moves.
- How & why Fondu par terre and en l’air develops strength and flow of movement on one leg while maintaining good posture.
- How and why Développé and Relevé lent develops both strength and flexibility in the lower back and laterals for better spirals, camel spins and extensions in general.
- How and why finger grouping, hand training, port de bras with simultaneous head and eye coordination (Épaulement) improves complete artistic body lines and shapes (not just a “nice leg line”) expressiveness, musicality, and total body coordination

**** HERE IS WHERE YOU FIND OUT WHETHER YOU HAVE “EMBODIED THE WORK,” both in theory and in practice!**

Success in the application of the method will be made evident here. If you have not been applying and thinking toward the end goal on a regular basis, (on-ice continuity), then it will fall apart.

****What we want to see is Structurally Different Skating at this point - not just choreographically, but within the mind and body of the skater. ****

Section 1 - Barre at the Boards (foot & leg internal warm-up)

***1-) Facing the boards – Demi-plié and relevé on two & one foot**

Same as the skates-on barre exercise #1

Make sure that skaters are as high as possible on their toe picks with knees pulled up, and their seats don't stick out for the demi-plié en relevé!

- Here is where you can further discuss the different segments of the blade, what they are for, and how they should feel:

Feeling the different sections of the blade on the ice: Toe pick, Spin Rocker or Sweet Spot, Between the toe pick and radius, about under the ball of your foot a place where you can balance and can move with the least amount of friction. Most jumping and spinning involves this part of the blade. And the Radius or Rocker (from the ball of your foot to behind your heel is the radius).

***2-) Stroking and Cross-Over Exercises – Facing the boards**

Same as the skates-on barre exercises #2 & #3 in lesson 12 of this manual

Be careful with the push back so you don't crash into the boards! This is just a reminder to keep the heel down as long as possible on the stroke and to feel correct posture.

***3 - Déagé with flex and point to front, side & back (one hand on the boards)**

Same as the skates-on barre exercise #3 (Barre at the Boards page 5-61 of Fundamentals book.

1 2 3 4 and 5 6 7

Déagé front & flex; turn in; turn out & point; demi-plié; carry leg to side & straighten and

8

lower free leg to ice in turn out [free leg foot is now relaxed and perpendicular to the supporting foot. Repeat 1X en croix and repeat all to other side.

*Make certain the body does not twist during the demi-rond and that the free leg foot is strongly flexed and pointed.

4 –(Advanced) Degagé to grand fouetté at 90° (beginners at 45°)

Begin in parallel with LEFT hand on the barrier and right arm in 2nd

and a 1 2

Lift RIGHT leg FRONT to 45° in turnout, demi-plié on left leg (which remains in parallel)

3 4 5 and a

straighten; demi-plié again, deepen, push to straighten sharp to relevé on toe pick turning quickly toward the barrier (release arm on barre) and continuing to other

6 7 8

side “Land” holding arabesque in deep demi-plié [as for jump landing] with free arm (which is now the LEFT arm) in 2nd and RIGHT hand on the barrier.

Repeat to other side and repeat all again – when proficient turn with a small jump.

DEEP Demi-plié! Knee tracking and posture - watch that the lower back does not sink on the demi-pliés and “landings” of the grand fouetté. Point feet! Can also be done without the turn and as a real jump (sauté).

Section 2 - Center Ice Basic Stroking and crossovers

*For this section use beanbags and cups of water for posture & alignment with a focus on correct leg and foot lines: turn out, straight leg – foot pointed and not dropping to the ice etc. The free leg should be extended at 45° during all forward stroking.

Always thinking Eccentric Contractions – away from your center!

**** Music suggestions for this section are just that – suggestions.** A rule is that you always pick slower music for beginners so that the details of the movement are not lost. Music choices will become clearer to you as you become more proficient at discerning tempos and keys which reflect both the feeling and intent of the exercises, as well as take into account your student's ability to simultaneously “juggle” all of the technical requirements.

***1-Stroking and cross overs with beanbags and cups of water – even counts for stroking** (Track #14, or #16 for beginners and Track #8 for more proficient students) push on count one and hold through to the end of count 2.

Place a beanbag securely on the top of student's head & have them hold a plastic cup in each hand $\frac{3}{4}$ full of water with arms FULLY stretched out to sides and practice stroking:

1X around the rink counterclockwise & immediately repeat **1X** clockwise

- Posture & smooth level stroking technique (maintaining a deep demi-plié on skating side, no spilling water & no dropping the bean bag off the head!).
- Free leg completely stretched back, turned out with foot well pointed every time, and continually outstretched arms in “2nd” (no sagging at the elbows!).
- Appropriate arm can come forward during cross-overs but the arms **MUST** stay perfectly straight.

****Have them focus on feeling the arms stretch from the mid-spine and sternum while lifting the laterals****

***2-Stroking and cross over warm-up with bean bags and cups of water - varied counts**

1X around the rink counterclockwise & immediately repeat **1X** clockwise

1 (2,3) & 2 (2,3) 3 (2,3) & 4 (2,3) ...etc
Initial push off or stoke & hold position & stroke & stroke ...etc

**Make certain that posture & good alignment is held throughout (watch shoulders!), that the plié remains deep and the extended leg straight, turned out with the foot strongly pointed. Just as in ballet class, as things get more complicated the details can get lost!*

3 - Forward cross overs around hockey circles with bean bags and cups of water (Reminder: Always choose SLOWER music for less advanced students)

Begin with 4 students spaced evenly around a hockey circle facing counterclockwise in a T stop with **left foot front** and bean bag on the top of the head while holding cups of water, arms outstretched (right arm front and left arm back, chest to centre of circle)

Préparation: demi-plié

1 full crossover (2 strokes) per every 2 beats of music 4X around the hockey circle then travel to adjacent hockey circle and repeat exercise clockwise, turning upper body and arms in the opposite direction. When proficient, repeat all doing backward crossovers.

**This should be taken as both a fun as well as experimental exercise. Ask afterward what this exercise showed them about their own body awareness etc.*

Section 3 – Epaulement, Port de Bras & Poses of the Body Exercises:

*This section correlates with centre ballet exercise #18 in this coaches' manual (p.40) and exercise #6 on my video "Ballet port de bras preparation for on-ice exercise" the student must maintain the correct posture/alignment and leg and foot line as the previous exercises, adding Classical Port de Bras with all correct épaulement. **Head & eye focus must always be included.** The head direction and eye gaze are to the same side as the free leg. Watch posture, neck and shoulder tension.*

***1- Port de Bras Exercise ONE (arm pattern "A") Around the rink both ways**

As per exercise #18 in Lesson 11 of this Manual (Track #18)

❖ **REMEMBER "ÉPAULEMENT"!** At this point it should be integrated into the students' every movement – eyes and head able to follow hands without losing balance.

Begin in T-stop position - Right foot front going counter-clockwise, arms in preparatory.

Préparation: motivating breath ***Head and Eye gaze is always to the free leg side.**

And Count 1

On the push off both arms to 1st head and eyes are trained on the LEFT HAND,

Counts 2 3

on the glide open both arms to 2nd Head and eyes continue to left side,

4

allongé both arms in 2nd Head and eyes focus slightly upward, lift/breathe and straighten.

and

5

skating leg, then lower arms to preparatory on the demi-plié to push off on RIGHT foot and repeat using head and eye focus to the RIGHT. Repeat **2X** around the rink

Stop and repeat music and repeat all clockwise

***2- Port de Bras Exercise TWO (Arm pattern “B”)**

Begin in T-stop position - Right foot front going counterclockwise *Préparation:* motivating breath (both arms) **4 arm movements/positions per glide.**

On the push off both arms to 1st; on the glide, LEFT arm to 3rd, right arm open to 2nd;

Left arm opens to 2nd; allongé both arms in 2nd and straighten skating knee.

Slowly lower to preparatory, demi-plié to repeat push off on RIGHT foot and repeat **1X** around the rink. Repeat to other direction.

***3- Port de Bras Exercise THREE (Arm pattern “C”)**

Repeat previous exercise with BOTH arms going up to 3rd position on count 2 with head and eye gaze alternating left then right.

***4- Port de Bras Exercise FOUR (Arm pattern “D”)**

Repeat previous exercise with one arm remaining in 1st while the other goes to 3rd; then both arms open out to 2nd position, Allongé and repeat to the right.

***5- Port de bras exercise changing stroking frequency during port de bras**

(Track #22)

Begin in a T stop position - RIGHT foot front with arms in preparatory; *Préparation:* motivating breath.

First, try only the stroking pattern - arms can remain in 2nd position:

1 (2,3) & 2 (2,3) & 3 (2,3); 4 (2,3); and 5 (2,3) 6 (2,3) & 7 (2,3); 8 (2,3)

Stroke & hold position & stroke, stroke and stroke & hold position & stroke; stroke etc.
(Left) (Right), (Left) and (Right) (Left), (Right)

Then, continue with this pattern of stroking throughout using arm patterns A, B, C & D and changing arms every 2 counts.

(A) Arms to 1st on first stroke & open to 2nd on the hold & allongé on second stroke and 3rd stroke and slowly lower to preparatory on count “and” before 5 or 1 to repeat to the other side.

(B) Arms go to 1st on first stroke; right arm lifts to 3rd and left arm opens to 2nd on the hold; on the ensuing 2 strokes (counts 3 & 4) right arm opens to 2nd; allongé both arms (gaze is lifted up on the same side for allongé) and lower to preparatory to repeat to other side.

(C) Repeat again with both arms going to 1st then 3rd, then opening to 2nd, allongé and lowering back to preparatory on count “and” before 5 or 1

(D) Repeat with right arm staying in 1st while left goes to 3rd, both arms open to 2nd Allongé and lowering back to preparatory on count “and” before 5 or 1

1X around rink then repeat 1X clockwise

***6- Port de bras around hockey circles**

(Track #8)

Begin on hockey circle facing counterclockwise in a T stop with RIGHT foot front (inside edge) and both arms in preparatory Préparation: motivation breath & then demi-plié

One stroke of the cross-over per beat and one arm movement per stroke – for beginners, gaze is always to hand on inside of circle.

1 2 3 4 and

(A) Arms to 1st; arms open to 2nd; allongé and lower back to preparatory **(4X)** then travel to adjacent circle and repeat going clockwise – change head and eye gaze to the right.

1 2 3 4 and

(B) Arms to 1st; left arm to 3rd and right arm to 2nd: left arm to 2nd allongé & lower to prep.

(4X) then travel to adjacent circle and repeat going clockwise – change head and eye gaze to the right.

1 2 3 4 and

(C) Arms to 1st; both arms to 3rd, arm to 2nd allongé & lower to prep. **(4X)** then travel to adjacent circle and repeat going clockwise – change head and eye gaze to the right.

1 2 3

(D) Arms to 1st, right arm staying in 1st while left goes to 3rd, both arms open to

4

2nd Allongé and lower back to preparatory

Repeat 4X around the hockey circle and then skate to the other adjacent hockey circle to repeat the exercise going clockwise beginning LEFT foot front and looking to the right.

- ❖ Make certain that skaters stay on the hockey circle line, as there is a tendency to converge. When proficient at practicing this exercise individually, you can combine all 4 in one direction before moving on to the adjacent hockey circle.
- ❖ Later the exercise can be practiced doing backward crossovers.

7 – (Advanced) Port de bras exercise around hockey circles varying stroking frequency. Begin facing counterclockwise perpendicular to the boards in at T stop position left foot front with arms in preparatory; Préparation: motivating breath

Practice each section in **16 counts** around the circle – **same port de bras patterns (A, B, C and D) as previous exercise**

- ❖ First practice exercise at an even tempo **one stroke per 4 counts**
- ❖ Then practice holding the second count and stroking on counts 3 & 4
- ❖ Then Incorporate backward cross overs, spirals, lunges and Ina Bauers using the same 4 count arm pattern **moving to hockey circle at opposite end of the rink** to begin repeating exercise skating clockwise.

Suggestions on ways to do this: In **16 counts** traveling to a hockey circle at the other end of the rink continue stroking and into a spiral using same initial arm movements (1st to 3rd) then go into a spiral on a flat in 1st arabesque until you reach the other hockey circle to continue in the opposite direction. **Don't forget to change arms.**

Or, use the 2 hockey circles at one end of the ice (**in 8 counts**), then on the spiral, have students travel to the hockey circle at the opposite end of the ice, reversing the direction around the circle to repeat clockwise. Place a student who feels confident about the exercise in "front" of the line leading off to the next hockey circle. ***Please see diagram on page 131 of this manual: "Continuous Flow Port de Bras"**

REMINDER: Try to resist the temptation to do this merely as a piece of choreography! Without the internal work it will just look like everyone else – and this definitely is not our goal!

8 - 2nd and 3rd Port de Bras in an exercise around rink (both ways) **

(Track #14 or Track #12)

First have students review port de bras 1-3 with music just standing on the ice (or better yet, just before on-ice practice begins)

- Then have them practice 3rd port de bras in a **repeating 8 count combination** (a spiral or lunge can be used for the Cambré forward in 3rd port de bras and lunge or an Ina Bauer can be used for the Cambré back)
- Then have them practice the 2nd port de bras in a **repeating 4 or 8 count combination**: this will be very tricky as keeping one's balance while looking down and then quickly looking up while traveling is very difficult. Use consecutive 3 turns, "progressives/cross rolls" various MIF to achieve this directive. As long as it FLOWS and all épaulement (FROM THE INSIDE OUT) is in place go for it.
- Lastly put **all three-port de bras** into a continuous flow of movement across the ice - as in an improvisational presentation using all appropriate edges, stretched legs and feet and correct head and eye gaze with finger groupings!

****For this section, please see Diagram #1 on page 130 for consecutive 3 turns using 2nd port de bras and Diagram #2 on page 131 for continuous flow of port de bras using the whole sheet of ice.**

Section 4 General Center including Jumps and Spins

1- (Advanced) Continuous flow Temps lié en Avant on Ice*

(Track #18)

“Temps Lié” is a set series of connected steps in coordination with arm movements and transfer of weight which tests the students’ ability to simultaneously shift weight from one foot to the next while using specific arms and head patterns.

The exercise below has 2 options: All going in the same direction OR changing feet each time through. (Arm directions are in blue parenthesis below footwork)

Begin at one end of the rink in a T stop with left foot in front and arms in preparatory Préparation: motivating with arms

Push off on a Left Outside Forward edge bringing Right leg through cou de pied to front 45°

(Repeat motivating breath arms and then bring both arms to 1st on count 1)

Step to Right Inside Forward edge extending the left leg to the back at 45°
(Bring left arm up to 3rd and right arm to 2nd)

and pivot to Right Outside Back edge (essentially a right inside 3 turn)
Option – inside or outside edge here:

Choctaw to Left Forward Inside edge OR Left Forward Outside edge (Mohawk)

– bringing right leg to the side - either from the front (open “en dehors”) or from the back (closed as for Choctaw) – *whichever feels more natural to you.*
(Bring left arm down to 1st **Head and eyes following** – and open left arm to 2nd)

Continue with same side bringing right leg through to 45 ° to repeat
(Bring both arms down to preparatory and then back into position on “one”)

** The upper body movements, head and **eye gaze** directions should be identical to those used in temps lié practiced in the classroom. Extended leg should be well turned out with foot strongly pointed. Each push off should be strong in order to hold the pose. The transitions should be very smooth. Practice this exercise in **4 counts**.*

2-(Advanced) Fondu en l'air with extension side to a spiral in 1st and 2nd arabesque (Track # 6) Begin at one end of the rink in a T stop position with right foot front, arms in preparatory ***A very strong PUSH in needed on the initial glide***

Préparation: motivating breath only

And 1 2 3
On a flat glide forward extending left leg back; fondu bringing left leg to cou de pieds back (Arms open directly to 2nd; then to prep. on fondu through 1st & open to 2nd on extension)

4 5 6
Straighten skating leg & extend left leg side to 45°, THEN turn body to right ¼ turn (On the turn to arabesque arms stay as torso turns & end up in 1st arabesque position)

7 8
into an arabesque position [right leg will be on a forward outside edge]; raise left leg high (at least 90°) into a spiral with arms in 1st arabesque position.

and
Come up bringing left leg front to repeat to other side.
(Lower arms to preparatory to continue)

Repeat turning ¼ turn in the opposite direction to an inside edge and taking the arms to 2nd arabesque.

****Arms and épaulement are exactly as for fondu; gaze is to same arm as working leg for fondu. The push off needs to be very strong or the rest of the exercise will be at a standstill. This exercise travels down the long axis of the rink.***

***3 - Jumps with arm variations**

(No music, but count out loud – later add music so that the skater must count the entrance footwork, jump and exit using 8 counts of the music – Track #27)

3 different single jumps of your choosing with **2 different arm positions during the checkout as per port de bras we have studied** per type of jump. Prep. is **2 counts** the jump is on **count 3**, land on **count 4** and hold the landing a full **4 counts** so that the positions are clearly visible. **Timing and placement of counts can vary depending on the jump chosen. For example you may need 4 counts for the prep/entrance, jump on count “and 5” land on count 6 hold 7 and 8.**

Looking for:

- No pre-rotation on any jump
- Good overall understanding and execution of: **whole body line, lift in the torso head position, eye focus to pointed foot with stretched leg at 45° (at least) on the landing and musicality.**
- Port de bras chosen is in correct correlation to edges so that the “check out” flows – including head and eye focus.

***4 - Spins with arm variations**

(No music, but count out loud – later add music for the entrance footwork, spin and exit using 16 counts of the music – Track #11)

3 different spins (Same as above) but do the port de bras **DURING the spins as follows:** 2 varying arm positions WITHIN the spin and **one** on the checkout. Looking for correct head position on the check out and TRY for correct head positions DURING the spin.

4 counts for the prep, 4 counts for the spin, 4 counts for the check out, and 4 counts to “regroup”

Eye and head focus must be present during the arm changes!

A choreographed piece: around 2 minutes long to any music without words.

Must be WELL thought out, using as many of the techniques and exercises learned in this course. Include as many port de bras, correct use of épaulement, finger groupings, head and eye focus. Barre and centre exercises, with precision TO the music, and beginning and ending WITH the music. Utilize skating footwork, spins, lunges, and single jumps, with good stretch (down to the toes!), deep knee bends and fluid control throughout.

THE GOAL: The course’s goals should be “embodied” in this piece so that it is no longer a matter of “choreography,” but has become part of intrinsic skating technique. Students should show improved whole-body alignment, coordination of arms, head and eye focus. Deep connection with multiplanar movement, LIFTED torso, strong leg extension with energy, and strong pointe/turn out with fluid DEEP demi-plies during stroking and crossovers. They should have a completely stretched free leg on forward crossovers that are SLOW and deliberate – as in ice dancing. Lastly – flow of movement between footwork, jumps and spins so that “set up” time between elements is greatly diminished - showing strength, flexibility and efficient breathing and moving.

Becoming the Music - "Tasting the Steps" exercises

This section describes the bringing out of emotion and feel of a piece of music so that skaters "become the music" through their entire body.

Exercises (do and describe)

1-) What are your favorite elements in skating? How do they "taste," and how do they make you feel? (Pick 4 elements)

Each favorite element should be done several times SLOWLY in order to contemplate and savor the movement through the entire body:

- How does the movement as a whole make you feel? Why?
- Take apart the element and concentrate on feeling. Describing each part of the movement.
- What other sensations come to mind when you perform this movement? Colors? Memories? Imagination (like flying, swimming, etc.)? Tastes?

In order to connect emotionally with movement, it has to be slow enough to "register" in the human psyche, then that will become the leading factor in the ability to connect.

2-) Now pick 4 elements you don't particularly like and describe those impressions. Why do you dislike them? Are they difficult? Too fast to enjoy? Do they not feel like they are part of your personality or what you want to say?

3-) Projecting the music requires whole body engagement, not just passively listening or merely using facial expressions and arms. Work with a variety of tempos, styles, and pieces of music to get the skater to "contemplate" more on experiencing movement as a comprehensive, whole-body process. This will help the skater project the feeling of the music more clearly.

Working with your student's program:

- First, without your music - Taste the steps (elements) very slowly – feel them in your whole body
- Next - Listen to a portion (maybe 15 –20 seconds) of your music and taste the music – feel it while just listening (no movement)
- Put it together – movement, sensations and music.
- Do this for the entire program over a period of a few weeks (c.15- 20 second of music at a time)

This process will create a much greater mind body connection than would otherwise be experienced as there is time to contemplate – **process** and experience the gamut of sensations possible.

*** If we can't acknowledge, feel and describe the feeling – it can't be projected.**

PROJECTION requires IMPARTATION

The Value of Studying Pedagogy

By: Annette T. Thomas

Definition of Pedagogy: “The act, process and art of imparting knowledge. The art and science of instructional methodology.”

Many coaches and movement instructors in America teach what and how they remember their teachers teaching them. Even professional dancers usually teach what they remember having been taught. Often, movement trainers do workshops to learn “tips & tricks” on how to improve skills and technique. Many others take college courses and even get degrees in dance, but very few have actually taken courses in Pedagogy. This promulgates misconceptions of what a teaching “method” might be, but is not an actual teaching method itself. You can ask coaches and ballet instructors alike “what method do you teach” and there will usually be a dissembling of comments about their teacher or that they teach “a bit of this and that” garnered from their experiences rather than the name of an actual Method being taught.

In addition, having a Syllabus is not the same as having a Curriculum, and having a Curriculum is not the same as having the Pedagogical understanding of when to teach, how to teach, and in what manner to teach **the unique individual** who comes into your classroom. Pedagogy teaches you HOW to approach the student:

- At their correct mental and physical developmental stage
- At their appropriate learning pace
- No matter what their body type
- With understanding of biomechanical markers to look for
- No matter what their learning style may be

Without pedagogy, we tend to teach close to how we learned, which ends up being a slower, randomly broken-down process as the individual teacher improvises to get “good results.” This approach merely teaches the outward appearance of a movement and disregards the building block process that a Methodology imparts. Methodology, on the other hand, forms an intelligent, aware and self-motivated learner. In the dance and sports world, this is why few but the very gifted actually become “world-class,” *because the understanding and impartation of the full pedagogical process is missing.*

Ballet pedagogy provides the understanding of a truly methodological process for professional training “from the inside out” - not merely the choreography (appearance) of the movement, but the science (biomechanics, and kinesiology) behind the movements. It takes into account the entire development of the dancer/artist/sports person through every point of their progress - mentally, physically and emotionally - in a comprehensive and methodical manner.

Pedagogy courses demonstrate that teaching movement is not just about teaching choreographic “end form” exercises slowed down, but that there is an *entire progression of actual “forms”* - backward engineered from all final form movements, and that these forms are broken down in a logical and biomechanically sound progression from A, leading to B, leading to C. It is also not based on the “feel good” personality/popularity of the instructor but, on the artistic authenticity and scientific veracity of the materials being imparted. *This is why so many American ballet companies in particular get their principal dancers from other countries and not their own company schools, because “hit or miss” teaching by former dancers or even dance majors who have never studied true methodology cannot consistently create professional dancers.*

Studying Ballet Pedagogy:

- Provides a blueprint of each form of each step in the entire repertoire when it is physically and mentally appropriate to teach each one.
- Provides a clear understanding of each individual part of a step so that, in its final form, it will always be “clean” (not trying to clean things up after the fact).
- Is “age appropriate” meaning that at every level the students find the lessons to be an approachable challenge while still providing elements of creativity and self-expression.
- Gives the teacher and the student confidence in both the process and the outcome.
- Is not randomly based on current local/insular teaching standards, but on a global scale of valuation, where every student can be confident of “fitting in” perfectly, anywhere in the world in the same class level to which they have attained locally.

Self-test

After you have completed the course and taken notes on your observations of what you need to improve, you can test yourself by working on the below suggestions in a timely manner. This process should be at an even pace so as to absorb all that you have learned and are still learning. Always keep in mind that this is an ongoing PROCESS and what is being established here is a unified mentality toward technical training which incorporates both science and somatic. The goal is to “become” the correlative chart so that each exercise is recognized to contain information important to the whole of training.

This test can be repeated every so often as your capabilities grow. If you keep your video recordings, you can see the progress you’ve made in your teaching skills, which can be very encouraging and informative.

1-) Complete the Correlative Teaching Chart Listing of ALL 12 Vaganova Floor exercises associated/translated from floor, to barre, to centre work, to skates on, to on-ice practice.

2-) Combine 2 to 3 of the 12 Preliminary Vaganova Floor Exercises into cohesive “combinations” to appropriate music. Use accurate counting and cuing for corrections, both verbal and “hands on.” Do this for all 12 exercises.

3-) Compose and teach a complete ballet lesson employing all exercises learned in this course. Create a *fully* written out lesson plan including counts and technical cueing **which will also keep the student “on the music.”** Some exercises can be combined, such as pliés, relevés and cambrés all in one piece, or tendu and tendu jeté in 1st and 5th in one piece, as long as the exercises remain symmetrical in the repetitions given as well as “type” of exercise. For example, you wouldn’t combine pliés with Jetés or grand battement as they have a different purpose and “character.”

4-) Choose a portion of the “Skates On” off-ice Lesson

ANY 3 floor exercises and 3 of the standing exercises and create “enchâînement” (combinations) with music.

MAKE UP 2 of your own skates on exercises and add them to your chart – not at random, but relevant to the whole process begun here – from floor, to barre, to on-ice.

5-) Teach the Complete Final on-ice Lesson

Both as a private lesson as well as a group lesson, this will help you to learn how to focus on more individuals in more specific ways.

Essay (for your Journal) Review definition of Pedagogy and Continuity of Teaching Method. Re-read Chapter 1 of my Fundamentals Book, the articles on “How to Begin and Maintain a ballet for figure skaters’ program for your club” and “Progression of

Mind-Body Connection Skills for the Entire Program,” and review your own notes on the subject.

ESSAY PREMISE:

In light of what you have learned in this course, how would you teach skating differently? How would you tie in ALL off-ice and on-ice classes? How would you teach “LTS”, Moves in the Field, and possibly even Figures differently?

Imagine that you are a director - describe what your ideal situation would be for equipping a rink with a truly Completely Integrated/Unified Figure Skating School. Make a list of all the things currently lacking or making it difficult to teach ballet or any other off-ice classes at your current rink. Are various teachers/coaches cooperating in a single vision or are they doing their own thing. Are off to on ice classes integrated so that transitions from off to on-ice make sense – if not, why not? ... and what you would do if you were in charge. Encompass every possible on and off ice class and anything else you feel is relevant in your essay.

Why Ballet Specifically Geared for Skaters is the Best Choice

Co-written by Annette T. Thomas, Dorian Shields Valles,
Tai Babilonia and Deidre Arianne Kellogg

I have noticed around the web that a number of people have questioned why ballet specifically geared for skaters is even necessary, and that taking a “regular” ballet class should be good enough. I’d like to just share some thoughts and reasons here for you as a skater, coach or parent of a skater to consider:

THE SITUATION:

- The Classical ballet syllabus is comprised of well over 400 exercises, steps and poses not all of which are necessary or even beneficial for skaters.
- Most ballet teachers are not familiar with the needs and demands of skating and often criticize skaters unfairly (inaccurately) as they are not equipped to properly analyze why skaters do what they do or how to “fix” it.

A good ballet instructor can see a “million” things “wrong” with a skater’s alignment and execution of any particular ballet exercise, BUT only a ballet instructor well versed in WHY a skater does what he/she does (in particular the use of edges and movement direction) can discern what is germane to the demands of skating technique and if it is even necessary to “fix” something.

- Many dance schools work for half the year on recital or competition pieces, which have no bearing whatsoever on actual training techniques. This is a waste of training money.
- Most skating students have very little if any idea how to take what they have learned in a regular ballet class and put it on the ice. The idea that they would take a class just hoping for some positive outcome is also not a good use of time or funds.

*In order for the mind and body to absorb ballet technique purely by “osmosis” requires that a student take a regulation length (90 minute) class **at least** 3 times per week. I know of no skaters who take more than 2 ballet classes per week and from my understanding most skaters are only taking one ballet class per week, many of which are only one hour long. Besides a short education in “style” absolutely nothing can truly be gained with this approach.*

THE SOLUTION:

- Sports specific training targets what is most useful to the skater's training needs so that definable/measurable results are acquired more quickly. Why should classical ballet be any different? With the variety of competing types of off-ice programs available these days, having a sport specific ballet lesson is absolutely essential.
- Having a knowledgeable instructor prepare ballet lessons especially for the figure skater targets what the skater's need to learn both physically as well as intellectually in a shorter amount of training time. (Intensity of purpose and focus). The teacher will have immediate sport specific corrections, analogies and helpful tips on how the skaters can transfer what they are learning in class onto the ice.
- The teacher will not be conflicted as to the purpose of the class (not torn between a correction for a skater as opposed to a correction for a strictly ballet student). Many of the corrections would be the same but the reasons behind the need for them and WHY can be **entirely** different.
- In taking classical ballet lessons specifically geared for skaters, the skater is more engaged in the lessons because they recognizably have immediate relevance to their needs. The skater doesn't have to guess at what might work or help, and doesn't come in with a bad attitude or an incorrect (myopic) notion as to why they are there.
- Ballet for Figure Skaters lessons are usually offered at rinks making it much easier to attend and facilitating on site communication between the coach, the ballet instructor, the skater and the parent. *Good communication is a major factor in the success of the ballet program as continual cooperation between members of the training team is imperative to the success of the skater.*
- The skater, coach and parent can have confidence that everything the skater is learning in class is for the sole purpose of becoming a better skater. When the skater knows that the coach and ballet instructor are in frequent contact with each other, the skater is much more likely to be fully on board with the program too.

Having said all this, I feel that it is still better to find a pedagogically trained ballet teacher who knows very little about skating than to hire or take lessons from a teacher who claims to know much about skating but does not exhibit good ballet pedagogy. As I truly wanted to get to the root of this issue (and not just promote my personal interests), I have asked some prominent and knowledgeable people in the skating community to weigh in on this subject and they have graciously taken the time to respond.

Here, first, are comments by Dorian Shields Valles, former skater, coach, ballet aficionado (having taken lessons for many years by some of the best in the field) and now a USFS National Singles Technical Specialist. In her early years, Dorian Valles was trained by Mme. Tamara Elganova of the “*Ballet Russe de Monte Carlo*” and founder of the *Orange County Ballet Company*. Dorian later trained under Al & Harriet DeRea for ballet and jump class, and Roland Dupree and Steven Peck for jazz. Dorian’s off-ice teaching was intermittent but quite formidable. She began teaching off-ice ballet to her skating students in the early 1970’s and began including some on-ice jazz and choreography classes in the 80’s. Later, in the “90’s, she also taught off-ice conditioning and music appreciation.

Here are Dorian’s comments:

“I received a goal sheet for a couple of students that I work with from their main coaches. I added the goals for working with the ballet teacher at our rink as part of the goals for the year. I feel very strongly that ballet should be a component of any skater's training schedule if possible. Fortunately, I am able to discuss what my thoughts are as far as what the students should focus on for their individual needs and it is definitely helpful. I have seen improvement since the skater started to focus on the particular things I asked her to. These needs may change during the year as the skater's skills improve. Here are the few "bullet points" I posed to the head coach of these girls:

Also, I'd like to include in “Skater X's” goals for the year what she works on with the ballet instructor:

- Continue work on core strength, posture and carriage with emphasis on "lift" in upper body.
- Continue work on facial expression, head positions and emotional expression to the audience.
- Continue work on explosive "push away" movement from the floor for jumps.
- Work at the barre on proper knee over foot alignment on pliés, which will help to establish stable landing positions (in “Skater X's” case, no pronation).

One of the students I work with comes from a family that has limited resources and they do their best to stretch their finances to allow their skater to take ballet once a week as I've emphasized how important I feel it is for her to help "feel" her body and the music better. The goals I listed are individualized goals for the ballet instructor to work on but they can also be applied to so many skaters as well.

I feel it is extremely important to have a ballet instructor in-house for skaters or if not, (as this is not always possible as a lot of rinks don't have a ballet studio available) then there must be a very good communication system in place on a regular basis. Having distinct, set goals while working with the skaters and their ballet teachers will not only help the skater but the coach as well.

As time is always a factor for most coaches to try and make use of every minute during a skater's lesson, having a skater who has been trained in classical ballet makes the coach's job much easier since the skater will know instinctively how to place their arms, how to hold themselves "up and lifted" for great posture and how to stay down in their knees while stroking.

The benefits of classical ballet training give the athlete a sense of carriage, musicality and body awareness that can all be translated to the ice. It is always very evident to a coach whose skater has had that training.

When a coach has a good working relationship with a ballet instructor who is willing to help the skater reach their goals it becomes so easy to communicate the skater's needs as they seem to always be changing as the skater progresses through each season."

Here is what former pairs skater Tai Babilonia (who along with her partner Randy Gardner was the 1979 World Champion and the 1976-1980 U.S. national champion) has to say on the subject of ballet:

"We were lucky enough to have some of the best ballet instructors in Los Angeles. Our last ballet teacher, Terry Rudolph, was hired by our coach Mr. Nicks to work with all of his skaters in the ballet room giving a proper basic ballet class 3 times per week. Then she would (no skates) work on our programs on the ice from the starting position to the ending bow and skating off the ice, and would pick it apart. We didn't know any other way; this was all part of our training day.

It's the little things that count and I believe less is more, but that's just me. Look at John Curry, this is what skating should look like, isn't it called FREE style? John looked like a dancer who just happened to know how to skate.

Young skaters need to embrace their past skating legends. The innocence, care & love for the craft have been lost somewhere. I am so grateful and appreciate that I was part of skating when it was really all about the love of skating. Ballet is such a major and important ingredient to the Tai & Randy look; it set us apart from the Eastern Block skaters and also helped us through our whole professional skating career. Still to this day, I don't jump anymore but you can bet every time I lift my foot, that toe is pointed!"

And here is Deidre Arianne Kellogg who has been a choreographer and teacher of ballet specifically tailored to the needs of elite level figure skaters for over 25 years and Founder and Director of The Skaters' Consortium:

"As a ballet teacher who teaches classes specifically geared towards figure skaters and ice dancers, I agree that there are many reasons to go with a specialized teacher, all covered by Annette.

To reiterate, a skater-focused ballet teacher can plan a class working on skater-specific issues, and can be especially helpful in explaining to the skaters how to assimilate the techniques and movement from the studio floor to the ice.

I created some exercises that could only be called “Skallet Technique” (pronounced “skallay” - too bad that name is taken!), exercises that mimic the skating experience and technique while adding in the ballet technique. As an example, I teach a spiral/penché exercise where the planted foot stays in parallel, as it would on the ice, and the free side opens into turnout. Skating-specific ballet training can offer many things like that, and, as Annette so rightly stated, there are so many exercises in ballet that are just irrelevant to skaters.

Also, when it comes to corrections, they will be more accurate and useful to the skater coming from a teacher with solid skating knowledge. That said, Annette's point about proper ballet pedagogy stands.

From my experience, skaters prefer to spend their precious time on the ice, thus they should optimize their time in the studio with a teacher and a syllabus that will be geared specifically to their needs. It only makes sense.

Thank you, Annette, for addressing this important topic. You would think this to be a no-brainer!”

IN CONCLUSION:

The fact is that skaters no longer have the money or leisure time to take 3 ballet classes a week plus keep up with their other off-ice training demands. So, given that time is of the essence and sport specific training is absolutely imperative, choosing a ballet program that is specifically adapted to the immediate artistic and technical needs of the figure skater is the logical choice.

What Makes Teaching/Learning Classical Ballet Different

There are many opinions/misconceptions about what a ballet class is supposed to “do” for a skater, how effective it really is as a training tool or even how “safe” it is for skaters to take ballet. I have had skaters’ parents come up to me and tell me that their skater has been injured so they will not be taking ballet for X number of weeks, but the coach suggested that the skater still take the strength training class during those same weeks!

While I’m not suggesting that anyone (especially children) train while injured, classical ballet training, if taught correctly, is one of the safest, most effective off-ice conditioning classes obtainable. Over the years I have had students come into my classes who were injured in other sports. Every one of those students recovered quickly and effectively because the movement patterns taught in a proper classical ballet lesson are biomechanically sound and take into account the development of the individual.

One of the reasons why classical ballet is such an effective and virtually injury free training tool, is that it is a very slow, methodical process which trains the mind-body connection in a very specific process for maximum permanent results.

In many studios across the globe ballet is approached merely as a style of dance and NOT as a viable training tool. Recital or competition-based dance studios pass along their “knowledge” of ballet technique as if it were like playing the “telephone game” (from person to person) without ever taking pedagogy courses. Naturally then, these misconceptions have been passed down to the skating community as well. Since ballet training and the concepts revolving around ballet training have been misunderstood even in the dance world, educating the public as to what real classical ballet instruction has to offer is one of the major tasks pedagogically trained ballet teachers throughout the world find themselves engaged in, and this is especially so in the skating world!

A Bit of History:

The originator of the Russian Teaching Method, Professor Agrippina Vaganova, unified the classical ballet experience of generations and offered a clear and concise system of a virtually infallible way of teaching (pedagogy) and performing the entire ‘alphabet’ of classical dance. Vera Kostrovitskaya, who was one of Vaganova’s closest disciples, and most trusted assistant, was one of the leading figures to further develop Vaganova’s method of teaching. Incorporating the best techniques from French, Italian and Danish ballet schools, the Vaganova, or Russian Teaching Method, as it is called today is meticulously systematic and the most scientifically accurate in its approach to achieving both technical and artistic mastery. Vaganova never meant her teaching method to be solely the “Russian Method,” she meant it to be *the* teaching method of classical dance. (1)

Russian Method: Why it is different and why skaters can benefit from this method

I believe the Russian Teaching Method to be most helpful to figure skaters as its goals are essentially identical: high effortless looking jumps, well centered and multiple revolution spins, high extensions, smoothly executed intricate footwork, and artistic/expressive use of the entire body, all with a clear emphasis on injury prevention through careful body development. To me, Classical Ballet Training is analogous to Albert Einstein's "Unified Theory" or "The Theory of Everything" when it comes to physical training...you learn this and you learn the fundamentals of everything that comes afterward.

For example:

- In the Russian Teaching Method each exercise is broken down much as a sports scientist would "slow-mo" a perfectly executed movement in order to analyze, moment by moment, the progression of a step or element. But instead of looking at the movement from a purely external point of view, it is analyzed by the internal structure of the movement. This analysis (breakdown) is the beginning of the progression of A before B, and B before C and is then translated into specific exercise forms which are practiced by the student in a precise fashion with calculated repetitions to form the muscles, ligaments, tendons and correct neurological pathways.
- Each step and exercise has several "forms" which are taught separately and in progression...combinations of steps (called enchaînement) are never taught until the individual steps are completely mastered, including head, eyes, arms etc. for that particular step.
- The Method teaches that when a movement isn't broken down into its most basic forms it is immediately practiced as a piece of choreography rather than as an exercise being done for a specific purpose. This leads to bad habits and sloppy technique when trying to build on those fundamentals with more difficult steps. Inaccurate teaching can also lead to injuries because the actual intent of the exercise is not understood.
- The Russian Method recognizes that the area of the 5th lumbar vertebrae is the center of all body control. Training all the muscles of the lower back for strength first, then articulation (controlled flexibility), is fundamental in preventing injuries as well as acquiring aplomb and artistic nuance. Many dancers as well as figure skaters these days have an unprecedented number of back injuries due to poor training and overuse of the back muscles as they try for "tricks" before their backs are strong enough.
- The Method specifically instructs never to raise the free leg any higher than 90° in the first year and a half of training as this is the "magic strengthening angle" for

the lower back and pelvic muscles. Even (and especially) if the student shows a potential for great flexibility this angle is kept in order to strengthen the area first.

- The Method teaches that continually demonstrating the steps to the students causes the students to mimic you, and by doing so they will neither internally nor intellectually understand the precision or intent of a movement. Mimicking does not train the neurological pathways which create the mind-body connection. This is also why doing one's exercises by following a video will never produce the quality of results provided by "live" instruction.
- The Method specifically breaks down and limits the number of repetitions of certain "extreme" movements, i.e., various jumps, grand pliés and the like done in a single lesson in order to prevent over-use injuries. MORE is never better but ACCURACY and incorporation are.
- From the very first lesson the head, eye focus, arms and shoulders are trained with as much attention to detail as the legs and feet. "All possible inclinations and turns of the head accompany all the movements of the exercise(s), beginning with the first exercise at the barre"
- The Method also teaches that too much stretching can weaken ligaments, muscles and tendons to the degree that strength may never be achieved. Since it takes great strength and stamina to execute high jumps, passive stretching in particular is kept to a minimum with the majority of active stretching being placed within the lesson as part of an exercise. Too much stretching without first strengthening those exact same pathways will lead to eventual weakness and injury.

One of the main reasons for the rise in injuries of both dancers and sports people (and the rise in turn of the sports medicine profession) is the lack of following a precise and progressively detailed daily syllabus. A second reason is impatience in the desire to do difficult and fancy "tricks" before the body is ready, and to have the instant gratification of acquiring a medal or leading role before one is truly ready for it.

What a Classical Ballet Lesson Entails

A classical ballet lesson is 90 minutes long with very few exceptions (beginning children's class can be a slightly shorter). This is necessary in order to provide adequate time for every muscle, tendon and ligament in the body to warm-up, stretch, and to coordinate with other muscle groups in a cohesive, productive manner. Remember that there are well over 400 muscles in the body...every one of them is used to dance and to skate! **This is not "mindless exercise": the intellect as well as the sensibilities are always fully engaged so that the mind and emotions grow along with the body... this takes time.**

Classical ballet is first and foremost concerned with the stabilizing muscles (not the mobilizers) of the body. The stabilizers must be active, well aligned, strong and flexible before giving primary attention to the mobilizers (choreography). Practicing "Figures" used to do this for skaters.

Strength training may provide added strength without the knowledge of how to use that strength in a coordinated and effective way in skating (having a strong core may not preclude that you will always have good posture and "lift" during jump landings).

Flexibility training may make one more flexible without supplying the ability to sustain amplitude or a bend of the torso while simultaneously maintaining balance and whole-body control.

I have had coaches also ask me to do some "core work" with their skaters along with the ballet! When taught and applied correctly Classical Ballet training provides both strength and flexibility in just the right balance in a harmonized and systematic manner - incorporating flow of movement, whole body awareness and coordination (head and eyes to arms and feet) all in time to music.

No other single discipline can be seen to provide the skater with all of these necessary physical, intellectual and emotional tools to develop their fullest potential WITHOUT INJURY

What each ballet lesson provides:

- At least 8 progressive barre exercises (first learned facing the barre and then with one hand on the barre) which warm up the entire body in a methodically prescribed manner.
- At least 10 progressive center exercises including center-barre, port de bras (carriage of the arms, head and upper body), adagio and allegro.
- Music education in tempi, music character, with feeling and personal expression (not just as part of "choreography")

- Teaching of the internal workings of movement training: why each exercise is practiced, what it produces in the body when done correctly.
- Whole body movement coordination in time to the music: head, hands/fingers, eyes, arms, torso, legs, and feet. Teaching the importance of attention to detail, observation skills and objective personal assessment.
- Extensive aerobic training: advanced levels contain 20 minutes of almost continuous jumps as “de rigueur”.
- Supervised stretching to increase range of motion at the end of every class.
- Daily assessment of the class as a whole and of each student as an individual with one-on-one interaction for “problem areas”.

As proven by over 100 years of ongoing scientific analysis and refinement, these qualities cannot be obtained by a once-a-week lesson, a 45 minute or one hour lesson, or a lesson combined with other material. To see the best results in the least amount of time WITHOUT INJURY this format must be upheld and practiced at the very least 2X per week. If taught and applied correctly it is a proven “formula” which works without exception.

In closing I would like to say that I think the difficulty in understanding what Classical Ballet training is all about stems from what the current media has been feeding the public about dance in general. The current trend is to present ALL dance as doable by the general public so we forget the fact the Classical Ballet in particular is a fine art form and not a “reality show” set of “moves” (after all, we don’t have a show called “So You Think You Can Play the Violin”). The word Classical means “of the highest standard” or “perfection”...this is not to exclude or discourage any one from taking classical ballet but to encourage you to become aware of and embrace the challenge of the high standards and discipline for the rewards (as in the discipline of figure skating) are well worth the effort!

(1) Vera Kostrovitskaya and Alexei Pisarev, School of Classical Dance (Dance Books Ltd., 1995) p. 16

New material and excerpts taken from a previous article entitled “Russian Teaching Method and Why it is Different” and portions of “Fundamentals of Alignment and Classical Movement for Figure Skaters” pp.5-4 – 5-6 © 2011 by Annette T. Thomas all rights reserved.

The Importance of Warming up

Current articles on the web claim that “stretching before dance class (actually anything physical) helps to prevent injuries”. I cannot emphasize how bad this advice is....

Extreme stretching to increase range of motion without first completely warming up can actually *cause* injuries.

A well-designed warm-up regimen should prepare your entire person: mind, body and emotions, to be at its best for the lesson or performance ahead of you. Your warm-up should be seen as the beginning of your practice or performance and ought to be done with the same mental focus and concentration toward precision and quality of form you would have during your lessons.

A stretch is not a warm-up!

It is very important to understand the distinction between a stretch and a warm up as it is a thorough warm up that lowers your chances of injury, NOT stretching. Although mild stretches are done as part of a warm-up routine, extreme stretching in place of or during your warm up can actually cause injuries.

A warm-up routine's main physical purpose is to raise the heart rate and increase blood flow to the muscles and tendons with the least amount of strain on those same muscles and tendons.

This increased blood flow brings oxygen and nutrients as well as heat to your muscles, tendons, joints, and ligaments, which is vital in preparing them to work smoothly and correctly.

*Extensive and/or vigorous stretching puts maximum strain on joints, ligaments, tendons and muscles and should always to be done ***IF AT ALL*** after a complete warm up and some mid-range aerobic work when the entire body has worked up to a mild sweat.*

The role of Myofascia in a good warm-up:

Another misconception is that the muscles are tight and need to be loosened or stretched before they are ready to work. While this is half the truth, the other half of the story is that it is actually the Myofascia which surround/contain the muscles that is tight and this is what needs to be loosened (or softened) before the muscles are worked.

Always do the foot and lower leg Myofascial massages at the very beginning of every lesson and at the end of the day.

Progression of a well-designed warm up

A full warm up should methodically “lubricate” and prepare your entire body: head, neck, arms, fingers, spine, torso, hips, knees, ankles, toes and even your facial muscles. Remember you dance with all of you...it takes over 400 muscles just to step forward and every part is dependent upon every other part!

Beginning of warm-up

Large Muscles

Non-weight bearing

Slow, large Movements

General

End of Warm-up

to

Small Muscles

to

Weight bearing

to

Fine, quick movements

to

Action Specific

Tips:

- *Depending on your skill level a full warm-up should take between 15 to 30 minutes. You should never warm up so long or intensely that you become fatigued. Oddly enough, the higher-level dancer you are the MORE warm-up time you need.*
- *A warm up also prepares your mind and emotions to focus on the task at hand. It's where you “leave the day behind” to get reacquainted with your posture, alignment, balance (centering), and range of motion.*
- *Concentrate on doing all warm-ups in a well-aligned and methodical manner and not to “just get them over with” which can actually cause more harm than good.*
- *Learn to incorporate deep breathing into your warm-up exercises. One reason why dancers (and skaters) fatigue and run out of breath during jumps in particular is their lack of understanding how deep breathing techniques help to develop stamina and endurance.*
- *The effects of a warm-up last only about one-half hour so it is important not to warm up too early.*

***In a Vaganova Based Classical Ballet Lesson, the warm-ups are built in to the lesson plan itself. The beginning floor exercises and ensuing “internal warm-up” facing the barre, pliés and tendus, etc. are the perfect warm-ups; adding the Myofascial releases BEFORE class can help to ensure that you are working to your fullest physical capacity.*

The Seven Rules of S-t-r-e-t-c-h-i-n-g
UPDATED*

*There is much scientific literature these days to support the fact that stretching causes more damage than good – especially extreme stretching and even more specifically in young children. It is in fact ill advised that skaters do any extreme stretching as this only exacerbates the joint damage which is incurred during jump practice. Skater's need more Eccentric Contraction exercises in order to strengthen as well as lengthen muscles and keep joints strong. Increasing ROM is better accomplished through ECCENTRIC contraction exercises (as presented in the Vaganova Floor exercises) than any form of stretching as it both lengthens and strengthens muscles simultaneously.

Here are some guidelines to follow for the best possible outcomes:

- 0- Wear warm clothing to keep muscles warm- (under no circumstances should you ever stretch on the ice!
- 1- Do the myofascial massages before (It's "The warm up before the warm up"!)
- 2- Begin with **current range of motion**, and in a completely aligned manner. External aids (like blocks) are NEVER necessary when the body is properly aligned.
- 3- Concentrate on the part of the body you are stretching. Focus your attention on how the muscles feel: is your whole-body alignment correct? Are you feeling a pull at your joints or in the center of the muscle itself? A properly aligned stretch should NEVER be felt primarily at the point of origin or insertion but in the "belly" or center of the muscle. If you feel the majority of the pull at either end of your muscles (near the joints) you are either stretching too far or you have not warmed up properly. THIS WILL EVENTUALLY CAUSE AN INJURY.
- 4- We have 640 voluntary muscles (agonists and antagonists) in our bodies as well as 12 Myofascial Meridians. Make sure you are aware of the fact that everything in your body is CONNECTED so, just focusing on what "feels tight" will only pull your body out of alignment which will, again, eventually cause injury.
- 5- Deep breathing should ALWAYS be part of your stretch routine. OXYGEN – without it we cannot function properly. It brings mental clarity and prevents muscle cramps (lactic acid buildup).
- 6- Rest for at least several hours after stretches. NO physical activity especially not jumping or lifting! Strenuous activity after extreme stretching will cause loose joints and a situation ripe for injury.

7- *IF YOU FEEL YOU MUST STRETCH, TAKE INTO ACCOUNT THESE POINTS:*

- Only at the end of the last class to be taken that day
- Never passive stretching (try dynamic or just holding a pose long enough to feel a release)
- Remember to breathe deeply and MASSAGE the area being stretched
- Remember that everything is connected
- Never immediately before a competition
- Never before practicing jumps
- **Never during a growth spurt** – as teachers of children this last point is extremely important! Growth spurts cause the long bones of the body (arms and legs) and spine to grow faster than the muscles which attach to those same bones; so, it takes time for the muscles, tendons and ligaments to catch up to the bone growth. If we further stretch those muscles before they have a chance to catch up with the new bone growth, we can damage the muscles as well as growth plates.

Progression of Mind-Body Connection Skills for the Entire Program - in preparation for creating your “Teaching Chart”

1-) Floor Exercises

- Feeling, practicing and remembering (muscle memory) what correct WHOLE BODY PLACEMENT feels like – this takes TIME and practice in whole body awareness.
- Working accurately with the least amount of pressure on skeletal system
- Strengthening Core (meaning all 3 Stabilizer Complexes – shoulder, trunk and hip) warm the entire neuromuscular system up (mind body connections). Mild stretching – mostly through eccentric and isometric exercises and working turn-out in the most effective and injury preventative way.

2-) Exercises facing or back to the barre (two hands on the barre)

- Ballet exercises learned facing the barre reinforces the feeling of the floor exercises in a standing position.
- Placement and accuracy of movement is ensured with no twisting of torso.
- Turn-out is ONLY equally felt on both the working and supporting leg when facing the barre.
- All newly introduced steps and exercises are practiced first with two hands on the barre – including jumps.

3-) Exercises with one hand on the barre

- When the student has proven that they can accurately feel correct PLACEMENT during an exercise, you can begin one hand on the barre training of the same exercise at exactly the same speed and repetitions as with two hands on the barre.
- As proficiency is gained, speed and complexity can be added gradually.
- Maintaining whole body placement is paramount – not the complexity of the exercise.

4-) Centre exercises

- “Centre – Barre” exercises are repeated exactly the same as the barre exercises. They are practiced with arms “en face” and later with épaulement.
- Student must maintain accurate PLACEMENT and (now) complete BALANCE to the equation – APLOMB.
- Jumps are first taught and practiced facing the barre and then in the centre at the same speed with arms in preparatory (for core development). All other arm positions are added later.

5-) “Skates-on” exercises

- Reinforces accurate alignment, how to point the feet while straightening the knees correctly, ROM, and strengthening multiplanar movement patterns in the most effective, relevant and injury preventative way.
- Provides core strength exercises with no added equipment.
- Provides a fluid “bridge” of mind-body connection from off-ice to on-ice movement.

6-) On-ice exercises

- Brings the entire learning process full circle so that what was felt at every stage is now completely ingrained into the mind-body connection.
- This all takes SLOW meticulous and detail-oriented teaching and practice. It takes time to ingrain/imprint accurate mind-body connection skills and to “undo” all the bad habits – but so much better in the long run – technically, artistically and health wise!
- The good news is that doing it this way is actually FASTER and SAFER than trying to speed progress by taking short cuts and having to adjust technique later on.

Student Physical Assessments

These are exercises which lend themselves to the teacher observing individual strengths and weaknesses in their students – *all floor exercises help to determine assessment results

1-) Student walks away, toward & across your line of sight - hands on waist

- Even gait
- Hips and shoulders level
- Head straight – not forward or tilted
- Thoracic Kyphosis (hunched upper back not merely shoulders)
- How the feet go through heel, ball, toe (if pronated, supinated etc.)

A persons' gait tells you a lot about their spine, hips and shoulder girdles, what injuries they might have sustained in the past and why they may or may not be able to perform certain exercises easily or correctly.

A body out of alignment is both frustrating and an accident waiting to happen.

2-) Student rolls down spine while standing with back and then side to you

- Scoliosis
- Lumbar Lordosis
- Sway back

3-) Student sitting on the floor

- Legs together and straight out in front w/back & head completely straight – is one leg shorter than the other? Do the knees “knock” (Tibial torsion)
- Flex feet, then point feet with pulled up knees (look for pronation, supination, Pidgeon toes)

4-) Student lying on the floor

- On back - begin w/ both legs straight on floor – with knee bent, bring one leg up to chest & hold position. Then hold the same leg under the thigh and stretch leg out (up) as straight as possible keeping shoulders on the floor. Repeat extending leg to the side. (Make sure the hips stay neutral and stable). Repeat with other leg. Notice evenness of hips and shoulders through the process - one side is often skewed, which is normal.
- Lying on side with both legs straight on floor – draw top leg into retiré position and check alignment of spine (does the student stick their seat out to get the top leg into that position?) Extend the leg to the ceiling (is the spine still straight? How far forward (instead of to the ceiling) does the leg extend? - Turn-out, lower back issues (curvature) flexibility.
- Lying on stomach – face down and head neutral – raise one leg, then the other, then raise both legs. With both legs straight on the floor raise torso with arms out to sides not touching floor, then bring arms over head. Flexibility, evenness and symmetry of body and movements.

The 12 PRELIMINARY VAGANOVA FLOOR EXERCISES

These exercises help to provide a solid foundation for ALL movement

- Placement
- Alignment
- “Capital letter I” core strength (“setting” the 90° angle of the main fulcrum of the body)
- Flexibility
- Awareness (mind body connection)
- Turn-out

Even before standing exercises with two hands on the barre, they are the best for injury prevention as there is little pressure/weight on joints due to gravity. These preliminary exercises will also reveal any possible muscle/skeletal imbalances within the student.

*** In order to allow the students to really feel and understand each movement deeply - first teach without music. Only add music when the exercises have been mastered (comprehended somatically from the inside out – not just as a wrote set of exercises to “get over with”).**

RULE: ALWAYS do the myofascial massages & warm-up at the beginning of every lesson you teach

Sitting on the Mat

1 - Lifting out of the hips

With legs in parallel and straight in front of you, pull up knees (knee caps lifted to their full extent so the Quads are engaged fully) and point the feet strongly so that the heels come off the floor. Back straight, ears, shoulders and hips in one line – chin slightly higher than parallel to the floor. (You can also do this exercise with back to the wall or use a yardstick or pointer as a plumb line), with hands on waist and elbows aligned with ears, shoulders, torso and hips. Squeeze the knees together medially so that the knees do not “lock” (see page 3-56 in the Fundamentals book)

Counts 1 - 4

Roll spine down into a slump; then, engaging the glutes

Counts 5 - 8

roll back up vertebra by vertebra back to straight position – see that the student does not arch the lower back or pinch back or hunch their shoulders. Tell your students to imagine they have a wide belt just under the floating ribs lifting them up.

Counts 1 - 4

Then bring the arms straight out to the sides with only the fingertips touching the floor and hold the posture continuing to squeeze glutes and “get taller” stretching the vertebrae.

Counts 5 - 8

Then raise straight arms parallel to the floor maintaining the lifted posture.

Counts 1 - 4

Next raise straight arms into a high “V” maintaining lifted posture (no raised shoulders).

Counts 5 - 8

Reverse the process back down to arms parallel,

Counts 1 - 4 and counts 5 - 8

then fingertips to the floor, then hands on waist.

Repeat the entire exercise 4X – Last time ending with arms parallel to the floor.

THEN: Without losing head and torso LIFT, quickly clap hands above head with straight arms 3X returning arms back to parallel the floor each time. The quick movements further strengthen the stabilizer muscles to stay engaged during quick movements (such as in jump landing).

2 - Seated Flex and Point

(Track # 3 – as it correlates to the Battement Tendu exercise)

With hands clasped behind your head and elbows directly out to the sides, sit with legs together straight and in parallel (try to keep heels off the floor). Tighten glutes and knees pressed together medially.

➤ **Always maintain the posture acquired in exercise #1**

Counts: 1 2, 3 4 & 5, 6 hold 7, 8

Flex both feet, demi-point & point and hold (4X)

Then repeat with hands on floor - in turn out (as in the resistance band exercise for turnout) - pinky toes on floor. (4X)

Repeat all clasping hands behind head again practicing articulated foot “circles”:

1 2 3 4 5 6 & 7 8

Flex in parallel, turn out, demi-point, point & turn back in to parallel (4X) And reverse.

3 - Seated Retiré exercise Seated with legs straight in front of you in turnout with feet pointed and both arms in 2nd position (out straight to the sides). Maintain the strongest turnout on BOTH sides of the body at all times (Track #2 or #14 – as it relates to plié)

Counts 1 - 4

Draw one foot up the side of the straight leg to mid-calf keeping heel off the floor and knee as close to the floor as possible.

Counts 5 - 8

Then place the working leg foot FLAT on the floor bringing the knee to the ceiling (without slouching down).

Counts 1 - 4

Then take the working leg back out to the side in retiré and

Counts 5 - 8

Slowly slide the leg back down to straight. Do not shift weight to maintain turnout. Repeat with other leg then repeat 2X with both legs simultaneously.

* Last time end with forehead on knees and hands on shins, and slide down trying to keep the forehead on the knees all the way down to straight legs for a good back stretch.

4-Arms in 2nd Position Raising one leg in turn out (Track # 5 as it relates to Battement tendu jeté at the barre)

Sit with arms in 2nd (or just parallel the floor with palms facing front) and legs straight in front in turnout with feet strongly pointed and back completely straight and lifted.

1 2

Raise right leg completely straight without leaning back or

3 4 5 6 7 8

slouching and flex then point foot and lower leg back to floor. Repeat with left leg and repeat again. Then repeat turning head the opposite way of leg being raised to stretch back line. (When the student is ready you can do can include circling the leg CW & CCW)

*** Remember to keep back lifted and straight, neck long and shoulders down throughout – it's not about the height of the leg – it's about the ability to control and maintain whole body alignment.**

5- Straddle with Cambré forward (Track #14 as it relates to “cambré” at the barre)

Seated in a straddle with feet flexed and arms in “stick up” position, bend forwards at the hips with a completely FLAT back cueing to lift “in and up” on “and” 4 counts forward “and” 4 counts to return 4X each side. Head alternately turns to the right and to the left. Cue to engage the glutes strongly on the way up. **Toes & knees must point to the ceiling throughout this exercise.**

6-One leg bent in front with other leg straight behind Hands at sides on floor to assist in balance. With a completely FLAT back Cambré forward (4 counts) and come up (4 counts), then cambré back (from the MID back not lower back) in 4 counts and return 4 counts. Repeat all 4X Just as in the above exercise cueing to lengthen the spine and lift the laterals and deep muscles both going down and coming back up. Change legs and repeat to other side. Eventually this exercise should be done with arms in 2nd or 3rd (Cecchetti high 5th).

Lying on Back on the Mat:

7-Preliminary Turn out exercise - on back with hands on waist and legs in parallel (Track #14)

Counts 1 - 4

Draw up the knees in parallel w/ toes pointed and heels off the floor (**Do not arch lower back or “bunch” the stomach, and keep shoulder joints on the floor.**)

5 - 8

Turn out from hips without arching lower back & HOLD strong abductor stretch firmly tighten gluteals and deep abs to spine.

1 - 4 5 - 8

Adduct knees back up to parallel & slide back down keeping spine neutral, ending in flexed feet and “long spine”.

Repeat 4X in 16 counts each

8- “Plié with to split on ceiling” (Track # 6 or #14)

With hands on waist and legs straight in turnout and feet pointed

Counts 1 - 4

Draw the toes together (heels off the floor) to closest point to crotch.

Counts 5 - 8

Without lifting the “tail bone” off floor open legs straight to “V”

1 2 3 4

Flex & point, bring toes back together in strongest turn out possible and

5 - 8

slowly stretch legs back down to straight maintaining turn out and elongated spine.

Repeat 4X

9 - On back STRAIGHT leg raises (Relevé Lent) to ceiling in turn-out (Track #13)

with arms straight out to sides with palms on floor, legs straight and in turnout with feet pointed.

Counts 1 - 4

Raise right leg to ceiling without engaging the shoulder girdle or “bunching” abs and keeping the leg on the floor completely straight with knee pulled up.

Counts 5 - 8

Lower leg maintaining control and repeat with other leg. THEN repeat with both legs together (2X) in 16 counts. Repeat all 4X and then repeat all again in PARALLEL

THEN:

Using the same music and a count of 4 for each movement:

Lift right leg to ceiling, extend side without twisting hips, lower to near the floor without touching the floor and reverse the “circle.” Repeat with left leg then repeat with both legs together. Keep lower back and hipbones on the floor at all times by engaging deep abs, glutes, deep rotators and entire capital letter I Stabilizer Complex.

****As your students become more proficient you can have them try the exercises keeping the arms in 1st position throughout then in 3rd (5th) and finally using 1st Port de Bras arms for a challenging whole-body exercise.**

Lying on Stomach on the Mat:

10 – Turn out exercise with hip flexor stretch (no music, just focus on technique)

Bend elbows and place head face down on hands with legs straight and in parallel. Flex feet so that only the balls of feet are on floor.

Counts 1 - 8

Pull up knees strongly while simultaneously squeezing the legs in isometrically toward each other.

Counts 1 - 8

Then turn out from the hip sockets only by pressing heels to floor (as if you were in 1st position). Keep pressure off the knees by pulling them up.

Point feet (8 counts) maintaining turnout in the hip sockets.

Come back to parallel and flex feet back under to repeat from the beginning. (8 counts)

Later add leg lifts w/ legs turned out and hip bones on floor.

*Make sure students keep deep abs strongly engaged even when practicing prone exercises.

11 – Retiré and extend to side on the floor (Track #13 or #14)

With forehead down on hands and legs in turnout with feet pointed, draw right leg toes to inside of left knee keeping the hips as square to the floor as possible (counts 1 & 2).

Extend leg straight out to the side on the floor (counts 3 & 4) Flex BOTH feet and squeeze legs back together in flex. (counts 5 – 8) Repeat to other side. Repeat 4X alternating in 8 counts each.

THEN: Retiré (passé) to attitude (bent leg with knee up to ceiling) and extend leg to ceiling and lower slowly (8 count total)

*Maintain turnout on both sides with hips as square to the floor as possible – again it's not about the height – it's about the control and alignment.

12 – Swan Arch with Partners (Track #16 or #18)

With partners – one sits and holds ankles of the one lying on stomach with legs straight and in turn out. Hands under head as previous exercises. Lengthen spine “in and up” as the one lying down arches up w/arms in 2nd position. Gluteals and abs strongly engaged with neck long and shoulders down. Hold 6 counts and lower. Repeat 4X. Then repeat with arms in 3rd (Cecchetti 5th)

Then repeat with “port de bras” right and left as follows: Begin on stomach with right hand under head and left arm out directly to the side on the floor to the left. On counts 1 & 2 lift torso up looking to the left, while raising the right arm to 3rd and the left arm to 2nd. On counts 3 & 4 look up bring both arms to 3rd, on counts 5 & 6 look right keeping the left arm in 3rd and bringing the right arm to 2nd. On counts 7 & 8 come back down to the floor with left hand under head and right arm straight on floor to the side. Repeat SLOWLY 4X.

The 7 Steps Towards Becoming a “Master Teacher”

Teaching as a vocation - How to turn information into knowledge and impart it to your students

It is an undeniable fact that the majority of teachers and coaches without a pedagogy background (either by attending a "Teacher's College" or other teaching methodology courses) tend to teach primarily how they were taught - by demonstrating and then, doing the exercises along with their students. Teachers of this ilk tend to know WHAT to teach (a given syllabus), but not necessarily feel confident in having a true methodology of *impartation* (process). To be a more effective teacher, impartation of the material given (mentally, physically and emotionally) requires much more than coming in with a few notes and "winging it" from there. It requires emotional as well as intellectual commitment, discipline, focus and knowing your students' learning styles.

1-) **Intellectual Understanding**: This requires the review and possibly further study of all materials related to the ENTIRE SCOPE of skills/material you are preparing to teach. This includes all medium which might further your personal mental understanding. Not merely based on what someone told you, or what you saw somewhere, but a combination of analyzing accurate biomechanical, technical, and visual study and preparation. Not staying just one or even 10 lessons ahead of the students, but having a deep intellectual knowledge of the technical aspects of every step – “origin to mastery.” *You must grasp the entire scope of the process in question as it brings unity and continuity to your train of thought and thus to your teaching.*

2-) **Physical understanding**: You must physically practice all the exercises slowly and then at the tempo(s) at which you will ultimately be teaching them - no faster than 50bpm for beginners. Think clearly about what muscles are being used, how it feels to do the exercise correctly and incorrectly. This tests your physical understanding of the skills and determines if additional review is needed for your mental/verbal clarification. Your personal mind-body connection and awareness are imperative to the teaching process. If this process is not clear in your own thoughts, it won't be clear in your words either. Feel the exercise correctly within your own body and mentally practice it with your specific student or group in mind. What do they specifically need in this lesson both mentally and biomechanically? Teach to your specific audience. (See the 7 ways of learning fig. 1.1 on page 1-3 in the Fundamentals book) Verbalize your teaching while you practice as if you were rehearsing/memorizing for a play or a speech.

3-) **Emotional/Musical Understanding**: Choosing music is next and practicing the exercise to the music will ensure proper counting/musicality. It is best to practice each exercise several times and take notes to make sure all the important information is clearly delineated. I highly recommend that you COUNT aloud when you practice anything to music so that the technical and the musical flow easily together in your teaching. This is what the ART of CUEING is all about. (See article directly after this one).

When introducing a new piece of music for a recital or skating program, know and discuss the origin of the piece (composer, era, context) and your intent in choosing it. When introducing the piece to your students play the music and count aloud with them to show them the tempo and accents (down-beat, upbeat, phrasing and “mood”). Also, count for them during the exercise until they can hear and feel the beats for themselves.

4-) **Embodying the specific lesson plan**: Create clear and detailed lesson plans (with counting if music is involved) and go through the ENTIRE lesson plan with music by yourself. This practice provides necessary structure for personal reference (embodying the material) as well as clarity and consistency for your students. It’s your “rehearsal” so that your teaching “performance” can be fully directed toward your students without forgetting any important information.

After all of this - Being “FULL of the knowledge and specific task at hand in every part of your being” You are fully prepared to teach your students.

5-) **Hands on Approach for correct placement**: Begin your lesson by introducing your students to the skills you are going to work on that day using a basic demonstration and providing detailed verbal and visual instruction. Always include a hands-on approach by placing the students’ body in the correct position and tapping/identifying certain muscles necessary for the exercise, this helps them to feel the exercise correctly. Ask each student if they have questions before continuing, and remind them that after you demonstrate you will not be doing the exercise along with them. This forces them to think about the movement and the inner workings of their own body, as well as requiring them to memorize the movements. When your students are watching you or others in the class – there is NO mind-body connection taking place.

6-) **Frequently connect (verbal and physical cueing) with each student individually** asking them where and what they are feeling to make sure they are using the correct muscles and making the right mind-body connections. As the students practice the exercise walk around the room to make sure that they are actually doing everything you are requiring of them. Walking around the room affords different angles of viewing your students for accuracy. You should also briefly make physical contact with each student by fixing/placing them by hand; making them aware that if it isn’t right, they will be corrected. This actually speeds the learning process and helps them to “get” a particular movement/exercise more accurately than just doing it with them.

We are partly “electric” - physical contact fires neurons, which enable deeper mind-body learning to occur.

And, to reiterate, when students are watching you dance with them they are not feeling the movement within themselves.

You want to create “intelligent movers” so **teach them where you are going with each step/exercise** and what it will lead to next. This causes them to feel (rightly so) that they are a part of the process and they can more easily visualize the progression of their own learning.

ONLY give praise when it is due! Students know when they have done a bad job of things and don't want to be patronized! Make clear distinctions as to what was good, what could be better and what was truly exceptional – and clearly say WHY. **Accurate assessments using critical thinking skills are imperative for real learning to occur.**

7-) **Take notes at the end of class** or after a specific exercise to modify it in such a way so that NEXT class period you can be a better teacher and your students can be more successful students.

The progression is like an hour glass – you start with the biggest picture possible, bring it down to the smallest elements possible (in concentrated form) - embody the ENTIRE scope/progression and then “feed” it back to your students “backward engineered” from beginning to end.

The Art of Effective Cueing

Following from “The 7 Steps to Becoming a Master Teacher”, I want to delve a bit into the art of cueing effectively and why good cueing is absolutely vital to getting the results you're looking for. Breaking down why we cue the way we do and how we can cue more effectively will help pave the way.

We tend to cue the way we were taught:

Whether we've been teaching “forever” or are a newbie, we tend to copy the teaching style of our favorite teacher; if his/her verbal cues were full of imagery, “flowery” or “strict”, whether they walked around the room and physically corrected each individual or sat in a chair, whether they counted out loud or snapped their fingers or whether they danced with you or spoke out each step by name, describing muscles and expecting you to follow. Whatever the style, we tend to follow suit. The trouble with this is twofold:

- 1-) The cueing may not be accurate to the purpose
- 2-) The cueing may not be “in your voice” (or body language) and thus be inauthentic.

Both of these concepts are vitally important to the master teacher. Clear, direct and accurate cuing needs to be communicated to each student in a way that makes sense to them AND is in your voice - meaning, from your own comprehension and personality - not like a memorized litany of scripted commands.

Cueing for choreography is different than cueing for technique: When we cue for choreography, we are generally assuming that the dancers/movers are coming in with a certain amount of pre-existing dance knowledge so that we are forming a poem or story out of that pre-existing vocabulary. Possible modifications will be made but it is more about the collective “outward picture” than it is the building of technique from the ground up. In this case more descriptive, emotional and imaginative language can be used

effectively, but you wouldn't want to give these types of cues when building methodical and accurate technique from the "inside out."

Cueing for coaching (sports trainer) is different than for teaching a dance methodology: The Fundamentals Book describes the differences between a teacher and a trainer (Page 1-4). Personalities, points of view and delivery are generally different in that a teacher tends toward education and self-motivation while a trainer tends toward guidance and exhortation (external motivation).

In building a methodical technique, cueing should be accurate biomechanically, kinesthetically, musically and with the correct dance movement vocabulary. I highly recommend a book titled "Inside Ballet Technique: Separating Anatomical Fact from Fiction in the Ballet Class" by Valerie Grieg. The chapter "What We Say and What We Mean" is worth the price of the whole book. Different expressions mean different things to different people and since classical ballet is BASED IN SCIENCE (as is Graham Technique), we need to treat the teaching of it as such.

Cueing is verbal, physical and in fact the whole psyche directed to teaching the whole person. Because we each receive information in various ways and on many different levels of comprehension simultaneously, our cueing needs to speak to each of those levels. Use accurate verbal direction in musical phrasing. Be anticipatory and speak to both external (the steps or movement) and internal (musculoskeletal) direction. In body language, convey timing, the feel of the piece and/or an emotion; demonstrate, use mime, give positive and corrective feedback, as well as use hands on anatomical correction. And as I wrote in the article The 7 Steps Toward Becoming a Master Teacher, "...being 'FULL of the knowledge and specific task at hand in every part of your being' you are fully prepared to teach your students."

It takes time and considerable effort, but learning how to cue holistically can bring tremendous confidence, clarity and satisfaction to you and your students.

Ballet Lesson Syllabus for Beginning Coaches Course

BARRE:

1-) Demi & Grand Pliés in 1st 2nd 3rd and 5th (no 4th)

2-) Relevés in 1st, 2nd, and 5th

3-) Cambrés: front, side and back

4-) Battement Tendu in 1st and 5th

5-) Battement Tendu Jeté in 1st and 5th

6-) Passé par terre

7-) Demi rond and full Rond de jamb par terre

8-) Rond de jamb par terre in demi-plié

9-) Demi and full Grand rond at 45° en dehors and en dedans

10-) Wrapping Exercise

11-) Fondu par terre and en l'air

12-) Développé and relevé lent at 45° and at 90° in 1st and 5th position

13-) Grand Battement at 45° or 90° in 1st and 5th position

14-) Demi-plié and relevé facing and side to barre with leg on barre hands on waist (ending with Cambré back)

CENTRE

- 1-) Demi and Grand Pliés in 1st 2nd and 5th with relevé and correct arms
- 2-) The First 3 Port de bras (Including basic arm positions, correct finger groupings, head and hand training etc.)
- 3-) Tendu and tendu jeté in 1st and 5th
- 4-) Passé par terre, demi and full Rond de jamb par terre
- 5-) Rond de jamb par terre in demi-plié
- 6-) Temps Relevé par Terre
- 7-) Demi and full Grand rond at 45° en dehors and en dedans
- 9-) Relevé Lent and développé at 45° and 90°
- 14-) Trampoline jumps (with variations)
- 15-) Temps Levé in 1st 2nd and 5th combination (at barre and in the centre)
- 18-) Ballet port de bras preparation for on-ice class (#6 centre on video)
- 20-) Grand Battement at 90° en face in all directions and in croisé devant and croisé derrière in big pose.

Lessons in Ballet for Figure Skaters - Level 1

⌘ VIDEO INSTRUCTIONAL BOOKLET ⌘

Since there are many nuances and details of the method, which require personal presence, and ongoing lessons, I've provided this DVD, which is for demonstration purposes only and intended as a guide to the method as it relates to figure skating. I highly recommend that you read through the counts of each exercise and watch all demonstrations BEFORE attempting to practice any exercise in this lesson, as you will get very little benefit from it if you just try to copy the movements as you go along.

A NOTE TO MY STUDENTS: This video was created for the general public and as such does not go into as much detail as my private courses. As with my books, it is only to be taken as a reference for further instruction. The music used in this video is by Josu Gallastegui – His music can be found on Amazon and CD Baby. You can substitute the music with selections from our “Ballet Class Music for Figure Skaters” album.

Disclaimer:

The exercises contained in this video are meant to serve as examples and are not to be practiced by any who are not deemed physically fit or able by their physician, sports and/or health practitioner. Exercises should be practiced ONLY under the guidance of a knowledgeable, Vaganova trained instructor. Any individual who chooses to implement any exercise, idea or information contained in this video does so at his or her own risk. The author, videographer and publisher/printer assume no responsibility, nor liability, arising in any way out of the use of this video for your actions. This disclaimer of liability applies to any damages or injury under any theory of liability or any other cause of action.

PRELIMINARIES

A-) Myofascial massages: foot and Tibialis

B-) Resistance Band Exercises:

C-) Positions of the feet, arms and hands (Arrondi and Allongé) + “motivating breath”

D-) Demonstration and explanation of Stance and alignment holding 2 hands on the barre:

- Turn-out origins and how to find it
- Arches lifted (big toe and little toe pressed to floor)
- Knees pulled up + quads tight
- Lifted out of hips & tailbone down (not tucked)
- Spine long (DO-NOT constrict your ribs!)
- Shoulders down & open (neck muscles showing)
- Chin slightly lifted
- Arms from shoulders to elbows relaxed

E-) Demonstration and Explanation of:

- Plié
- Cambrés
- Tendu
- 3 segments of rond de jamb par terre
- 3 positions of sur le cou de pieds and wrapping exercise
- Preliminary form of Fondu par terre** and at 45° Temps levé in 5th, sissonne simple and assemblé

****CORRECTION FONDU PER TERRE** – as the working foot touches the floor in the Preliminary Form, it should be much closer to the supporting leg foot. As both legs straighten, the working foot continues to slide along the floor to the fully extended tendu position.

- **Additional information for pliés** – always **DEEPEN** the demi-plié before straightening the legs.

BALLET LESSON - Beginning Floor Exercises

A -) Preliminary warm-up floor exercise for: Feet and "Back Line"

Begin Hands behind head: Legs straight and parallel

1 2 3 hold 4

Flex, demi & pointe (2X)

Repeat w/ hands on floor in turn out (2X)

THEN:

Arms in 2nd and legs straight and turned out

1 2 3 4 5 - 8 1 - 4

Retiré, flat (knee to ceiling); open/turn out and lower; rep. LEFT then BOTH

5 - 8 1 - 8

Repeat BOTH LEG w. **arms in 3rd** & HEAD TO KNEES in turn out; flex & lower

THEN:

In 4 counts each (16 counts total)

1 2 3 4

Arms in 2nd Lift right leg, flex & pointe & lower REPEAT LEFT and

REPEAT W/ arms in 3rd

In 4 counts each (16 counts total)

LAST: straddle and arms bent Cambré forward & up rep looking left

End feet together knees out and bend over w/elbows on thighs

B -) Preliminary warm-up floor exercise for: Turn-out and core muscles

On back with arms in 1st legs straight and in turn out FEET FLEXED

1 2 & 3 4; 5 6 & 7 8; 1 & 2 (3 4)

Point Both feet, retiré & HOLD; extend sides & HOLD; FLEX & POINT (2X)

5 6 7 & 8

Retiré & straighten legs & FLEX FEET. **Repeat this 1X**

THEN:

1 2 3 4 and 5 & 6 7 and 8

Point & Retiré; lift to attitude; turn in and out (2X) extend sides

1 2 3 (4,5) 6 7 8 and

Flex & turn in & out (2X) Pointe; retiré and straighten; FLEX Repeat this 1X

BARRE WORK:

1-) Internal warm-up

Begin facing barre in 1st position

A - Lift heel of right foot w/bent knee to press ball of the foot on floor; raise whole foot
off floor to point foot; place ball of foot back down onto floor to press the demi point
and lower heel back to 1st. **(2X each side)**

B - Tendu right foot to side “through the foot”; flex foot to 25° off of floor; strongly
rotate whole leg in (from hip socket) & strongly rotate leg back out; demi-pointe
right foot off the floor (toes flexed upward); pointe full foot, lower foot to tendu,
& close to 1st position **(1X each side)** repeat at 45° (**tendu is 1; dégagé is 2**)

ending C – Demi-plié; lift heels IN demi-plié; straighten knees & lower heels to 1st &
reverse **(2X)**

2-) Demi and Grand Pliés in 1st, 2nd Position (first form). Music can be repeated for 3rd or 5th position – both sides). *NOTE: Always deepen on the “and” before straightening from the demi-plié. This is not evident in the video but is a good practice for beginners.*

Begin facing the barre in 1st position

1, 2 deepen 3 4: 5 - 8
1 demi-plié & straighten; hold “isometric squeeze-lift”

1, 2 deepen 3, 4 ; 5 6 & 7 8
1 demi-plié & straighten; relevé hold and lower heels

2 grand pliés in 8 counts each; tendu to 2nd position & **Repeat ALL in 2nd position**

Counts for Grand pliés (REMINDER don’t touch thighs with calves in 1st, 3rd, or 5th!):

COUNTS FOR GRAND PLIÉ:

2 counts to demi;

1 count to grand;

1 count back to demi

2 counts to straighten

2 counts to HOLD (or, on 2nd one, to change position)

3-) Demi and Grand Pliés in 3rd or 5th Position (2nd form) w/ Cambrés front, back & side

Begin facing the barre in 3rd or 5th position

1 2 & 3 4 ; 5 6 & 7 8

1 demi & straighten; relevé & lower

1 grand plié in 8 counts & tendu LEFT side to repeat with left foot front

Tendu side & close to 1st position

1 2 & 3 4 and 5 6 & 7 8

Cambré front & return; turn head to right & cambré back & return

Repeat cambrés front and back turning head to left.

Bring left arm up to 3rd and cambré side to the right (4 counts) and return (4 counts); repeat to other side.

4-) Battement tendu & tendu jeté (1st FORM) w/ demi-plié in 1st and passé par terre ending with cambrés back

Begin facing the barre in 1st position

1 - 4 & 5 - 8 ; 1 2 & 3 4 & 5 6 and 7 8

1 Tendu side & close to 1st; 1 tendu side & close 1st & demi-plié and straighten

>>> REPEAT THIS FRONT and BACK ONLY

Out on 1 hold 2 & 3 4; and 5 hold 6 & 7 8

THEN: 2 passé par terre (tendu front & close 1st; tendu back & close 1st) 2X (w/head)

1 2,3 4 ; 5 - 8

Repeat ALL same foot in battement tendu jeté: tendu, lift, tendu; close

1 2 3 4 5 6 & 7 8

Tendu, lift, tendu close; demi-plié & straighten

Passé par terre in jeté: jeté on “and” hold 2 tendu 3 close 4 etc.

****End 16 counts: hold last tendu** back, turn head in direction of extended leg

1 - 4 & 5 - 8 ; etc

cambré back; & come up; turn head the other way and cambré back again come up; close to 1st.

Repeat music to repeat for other side

5-) Battement tendu and battement tendu jeté (2nd form) in 5th and with relevé in 1st

Begin facing the barre in 5th position Right foot front
(Heels hit on “and”)

>>>Tendu is in 2 counts

and 1 & 2 and 3 & 4 ; and 5 & 6
Tendu side & close front; tendu side & close back; tendu side & close front;
7 & 8
demi-plié & straighten.

>>>Jeté is in 4 counts

REPEAT SIDE in tendu jeté (2X) “and” is degage to 45° hold 2; tendu 3; “and” is hit
heels & close count 4.

THEN: do 2 tendu in 2 counts each and 2 tendu jeté in 4 counts each. 1X en croix
and close last one to 1st position.

END variation: 1 tendu jeté extending to relevé in 4 counts each 1X en croix

6-) Passé par terre, demi-rond de jamb, rond de jamb par terre and demi-grand and grand rond de jamb at 45°

Begin in 1st position

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
Tendu front & close 1st & tendu back & close 1st THEN:

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
Tendu front, trace to side & close to 1st; tendu side, trace to back and close to 1st (rep.
from beginning 1X)

Then: 1 rond de jamb par terre en dehors in 8 counts each

Then: 2 rond de jamb en dehors in 4 counts each

Then: 1 rond per terre in demi-plié en dehors 2 counts each direction & HOLD 2 counts
back and reverse to en dedans

Then: 1 demi-grand rond at 45° (closing to 5th demi-plié from side on count 4) in 8
counts closing to 1st

Then: 2 grand rond at 45 in 8 counts each

**** Immediately repeat all en dedans**

Repeat music to repeat exercise to the left

7-) Fondu par terre & en l'air in 1st & 2nd form*

Begin in 1st and préparation tendu to the side

4 fondu par terre in **4 counts** each to: **SIDE as follows:**

1st form: bring working foot to cou de pieds front & demi-plié **1,2** straighten **3,4**

THEN repeat in 2nd form w/ tendu working foot toe to the floor on **count 3** & straighten **count 4**

Repeat this to relevé & extend en l'air

>>>THEN: repeat all the above in cou de pied back

THEN DO 1X en croix as follows:

1 fondu par terre and **1** fondu en l'air en flat in **4 counts** each

Repeat music to repeat all to left side

***CORRECTION – as the working foot touches the floor in the Preliminary Form, it should be much closer to the supporting leg foot. As both legs straighten, the working foot continues to slide along the floor to the fully extended tendu position.**

8-) Wrapping exercise, Frappé toe to the floor and at 25°

Begin in 5th, right foot front and préparation tendu side & flex foot to ankle for wrapping exercises:

1 2 & 3 4; 5 6 & 7 8

Wrap & flex; wrap (**4X total**)

THEN: Wrap foot on first 2 counts

4 single frappés in **4 counts** each **TO THE SIDE** first 2 wrapped, last 2 cou de pied back (**2** toe to the floor and **2** at **25°**)

THEN: repeat ONE EACH: FRONT, SIDE, BACK, SIDE tendu & close 5th front

Repeat music for other side

9-) Rond de jamb en l'air and petit battement sur le cou de pieds

Begin in 1st and préparati^on tendu then relevé lent 45° to side

7 rond en l'air **en dehors** in **2 slow counts** each then pointe tendu to the floor (on count 15) and raise again to side (on count 16) continue with 7 rond de jamb en l'air **en dedans** in **2 counts each** THEN....

Last **count 15** tendu & **count 16** cou de pieds wrapped to continue:

Then: 4 petit bat. in **4 quick counts each** and then 6 in **2 quick counts each**

On last **counts 7 & 8** go into relevé to continue

Then: **repeat all petit bat. en demi-pointe**

End tendu side lowering heel on **count 7** & close to 5th Front on **count 8**

Repeat music to repeat to other side

10-) Relevé Lent & Développé to 90° facing and with back to barre

Begin in 1st with back to barre for side and front

As follows: SIDE, SIDE, then FRONT, FRONT (in this exercise tendu is always on count 7)

1 2 3 4 5 & 6 7 8
Tendu side & relevé lent side to 90° HOLD; tendu side to floor & close 1st.

1 2 3 4 5 & 6 7 8
Passé & extend side to 90° & HOLD tendu side to floor and close 1st.

Repeat all beginning to back and repeat all with the left leg

Repeat music and repeat all facing the barre to side again and back

11-) Grand battement, and Grand battement jeté pointé in 1st position

"And" is the apex

It's in $\frac{3}{4}$ (**so 6 counts** per each grand bat.)

Begin in 1st with back to barre for side and front

AS FOLLOWS: RIGHT SIDE, LEFT SIDE and RIGHT FRONT, LEFT FRONT

Lift on **"And"** tendu hold 1,2,3 close to 1st on 4, 5, 6

2 grand battements in **6 counts** each (Controlled landing though tendu before closing back to 1st)

And 1,2,3, and 4(tendu) close 5 6

2 grand battement jeté pointé in 6 counts each. End the last one in demi-plié (extra music for this no need to rush!)

As follows: right side, left side; (demi-plié) right front & left front (demi-plié)

Repeat music to repeat side and back facing the barre

12-) JUMPS AT BARRE: Temps Levé and Changement de pieds
4 COUNTS EACH – for demi plié and 2 counts for straightening

1 and a 2 & 3 4

Demi plié; jump/land deepen and straighten

3 each of temps levé in 1st, 2nd, 5th tendu to close to next position

4 jumps in 5th (RT foot front), 4 changement de pieds

13-) JUMPS AT THE BARRE: Échappé in 1st and 5th, Sissonne simple and Assemblé

This section 2 counts for demi-plié (except for Échappé in 4 counts)

1 Échappé in 1st in 8 counts each

1 2 and 3 4 and 5 6 & 7 8

Demi-plié; jump/land in demi-plié; deepen & jump/land hold & straighten

and 2 in 4 counts each

1 and 2 ; and a 3 4 & 5 - 8

Demi-plié jump/land; deepen; jump/land hold the demi-plié & repeat

repeat above Échappé in 5th

THEN: 2 Sissonne simple 1 c.d.p back and 1c.d.p front conditional
in 8 counts each as follows:

1 2 and 3 - 6 & 7 8

Demi-plié, jump/land HOLD & straighten/close 5th

THEN 2 assemblés to side only 2 closing front 8 counts each

As follows demi-plié & tendu side 1,2 assemblé and land demi-plié 3,4 straighten 5-8

14-) Demonstration of one hand on the barre with Port de Bras

Motivating breath (designated as “MB”) and “Préparation” **2 counts** per each movement:

1 2 ; 3 4 5 6 ; 7 8 & 1 2 & 3 - 8

MB-Open; back to prep; 1st; open 2nd & allongé hold & close back to prep; **look front** (2X)

THEN: 1X

1 2 & 3 4 & 5 6 & 7 8 1 2 3 4 ; 5 6

MB-Open & back to prep. & to 1st & up to 3rd stay with head tilt; lower back to 1st

& 7 8

& prep. **Head remains to side**

1 & 2 & 3 & 4 ; 5 6 & 7 8 & 1

MB-Open & back to Prep. & to 1st & out to 2nd; Cambré front & up to 3rd & Cambré

2 & 3 4 & 5 6 & 7 8

back & up & lower arm to 1st posit; open 2nd & Allongé close to prep **head remains to side**

Repeat music for other side

CENTER

VIEW OF “THE 8 POINTS OF THE STAGE” DIAGRAM

1-) 1st, 2nd, 3rd and 4th Port de Bras in croisé

IN **16 counts** each

2-) Demi and Grand Pliés in 1st, 2nd & 5th Position

1st and 2nd positions as follows:

1 Demi-plié in 4 counts (**2 counts** down and **2 counts** to straighten)

1 relevé in 4 counts (come down on count 4)

1 grand plié in **6 counts** and tendu to next position **2 counts**

5th position as follows:

2 demi-plié (with arms) 1 grand and tendu to point 2 repeat in 5th only

3- Battement tendu & battement tendu jeté with demi-plié in 5th and passé par terre 1X en croix

1 2 3 4 & 5 6 & 7 8

Tendu, flex, tendu close & demi - plié & straighten

2 tendu in **4 counts** each

2 jeté (first form in **4 counts**)

1 jeté in 2nd form in **4 counts** and demi-plié in **4 counts**

Last on side close 1st for passé par terre

Tag ending: passé par terre in tendu 1X and in jeté 2nd form 1X in 4 counts each as follows:

“and” 1 2, 3 & 4

Jeté, hold, tendu & close: repeat to back

4-) Fondu par terre and at 45° with rond de jamb par terre

Beginning en face (to Point 1) in 5th position

1 fondu par terre in **4 counts** (with arms)

1 fondu at 45° in **4 counts** front, side and back

2 rond en dehors in **4 counts** each close 5th back & repeat all en dedans

5-) Temps lié par terre: forwards and backwards without and with Bends of the body Beginning in 5th position croisé to point 8

8 counts per section

Then repeat forward (en avant) and backward (en arrière) with bends of the body

6-) Ballet port de bras preparation for on-ice exercise

(4 counts per “side”)

Begin in a “T- stop” position with right foot front and arms in preparatory

Use “motivating breath” during 4 counts of introduction music

1 2 3 4 “and a” arms lower for next stroke
Both arms to 1st; open to 2nd; Allongé & lower (2X looking RT then LT)

1 2 3 4 “and a”
Both arms to 1st (opening to 3rd & 2nd) Both arms to 2nd; Allongé & lower (2X looking first Rt. Then LT.)

1 2 and 3 4 “and a”
Both arms to 1st, to 3rd: Both arms open to 2nd; Allongé & lower (2X)

1 2 3 4
Both arms to 1st: one arms stays and the other goes to 3rd; both to 2nd; Allongé

“and a”

& lower – repeat this looking left

7-) Poses of the body & arabesques toe to the floor & at 45° (small pose & big pose) and attitudes at correct height

Beginning in 5th position croisé to point 8

8 counts per pose, one side only

- 6 - Poses of the body in tendu a la second tendu & lift to 45 tendu & close & repeat en avant (arms remain in 2nd for this)
- 4 - Arabesques – arms small pose for tendu to the floor and big pose for 45°
- 4 - Attitudes (4th one being attitude par terre) allongé to tendu to the floor & close 5th for the attitudes).
- 2 grand rond at 90° in 8 counts each (to show a la quatrième devant, a la second & a la quatrième derrière with arms... ending in 1st arabesque penché to show foot above head & close & repeat LEFT).

Repeat music to repeat all to other side

8-) Trampoline jumps with Échappé and Temps Levé in in 1st , 2nd and 5th

16 trampoline jumps in 1 count each 8 front & 2 each side going clockwise

THEN: 2 temps levé in each position 1st , 2nd & 5th in 1 count each with 5th going to croisé

THEN: 4 changement going from croisé to croisé in 2 count each

THEN: 2 Échappé in 4 counts each 1st and repeat 2 in 5th

END 2 sissonne simple 4 counts each, 1 front and 1 back
And 2 assemblés from tendu side coming forward 4 counts each

9-) Waltz adagio with balancés glissade en tournant

Begin in attitude par terre right foot back with hands on waist

4 balances de cote (means both right & left as one) in 2 counts of 3 each

THEN: 4 balances de cote en tournant in ¼ turns (wall to wall)

THEN: 4 balances with stylized arms side to side then 4 “up and down

THEN: tendu to point 2 in efface devant and do: 2 glissade en tournant to the right and close front & immediately repeat all to the left

10-) End of class stretch and strengthen exercise

1 2; 3 4 ; 5 6 & 7 8

Flex; turn out; point & turn in (2X)

1 - 4 & 5 - 8

Lift right leg & lower repeat LEFT

And 1 - 4

Repeat both and HOLD

**Port de bras back arch right & left- don't lower back down after each
(4 counts total)**

11-) "Révérence" in Hungarian Style

(Shown in the Instructional Video)

Beginning "Skates On" Ballet Lesson

A - Foot massage & Thera-band exercises

B - How to point your feet in skates

C- Preliminary foot exercise: Lie on back with legs together and straight up to ceiling (hands on waist): flex and point **10X** knees pulled up and seat tight.

Floor Exercises:

1-) Turn-out Exercise with leg rotations

Sit on mat and lean back on your elbows. Bend knees & turn out at the hip joints bringing your feet close to your body. Make sure torso is well supported (doesn't sag).

1 2 & 3 4

Bring right leg into attitude front; turn in & turn out; extend leg straight

and 5

to side as far as possible without twisting torso; flex foot & turn in strongly at the hip

6 and 7 & 8

socket & turn out; point foot; retiré & extend side again

THEN:

2 counts per rotation

Rotate in large circles **2** en dehors and **2** en dedans one time with a flexed foot and once w/ a pointed foot (always changing from point to flex on "and")

Bring leg back to original position and repeat all with the left leg

2-) "Criss-cross" (32 counts total)

Lie on your back with hands behind your head; right knee touching left elbow and left leg straight down to between 1' & 2' off the floor. Lower back should not be arched off of the floor and deep abs should be pressed toward the spine throughout the exercise.

Inhale fully on the "twist", exhale fully on the HOLD and alternate pointing and flexing the feet.

1 2 3 4 5 - 8

Reverse position & HOLD position & repeat to other side (**2 full twists –Lt. Rt;Lt. Rt in 8 counts each**) – Meaning 4 counts each position

Repeat: **2 full twists in 4 counts each** – Meaning - 2 counts each position and then **4 full twists in 2 count each** Meaning - 1 count each position.

END: both knees to chest to relax back

3-) Full stretch-up and twist (64 counts total)

Lie on back **with left leg bent to the side on the floor** and right leg straight up at an angle of 45° turned out & foot strongly pointed; arms straight to front & parallel to the raised leg

And 1

Lengthen & lift torso without moving either leg so that the whole torso is off floor

2 3 and
in a sitting position and HOLD w/ arms in 3rd then open arms out to 2nd & lengthen

4
lowering torso back down to the floor (without moving either leg) **repeat 3X**

and change 4 counts to repeat with other leg

THEN: Repeat with right leg again (bent leg is now in parallel – skate is FLAT on floor and knees touching) as follows (2X each leg)

1 2 3
Stretch up w/ arms in 3rd & HOLD; twist the upper body to the right opening arms to 2nd;

4 5
come back to center lifting arms to 3rd. twist to left & open arms out to 2nd; come back

6 7 and
to center with arms in 3rd; opening the arms to 2nd lengthen torso and lower in a

8
controlled manner to floor (**2X**) **Immediately repeat with other leg extended. End with Back Relaxer (& stand a few moments if necessary)**

** Try to keep your torso lifted, shoulders down and knees together. Turn out extended leg within the hip socket and point the foot hard throughout the entire exercise*

4-) On Side with Développé with Leg Rotations (64 counts total)

Lie on side with upper hand on floor in front of you with elbow bent and other hand supporting your head; legs are slightly bent to the back and together

1 2 3 and 4
Retiré & extend side as high as possible (up toward the ceiling) flex and point
5 6
Flex again & lower leg out in front of you to about 6 inches off the floor; pressing
7 and 8
the floor leg into the floor for leverage lift the top leg to the ceiling again and point

THEN:

1 , and 2 3 and 4
Retiré, flex and push heel to ceiling to straighten leg & pointe; retiré again,
5 6
attitude leg to the back & straighten (stretch same arm as leg forward to counter-
7 8
balance) **attitude again & arch to look back (as in a 'catch foot')**
and 8
Put hand back on floor and rond leg to side again extend to ceiling.

In 4 counts each rotate leg 2X en dedans (down to floor, around and up to ceiling, once with a pointed foot and once with a flexed foot; and 1X en dehors with a pointed foot and

Immediately switch side to repeat all with the other leg

5-) Reverse Crunch and spiral work

Begin on "all fours" and extend right leg back in turn-out

1 2 and 3 4
Crunch in touching head to knee and extend w/leg turned out on the extension

Do side extension and return (4X), place free hand on floor & do 'up and overs' w/ 2 knee drops & lift in attitude & extend (2X)

THEN: Head & working leg down to mat and do 4 grand battements (**in 2 counts each**)

Count 8 1 2 - 8
to the back HOLD last one Head up & torso arched go to attitude back & extend HOLD
& end with child pose

Repeat Music to repeat all to other side

STAND AND SHAKE OUT LEGS WHEN DONE

6-) Scissors (changement de pieds) with flex and point

Begin on back with both legs up to ceiling in turn-out with feet strongly pointed and hands on waist. **Relax neck and shoulders throughout the exercise...keep the tension in the core and inner thighs. Concentrate the crossing of the legs at mid-thigh.**

Criss-cross the legs **3X** opening the legs to a small "V" and crossing the legs on the beat. Open the legs to the widest "V" possible on "**and**" THEN: FLEX FEET on **count 4** and repeat, alternating flex and point every 4 counts (**4X**)

THEN: 4 counts straight of changement no stops **4 in flex** and **4 in point (4X total)**

ENDING: place both feet on floor and roll up torso (lift hips as high off the floor as possible) **4 counts** and lower **4 counts and repeat.**

**Tighten gluteals throughout to maintain turn-out and keep deep abs strongly engaged (navel to spine)*

Barre Exercise with both skates on

1-) Demi-plié and relevé facing the barre (122 counts total)

Face the barre in 6th position with both skates & guards on.

1 2 3 4 5 - 7 8
(A) Demi-plié & straighten & relevé HOLD & lower (**2X**)

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
(B) Demi-plié & straighten; relevé & hold; demi-plié in relevé & straighten & lower (**2X**)

Repeat with legs in small 2nd parallel (slightly inside of hip width, knees MUST stay parallel to toes during all pliés!!!)

THEN: Repeat (A) and (B) 1X each with free leg in:

Cou de pieds back; then

Extended to side at 45°; then

Extended to back at 45°

Repeat with other leg

*****Hips should be square to the barre at all times with working leg well turned out at the hip and foot strongly pointed. Supporting leg still in parallel but the glutes are strongly engaged with knees over toes. Lift out of hips!**

>>>>Take the left skate off to continue The Lesson<<<<
Barre Exercises with one skate on**

2- Dégagé to 45° with flex and point with one hand on barre

Préparation: Standard, arms remain in 2nd

Both legs well turned out beginning in “3rd “ (front knee is bent)

1 2 3 4 and 5
Dégagé leg front to 45°; flex, turn in; turn out; point; Demi-plié sup. Leg (lift
6 7 8
skate leg slightly) & carry leg to side*; Straighten supporting leg & lower to floor

Continue 1X en croix working leg ending in original pose (3rd with front knee bent)

Be strongly aware of whole-body alignment as this is not just about the free leg. When mastery over whole body alignment has been achieved at 45° then practice at 90°.

3- Développé and relevé lent to 45° and 90° with demi-grand rond de jamb

Begin with back to the barre in strong turnout in “3rd” (front knee is bent)

1, 2 3 4 5 6 7 & 8
Practice to side: Retiré; turn in; turn out & attitude, extend SIDE & lower

THEN:

1 - 2 3 4 5 & 6
Relevé lent side to 45° & carry FRONT & HOLD (Flex & pointe)
7, 8

Lower to tendu front. Repeat above to the FRONT ending tendu side & quickly turning to FACE BARRE to

REPEAT ALL to SIDE and BACK

** The above exercise can be adapted for centre work for more advanced students.

4- ONE HAND ON BARRE Développé and demi-grand rond and grand rond de jamb at 90° with pieds dans la mains (only for more advanced students)

Préparation: Standard

Begin Well turned out in 3rd

1 2 and 3
Retiré front in demi-plié & HOLD; Straighten & grand rond de jamb en dehors at
4 5 6 7 8
90°; demi-plié supporting leg & raising extended leg; straighten & lower to floor.
Repeat en dedans

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
Do “Pieds dans la main” front & HOLD and SLOWLY lower to tendu front

1 - 8 1 - 8 and
Repeat side; then hold knee & extend back to penché & come up (still in arabesque)

1 - 8

1 - 8

Face barre and do penché again with skate foot coming out of top of head (directly above head as viewed from front) come up & go into attitude & hold w/head back.

END: tendu side & Cambré side and other side to relax

Make certain that all alignment is accurate and that you are not leaning away from the free leg. When 45° becomes easy try the exercise at 90° keeping torso vertical.

**** THE ABOVE EXERCISE WILL BE HARD ON THE HIP FLEXORS IF YOU DO NOT FULLY & CONTINUALLY ENGAGE YOUR GLUTES TO HOLD TURN-OUT**

»Take right skate off and put left skate on to repeat all exercises beginning with barre exercise #2

5-) ENDING RELAXER/STRETCH FOR SKATES ON CLASS:

On back with legs up straight to ceiling and slightly open do:

In 1 count each

8 ankle rotations outward

8 ankle rotations inward

THEN:

Pinwheel pose right leg front: bend forward 2 counts & come up 2 counts backward 2 counts & come up 2 counts

Bend side (toward the front leg) 4 counts & other side 2 counts

Change legs and repeat all 4 bends

Go into straddle with arms in 2nd and do:

Flex feet and bend knees 2 counts & straighten & point 2 counts (2X)

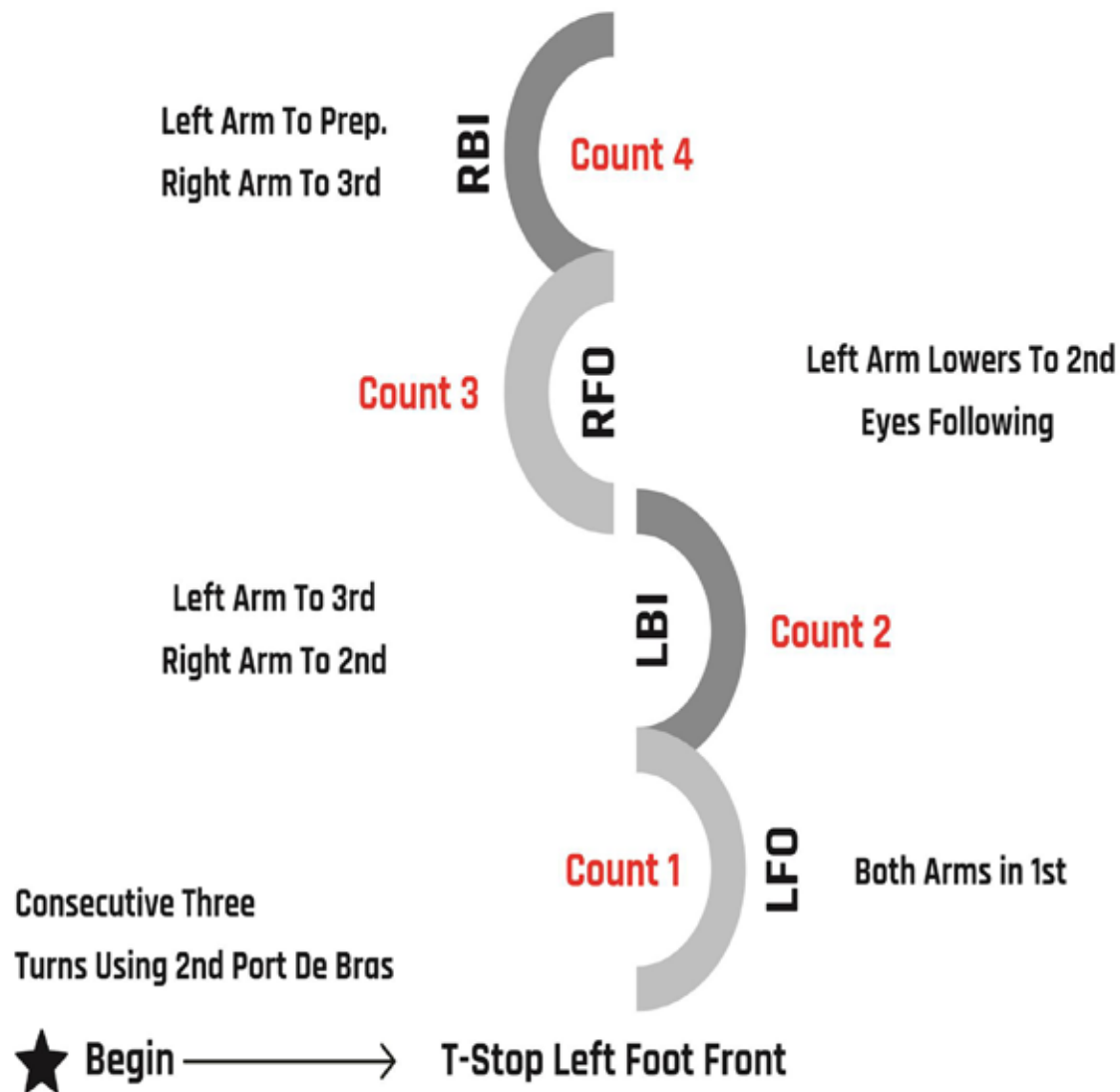
End: feet together and knees bent out to sides curl forward head to feet and elbows on thighs just above knees.

Example of Correlative Chart

Vaganova Floor Exercises	Ballet Exercise (Barre and Centre)	Skates on Lessons	On-ice Applications
#2 Flex and point – foot, ankle and lower leg strength/flexibility, correct trajectory of foot to lower leg line	Plies, tendu, frappe, extensions/leg and foot line, jumps	Flex and point, feeling the foot in the boot,	All foot work, deeper edges, stronger stroking more fluid jumps and softer landings. Better lower leg to foot line, “point”

Diagram #1 Consecutive Three Turns Using 2nd Port de Bras

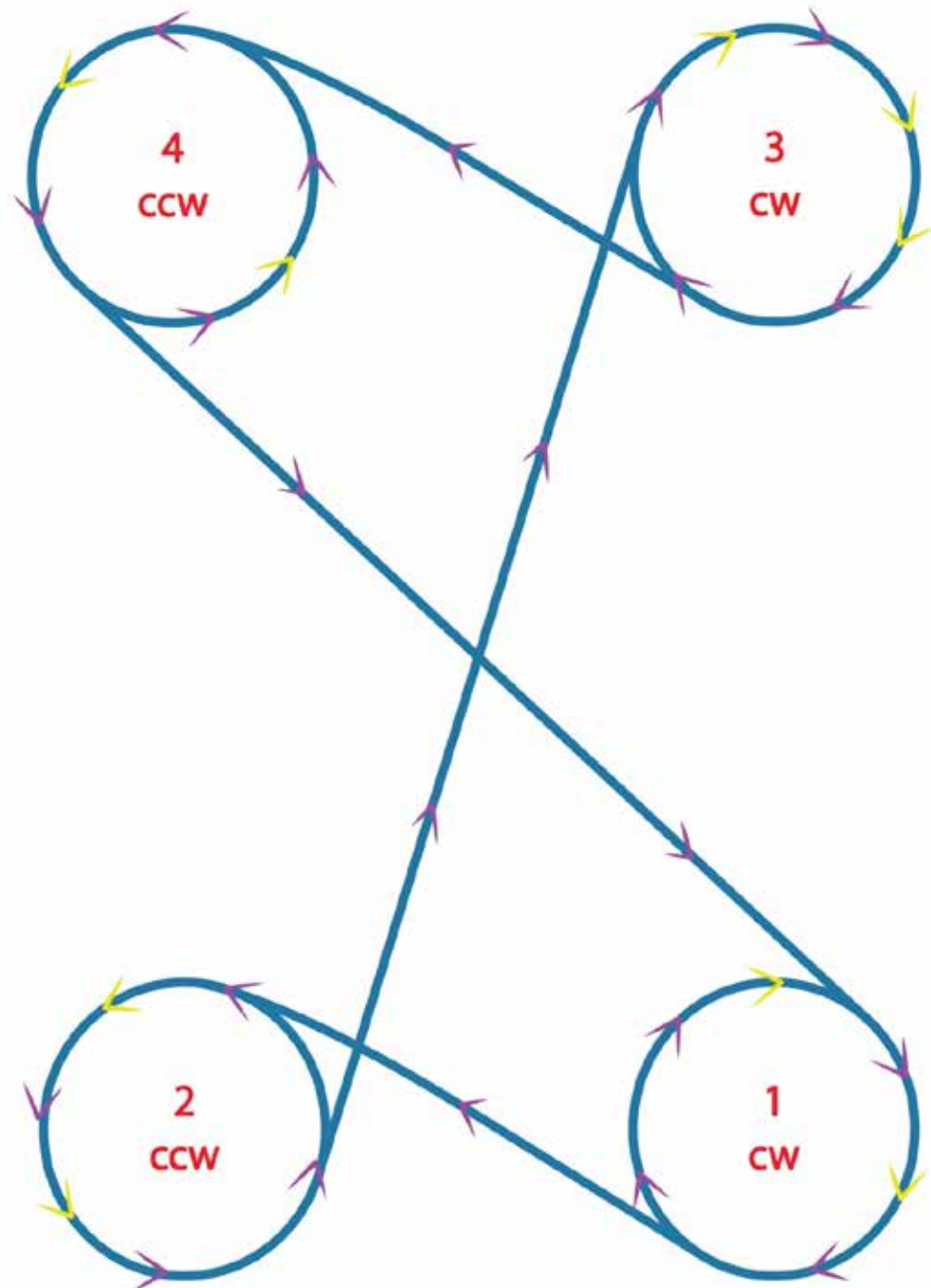
AND CONTINUE FROM BEGINNING



EYE AND HEAD FOCUS:

- Counts 1 and 2 look to the right
- Counts 3 and 4 look to the left

Diagram #2 Continuous of Flow of Port de Bras



 BEGIN EACH
PATTERN HERE.

"For those who have wanted to take my "Ballet for Figure Skaters 16-Week Coaches Course" and just haven't found the time to do so, this expanded volume provides all the lessons taught in this course to do at your own pace. This manual can be used on its own, but is meant to accompany my two other books: ***Fundamentals of Alignment and Classical Movement for Figure Skaters*** and ***Lessons in Classical Ballet for the Figure Skaters***, as well as my instructional video—all available here: <https://www.balletforfigureskaters.com/books> and the music album "Ballet Class Music for Figure Skaters" available here: <https://whitefeatherproductions.com/>



ANNETTE T. THOMAS has been a dance teacher and choreographer since 1970. Trained at Carnegie Hall by the late Maria Nevelska of the Bolshoi Ballet and Alexandra Danilova of the ballet Russes. Annette has lectured and published numerous freelance articles on dance, injury prevention, imagery, and creative movement and has worked extensively with both handicapped and gifted children in the areas of creativity, art and movement. She received her Certificate of Completion of the First Class Pedagogical Course for the Study of Classical Ballet in 2005 from Dr. Peggy Willis-Aarnio and again in 2023 with Janet Springer of Classical Dance alliance. Ms. Springer worked extensively with John Barker for 30 years on Vaganova Pedagogy and Methodology. Mr. Barker was

the very first American given the privilege of learning from the great Vera Kostrovitskaya. Annette also works collaboratively with Inna Stabrova of the Ohio Conservatory of Ballet in teaching online teacher training courses in Level 0 and Level 1 of the Vaganova Method. She is a former member of the Professional Skaters Association, the United States Figure Skating Association, the International Association for Dance Medicine and Science, and the Wisconsin Dance Council. Annette, who is now semi-retired, lives in Florida with her husband and teaches private online courses for adult skaters, coaches and ballet teachers worldwide.

MADELINE LYDIA STAMMEN is an experienced professional figure skater and performing artist. She is a USFSA triple gold medalist and has performed in over 30 countries worldwide. Since 2012 she has skated as a lead for companies like Royal Caribbean International and created one of the original main characters of Cirque Du Soleil's first show on ice, "Crystal." She now coaches all levels in the Chicagoland area and in Savannah, Georgia.



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